Python — Capstone Projects

How to use this book

A **capstone** is a project big enough to force you to combine many topics at once: data structures, files, classes, typing, testing, concurrency and packaging. Reading chapters teaches you the pieces; a capstone teaches you how the pieces fit, where they rub against each other, and what you do when the textbook answer is not enough. Each of the 40 briefs below describes **what to build and why** — the problem, the requirements, an architecture, the data model, the hard parts and how to test it. It does **not** give you the code. You write the code. That is the point.

How to pick one. Start from the project map below. If you have finished Chapters 1–9, any Beginner project is in reach. Intermediate projects assume Chapters 10–16 (classes, generators, decorators, type hints, the standard library, testing and asyncio). Advanced projects assume you are comfortable with all of that and are ready to read CPython documentation, PEPs and the source of real libraries. Pick something you would actually use: a todo CLI you run every day will teach you more than an impressive project you abandon. If you are preparing for interviews, pick one project from each level and be able to talk through its design for ten minutes.

How to use a brief.

1. Read the whole brief once, including the deep dive and trade-offs, so you know where the traps are before you start.
2. Build the **milestones in order**. Each has a "done when" check: do not move on until it passes. A working small version beats a half-working big one.
3. Write the tests described in the testing strategy as you go, not at the end.
4. Only then attempt the **stretch goals**. They are where most of the learning about scale and polish happens.
5. Finally, answer the **In the interview** questions out loud without looking at the answers, and do the self-check where there is one.

Versions. Every brief targets **Python 3.14** (released October 2025), and most projects run on 3.12+. Where a brief uses a 3.14 feature it says so and names the PEP: template strings (t-strings, PEP 750), deferred evaluation of annotations and the `annotationlib` module (PEP 649 and PEP 749), the officially supported but still optional free-threaded build (PEP 779), the `concurrent.interpreters` module for multiple interpreters (PEP 734), the `compression.zstd` module for Zstandard compression (PEP 784), plus smaller additions such as `Path.copy()` / `Path.move()`, `uuid.uuid7()`, `python -m pdb -p PID` remote attach (PEP 768) and `asyncio` task introspection. Third-party libraries are named without version numbers — use their current release.

Colour code (in the PDF). Section headings are coloured by role so you can scan a page: green for **What it is**, coral for **The problem it solves** and **Requirements**, violet for **Real-world examples**, blue for **The architecture** and the **Deep dive**, amber for **Trade-offs**, pink for **In the interview**, teal for **Self-check** and a yellow box for **TL;DR**.

Level legend.

Level	You should know	Typical size
Beginner	Ch 1–9: syntax, collections, functions, files, exceptions	200–600 lines, 1–2 weekends
Intermediate	Ch 10–16: classes, generators, decorators, typing, stdlib, pytest, asyncio	600–2,000 lines, 1–3 weeks
Advanced	Everything, plus reading PEPs and library source	2,000+ lines, 3–6 weeks

Real-world examples link to official documentation, PEPs, papers and open-source projects so you can

compare your design with a production one. Treat them as reading, not as code to copy.

Project map

#	Project	Level	Time	Prerequisites (chapters)
1	Todo list CLI with argparse and JSON	Beginner	1 weekend	Ch 3, 6, 9, 14
2	File organiser	Beginner	1 weekend	Ch 3, 9, 14
3	Password and passphrase generator	Beginner	1 weekend	Ch 4, 7, 14
4	CSV expense report	Beginner	1 weekend	Ch 5, 6, 9, 14
5	Web server log analyser	Beginner	1–2 weekends	Ch 4, 6, 11
6	Flashcards with spaced repetition	Beginner	1–2 weekends	Ch 6, 9, 10
7	Duplicate file finder	Beginner	1 weekend	Ch 6, 9, 11
8	Weather CLI with a response cache	Beginner	1 weekend	Ch 9, 14
9	Habit tracker on SQLite	Beginner	1–2 weekends	Ch 9, 10, 14
10	Incremental backup tool with zstd	Beginner	2 weekends	Ch 9, 14, 17
11	Async web scraper with httpx	Intermediate	2 weeks	Ch 9, 11, 16
12	REST API with FastAPI and PostgreSQL	Intermediate	2–3 weeks	Ch 10, 13, 15, 16
13	Markdown static site generator	Intermediate	2 weeks	Ch 4, 9, 11, 14
14	Plugin system with entry points	Intermediate	1–2 weeks	Ch 8, 10, 13
15	Typed configuration loader	Intermediate	1–2 weeks	Ch 10, 12, 13
16	Publish a library to PyPI with uv	Intermediate	1 week	Ch 8, 13, 15
17	Resilient HTTP client library	Intermediate	1–2 weeks	Ch 7, 12, 16
18	Async chat server	Intermediate	2 weeks	Ch 9, 16
19	Safe templating with t-strings	Intermediate	1–2 weeks	Ch 4, 10, 13
20	Structured logging library	Intermediate	1–2 weeks	Ch 12, 14
21	Mini Git	Intermediate	2–3 weeks	Ch 6, 9, 14
22	LRU and TTL caching library	Intermediate	1–2 weeks	Ch 6, 7, 12, 16
23	Full-text search engine	Intermediate	2–3 weeks	Ch 4, 6, 11, 17
24	Webhook receiver and event dispatcher	Intermediate	2 weeks	Ch 12, 14, 16
25	Database schema migration tool	Intermediate	2 weeks	Ch 8, 9, 14
26	Async job queue on PostgreSQL	Advanced	3–4 weeks	Ch 9, 15, 16
27	Mini ORM with descriptors and metaclasses	Advanced	3 weeks	Ch 10, 12, 13
28	Interpreter for a small language	Advanced	4–6 weeks	Ch 3, 10, 19
29	Sampling and tracing profiler	Advanced	3 weeks	Ch 16, 17
30	Free-threaded parallel pipeline	Advanced	2–3 weeks	Ch 16, 17
31	Data pipeline with pandas and polars	Advanced	3 weeks	Ch 13, 15, 18
32	Distributed task runner	Advanced	4–6 weeks	Ch 9, 16, 17
33	LSP-style linter with ast	Advanced	3–4 weeks	Ch 12, 13, 14

#	Project	Level	Time	Prerequisites (chapters)
34	A testing framework	Advanced	3–4 weeks	Ch 8, 12, 15
35	Plugin host on subinterpreters	Advanced	3 weeks	Ch 8, 16
36	Log-structured key-value store	Advanced	4 weeks	Ch 6, 9, 17
37	Debugger on sys.monitoring	Advanced	3–4 weeks	Ch 12, 15, 17
38	ASGI web framework from scratch	Advanced	3–4 weeks	Ch 12, 13, 16
39	Collaborative editor backend with CRDTs	Advanced	4–6 weeks	Ch 16, 19
40	Vector similarity search engine	Advanced	4 weeks	Ch 17, 18, 19

1. Todo list CLI with argparse and JSON

Level: Beginner · **Time:** 1 weekend · **Prerequisites:** Ch 3, Ch 6, Ch 9, Ch 14

What it is

A command-line program, `todo`, that lets you add, list, complete, edit and delete tasks from the terminal: `todo add "Buy milk" --due 2026-10-03 --tag home`, `todo list --tag home`, `todo done 4`. Tasks are stored in a single JSON file in your home directory. A **CLI** (command-line interface) is a program you drive by typing commands and flags instead of clicking buttons, and **JSON** (JavaScript Object Notation) is a plain-text format for nested lists and dictionaries that Python reads and writes with the `json` module.

The problem it solves

Most people keep tasks in their head, on sticky notes or in a heavy app. Developers live in the terminal, so a tool that is one command away and stores data in a readable file they can back up or put under version control is genuinely useful. For you as a learner, it is the smallest project that exercises the full loop of a real program: parse input, validate it, load state, change it, save it safely and print a clear result.

Real-world examples

- Taskwarrior is a mature terminal task manager with tags, due dates, priorities, filters and reports — a good model for which features matter once you use the tool every day.
- The `argparse` documentation shows sub-commands (`add_subparsers`), which is exactly how `git commit` / `git push` style CLIs are built. In 3.14, `argparse` prints coloured help by default and can suggest the closest valid choice when the user mistypes (`suggest_on_error=True`).

Requirements

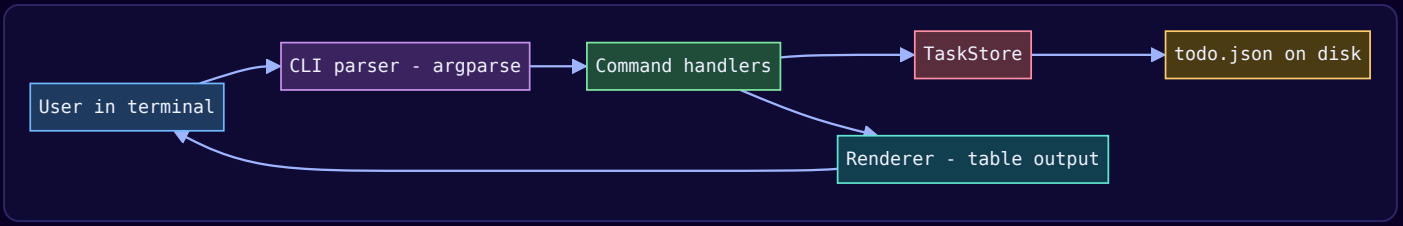
Functional

- Sub-commands: `add`, `list`, `done`, `undo`, `edit`, `rm`, `clear-done`.
- Each task has an id, title, optional due date, tags, priority (low/normal/high), created and completed timestamps.
- `list` filters by tag, status and "overdue", and sorts by due date then priority.
- Clear error messages and a non-zero exit code on bad input (`todo done 999` → "no task 999", exit code 1).

Non-functional

- Start-up and any command complete in under 100 ms for 10,000 tasks.
- The data file is never left half-written, even if the program is killed mid-save.
- Zero third-party dependencies, so it runs anywhere Python 3.12+ runs.

The architecture



- **CLI parser** turns `sys.argv` into a `Namespace` with the chosen sub-command and its options. It knows nothing about tasks.
- **Command handlers** are plain functions, one per sub-command (`cmd_add(store, args)`), holding the business rules: ids are unique, due dates are parsed, completed tasks cannot be completed twice.
- **TaskStore** loads and saves the JSON file and hands out `Task` objects. Swapping JSON for SQLite later should only touch this box.
- **Renderer** formats tasks into aligned columns with f-string format specs, so output logic stays out of the handlers.

Data model

Field	Type	Notes
`id`	`int`	Monotonic, never reused (store `next_id` in the file)
`title`	`str`	Non-empty, stripped
`due`	`date | None`	Stored as ISO 8601 text `"2026-10-03"`
`tags`	`list[str]`	Lower-cased, de-duplicated
`priority`	`str`	`"low"`, `"normal"`, `"high"`
`created_at`, `done_at`	`datetime`, `datetime | None`	Stored as ISO text with timezone

The file is `{"version": 1, "next_id": 42, "tasks": [...]}`. The `version` key lets a future release migrate old files.

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Argument parsing	`argparse`	Standard library, sub-commands, generated help
Storage	`json` + `pathlib`	Human-readable, diff-able, no install
Dates	`datetime`	ISO parsing with `date.fromisoformat`
Tests	pytest + `tmp_path`	Each test gets its own throwaway data file

Milestones

1. **Parse and echo.** Build the parser with all sub-commands and print the parsed namespace. *Done when* `todo --help` and `todo add --help` show every option.
2. **Add and list.** Implement `Task`, `TaskStore.load/save` and the `add` / `list` handlers. *Done when* added tasks survive a restart.
3. **Change state.** `done`, `undo`, `edit`, `rm`, with proper errors for unknown ids. *Done when* each bad input prints one clear line and exits with status 1.
4. **Filters and sorting.** Tags, overdue, priority ordering. *Done when* `todo list --overdue` shows only past-due open tasks, earliest first.
5. **Safe saves.** Atomic write and a file lock or "last writer wins" note. *Done when* killing the process during a save never corrupts the file.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Atomic saves.** Writing directly over `todo.json` and crashing halfway leaves a truncated, unparseable file. Instead write to `todo.json.tmp` in the same directory, call `flush()` and `os.fsync()`, then `os.replace(tmp, real)`. `os.replace` is atomic on POSIX and Windows when both paths are on the same filesystem: readers see either the old file or the new one, never a mix.
- **Dates and time zones.** A due date is a calendar day, so store a `date`, not a `datetime`. Timestamps like `created_at` should be timezone-aware (`datetime.now(UTC)`) so sorting stays correct if you travel. JSON has no date type, so convert to and from ISO strings at the store boundary and nowhere else.
- **Stable ids.** If ids are list positions, deleting task 2 renames task 3. Keep a `next_id` counter in the file so ids are permanent, the way a database sequence works.

Testing strategy

Unit-test handlers with an in-memory store, and test `TaskStore` with pytest's `tmp_path` fixture. Test the parser by calling `parser.parse_args([...])` with lists of strings. Add an end-to-end test that runs `main(["add", "x"])` and asserts on captured output (`capsys`). Write one test that simulates a crash: monkeypatch `os.replace` to raise and check the old file is intact.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Loading and rewriting the whole file on every command is O(n), which is fine up to tens of thousands of tasks. Two terminals running `todo` at once can lose an update (both read, both write); a lock file or moving to SQLite (Project 9) fixes that. JSON is readable but slow to parse at very large sizes and cannot express dates natively.

Stretch goals

- Recurring tasks (`--every week`) and natural dates (`--due friday`).
- Shell completion and a `todo export --csv` command.
- A `--json` output flag so other scripts can consume the list.

Skills practised

- Ch 3 — Control flow: `match` on the sub-command.
- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: tags as sets, lookup by id.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: custom exceptions, `pathlib`, JSON, atomic writes.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `argparse`, `datetime`.

In the interview

Q: How do you make sure a crash never corrupts the data file? **A:** Write to a temporary file in the same directory, fsync it, then `os.replace` it over the original. The rename is atomic, so readers see the old or the new file, never half of one.

Q: Why not use the list index as the task id? **A:** Indices shift when items are deleted, so a user's `todo done 3` could hit the wrong task. A persisted counter gives stable ids.

Q: Where would you change the code to switch from JSON to SQLite? **A:** Only in `TaskStore`. Handlers depend on its methods, not on the file format, so the rest of the program is unaffected.

TL;DR

A small, dependency-free CLI that teaches the full program loop: parse arguments, validate, load, mutate and atomically save state, with storage hidden behind one class.

2. File organiser

Level: Beginner · **Time:** 1 weekend · **Prerequisites:** Ch 3, Ch 9, Ch 14

What it is

A tool that tidies a messy folder such as `~/Downloads` by moving files into sub-folders according to rules: images to `Pictures/2026-10/`, PDFs to `Documents/`, installers older than 30 days to the trash. Rules live in a small TOML file, and every run can be previewed with `--dry-run` and reversed with `undo`. **TOML** is a simple configuration format (`key = "value"` plus `[sections]`) that Python reads with the built-in `tomllib` module.

The problem it solves

Download folders grow to thousands of files and nobody sorts them by hand. A script that does it on demand, or every night, saves real time. The learning value is in doing destructive file operations **safely**: never losing a file, handling name clashes, and being able to explain and undo what happened.

Real-world examples

- organize is an open-source Python file-management automation tool driven by a rules file with filters and actions — the same idea, much further developed.
- The `pathlib` documentation covers the 3.14 additions `Path.copy()`, `Path.copy_into()`, `Path.move()` and `Path.move_into()`, which replace many uses of `shutil` for this kind of tool.

Requirements

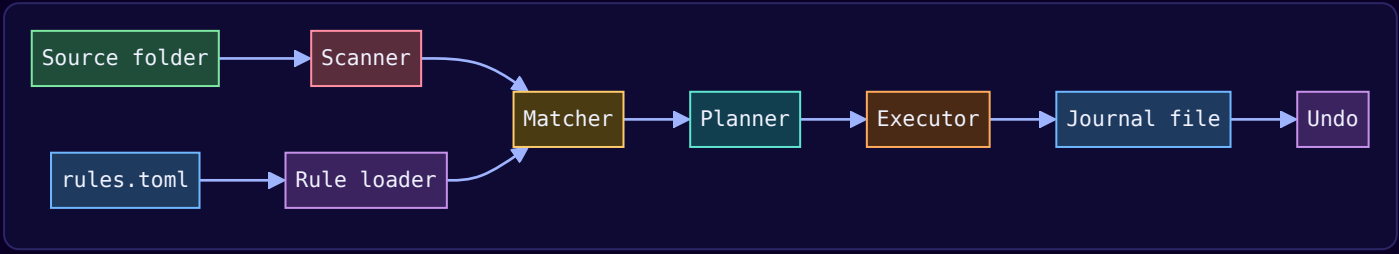
Functional

- Rules match on extension, name pattern (glob), size and age, and choose a destination template like `Pictures/{year}-{month:02}`.
- First matching rule wins. Unmatched files stay put.
- `--dry-run` prints the plan without touching anything. Every real run writes a journal used by `undo`.
- Name clashes are resolved by adding `(1)`, `(2)` instead of overwriting.

Non-functional

- Handle a folder of 50,000 files in under 10 seconds on an SSD.
- Never overwrite or delete a file without a journal entry.
- Works on Linux, macOS and Windows.

The architecture



- **Rule loader** parses TOML into a list of `Rule` objects and rejects bad rules early with a line-specific message.
- **Scanner** walks the folder with `Path.iterdir()` (or `Path.walk()` for recursion) and yields file info lazily.
- **Matcher** returns the first rule that matches a file.
- **Planner** turns matches into a list of `Move(src, dst)` operations and resolves clashes. Planning without acting is what makes `--dry-run` trivial.
- **Executor** performs the moves and appends each to the **journal**, a JSON Lines file (one JSON object per line).
- **Undo** reads the latest journal backwards and moves files back.

Data model

Type	Fields	Purpose
`Rule`	name, extensions, glob, min_age_days, max_size, dest_template	One line of policy
`FileInfo`	path, size, mtime, suffix	What the scanner saw
`Move`	src, dst, rule_name	One planned action
Journal line	run_id, src, dst, timestamp	What actually happened

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Paths and moves	`pathlib` (3.14 `Path.move`)	Object-oriented paths, cross-platform
Config	`tomllib`	Built in since 3.11, read-only and safe
Patterns	`fnmatch` / `Path.match`	Shell-style globs users already know
CLI	`argparse`	`run`, `plan`, `undo` sub-commands

Milestones

1. **Scan and print.** List every file with size, age and suffix. *Done when* the scan is lazy (a generator) and skips hidden files on request.
2. **Rules and dry run.** Load TOML rules and print the plan. *Done when* `--dry-run` output matches what a human expects for a sample folder.
3. **Execute with clashes.** Move files, creating folders as needed, renaming on clash. *Done when* two files named `a.pdf` both survive.
4. **Journal and undo.** *Done when* `undo` restores the folder exactly, verified by comparing a before/after listing in a test.
5. **Schedule.** Document a cron or Task Scheduler entry. *Done when* a nightly run works unattended and logs to a file.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Moves across filesystems.** A rename is instant and atomic on the same disk, but moving to another disk is really copy-then-delete. If it fails midway you can end up with two copies or a partial copy. `Path.move()` (and `shutil.move`) falls back to copy-and-delete automatically, so log before and after and verify the size of the copy.
- **Clash resolution races.** Checking `dst.exists()` and then moving is a classic **time-of-check to time-of-use** bug: another process can create the file in between. For a personal tool, plan clashes against the set of names already planned in this run *and* re-check right before each move. Treat a failed move as a logged skip, not a crash.
- **Templated destinations.** `"{year}-{month:02}"` uses `str.format` with values from the file's modification time. Validate templates at load time by formatting them against a dummy file, so a typo fails before any file moves.

Testing strategy

Use `tmp_path` to build fake folders with known files, set modification times with `os.utime`, run the planner and assert on the plan (pure, fast tests). Run the executor on the same folder, then `undo`, and compare directory listings. Parametrize rule-matching tests over many file names.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

First-match-wins is easy to explain but means rule order matters. A journal per run makes undo safe but grows forever, so rotate old journals. Watching the folder continuously (with the `watchfiles` package) gives instant sorting but adds a long-running process that must survive errors.

Stretch goals

- Sort photos by EXIF date taken instead of modification time.
- Detect duplicates before moving (see Project 7).
- A `--watch` mode that reacts to new files.

Skills practised

- Ch 3 — Control flow: rule matching loops.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: `pathlib`, handling `OSError`.
- Ch 11 — Iterators, generators and functional tools: lazy scanning.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `argparse`, `datetime`, `logging`.

In the interview

Q: Why separate planning from execution? **A:** The plan is pure data, so it is easy to test, to preview with `--dry-run` and to log. The executor becomes a thin loop with error handling.

Q: What happens when the move crosses disks? **A:** It becomes copy then delete, which is not atomic. You must handle partial failures and verify the copy before deleting the source.

Q: How does undo stay correct if the user moved files afterwards? **A:** Undo checks that each destination still exists and the source is free before moving back, and reports conflicts instead of guessing.

TL;DR

Rules in TOML drive a scan → plan → execute → journal pipeline, which makes destructive file moves previewable, safe on clashes and reversible.

3. Password and passphrase generator

Level: Beginner · **Time:** 1 weekend · **Prerequisites:** Ch 4, Ch 7, Ch 14

What it is

A CLI and small library that generates strong random passwords (`k#9Qv!r2...`), memorable passphrases (`correct-horse-battery-staple` style, from a word list), and PINs, and reports the **entropy** of each: a measure, in bits, of how many guesses an attacker needs. Each extra bit doubles the guesses.

The problem it solves

People reuse weak passwords because strong ones are hard to invent. A generator solves that, but only if it uses a **cryptographically secure** random source — one whose output cannot be predicted even by someone who has seen earlier outputs. The project teaches the difference between `random` (fast, predictable, fine for games and simulations) and `secrets` (unpredictable, meant for security), which is a common interview question.

Real-world examples

- The `secrets` module documentation explains why `random` must not be used for security and shows password recipes.
- NIST SP 800-63B is the US government's digital identity guideline. It favours length over forced complexity rules and recommends checking new passwords against lists of known-compromised ones.
- The EFF dice-generated passphrase page publishes word lists designed for passphrases, with words chosen to be easy to type and distinguish.

Requirements

Functional

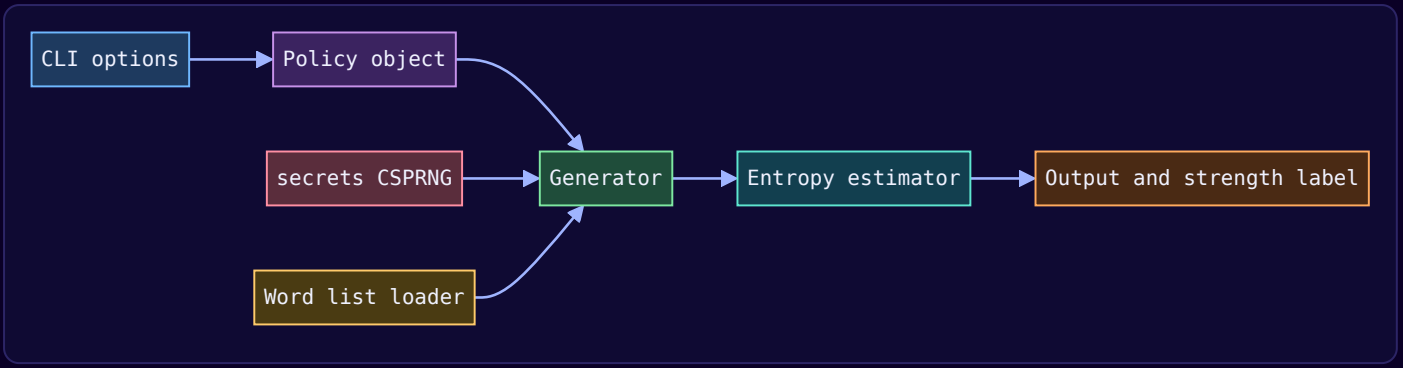
- Passwords: length, character classes (lower, upper, digits, symbols), "at least one of each class", exclude look-alikes (`0O1lI`).
- Passphrases: word count, separator, optional capitalisation and number, custom word list.
- Print entropy in bits and a plain-English strength label.

- `--count N` generates many at once. `--copy` puts one on the clipboard (optional dependency).

Non-functional

- Every random choice comes from `secrets`. A test enforces that `random` is never imported.
- Generate 10,000 passwords in under 1 second.
- Never write generated secrets to logs or disk.

The architecture



- **Policy** is a frozen dataclass describing what to generate. Validation (length at least 8, at least one class) lives here.
- **Generator** builds the alphabet from the policy and draws characters or words with `secrets.choice`.
- **Word list loader** reads and de-duplicates a list, rejecting lists that are too short to be useful.
- **Entropy estimator** computes bits from the alphabet size and length, which is accurate only because the output is truly random.

Data model

Type	Key fields	Notes
`PasswordPolicy`	length, use_lower, use_upper, use_digits, use_symbols, exclude_ambiguous, require_each	Frozen dataclass
`PassphrasePolicy`	words, separator, capitalize, add_number, wordlist_path	Frozen dataclass
`Result`	value, entropy_bits, label	Returned by every generator

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Randomness	`secrets.choice`, `secrets.randbelow`	OS-backed CSPRNG
Alphabets	`string.ascii_letters`, `string.digits`, `string.punctuation`	No hand-typed lists
Maths	`math.log2`	Entropy in bits
CLI	`argparse` with mutually exclusive groups	`password` vs `passphrase` modes

Milestones

1. **Basic password.** Fixed length from letters and digits. *Done when* 1,000 outputs are all distinct and the right length.
2. **Policies.** All character-class options and look-alike exclusion. *Done when* invalid policies raise a clear `ValueError`.
3. **Guarantee each class.** *Done when* every output contains each requested class, without biasing the result (see deep dive).
4. **Passphrases.** Word list loading and options. *Done when* a 6-word passphrase from a 7,776-word list reports about 77.5 bits.

5. **Entropy and labels.** *Done when* labels match thresholds documented in the README.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Entropy, correctly.** For a uniformly random string of length L from an alphabet of N symbols, entropy is `L × log2(N)`. A 16-character password over 94 printable symbols has about 105 bits. A 6-word passphrase from 7,776 words has `6 × log2(7776)` ≈ 77.5 bits. This formula only applies to random output — a human-chosen password has far less entropy than its length suggests.
- **"At least one of each" without bias.** The naive fix — replace a random position with a digit if none exists — slightly changes the distribution. Two clean approaches: **rejection sampling** (generate, and if a class is missing, throw it away and try again) or "one from each class, fill the rest from the full alphabet, then shuffle with `secrets.SystemRandom().shuffle`". Rejection sampling is simplest to reason about.
- **Modulo bias.** If you turned random bytes into indices with `byte % N`, values below `256 % N` would appear more often. `secrets.randbelow` and `secrets.choice` already avoid this, which is one reason to use them rather than rolling your own.

Testing strategy

Property tests with Hypothesis: for any valid policy, the output has the right length and only allowed characters. A statistical smoke test: over 100,000 draws each character appears with roughly equal frequency (a chi-squared test with a loose threshold, so it does not flake). A test that greps the source for `import random`. Test entropy maths against hand-computed values.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Passphrases are easier to remember and type on phones but need more characters for the same entropy. Symbol-heavy passwords are rejected by some websites, so allow per-site policies. Clipboard support leaks secrets to clipboard history on some systems — warn about it. The biggest real-world failure is using `random`, which is a Mersenne Twister whose future output can be predicted after observing 624 outputs of 32 bits.

Stretch goals

- Check candidates against the "Have I Been Pwned" range API using k-anonymity (only the first 5 characters of the SHA-1 hash leave your machine).
- A deterministic "password from master secret + site name" mode using `hashlib.scrypt`, and a write-up of its risks.
- A tiny GUI with `tkinter`.

Skills practised

- Ch 4 — Strings: `string` constants, joining.
- Ch 7 — Functions: keyword-only arguments for policies.
- Ch 10 — OOP in Python: frozen dataclasses.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `random` vs `secrets`.
- Ch 15 — Testing and debugging: Hypothesis property tests.

In the interview

Q: Why `secrets` and not `random`? **A:** `random` uses the Mersenne Twister, which is deterministic and predictable from its outputs. `secrets` reads the operating system's cryptographically secure generator.

Q: How strong is a 12-character password of lowercase letters? **A:** `12 × log2(26)` ≈ 56 bits, if it is truly random. That is a little more than four random words from a 7,776-word list (about 52 bits) and far less than 16 characters over 94 symbols (about 105 bits).

Q: How do you force one digit without biasing the result? **A:** Rejection sampling: regenerate until the constraint holds. Every accepted password is then uniformly random among valid ones.

TL;DR

Secure generation is one line (`secrets.choice`) — the real lessons are entropy maths, unbiased constraints and why `random` is unsafe for anything security-related.

4. CSV expense report

Level: Beginner · **Time:** 1 weekend · **Prerequisites:** Ch 5, Ch 6, Ch 9, Ch 14

What it is

A tool that reads bank or card exports in **CSV** (comma-separated values — a text table, one row per line), categorises each transaction with keyword rules, and prints a monthly report: totals by category, top merchants, month-over-month change and a list of transactions it could not categorise. It can also write the report as Markdown or a new CSV.

The problem it solves

Banks export transactions in slightly different CSV layouts and nobody wants to sum them by hand in a spreadsheet each month. The project teaches messy real-world input (different column names, date formats, thousands separators, negative signs) and correct money arithmetic, which floating-point numbers get wrong.

Real-world examples

- csvkit is a suite of Python command-line tools for converting and querying CSV files — a reference for robust CSV handling.
- The `csv` module documentation explains dialects, quoting and why files must be opened with `newline=""`.
- The `decimal` module documentation explains exact decimal arithmetic for money.

Requirements

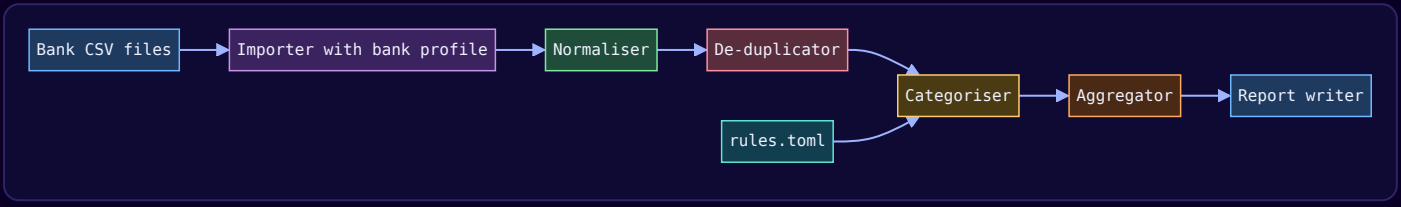
Functional

- Import one or more CSV files using a per-bank **profile** (column mapping, date format, decimal separator, sign convention).
- Categorise with ordered keyword or regex rules from a config file. Unmatched rows go to "Uncategorised".
- Report per month: total in, total out, per-category totals and share, top 5 merchants, change versus previous month.
- De-duplicate transactions when overlapping exports are imported twice.

Non-functional

- Totals are exact to the cent — no float rounding errors.
- 100,000 rows processed in under 2 seconds.
- A malformed row produces a warning with file and line number, not a crash.

The architecture



- **Importer** uses `csv.DictReader` and a profile to map bank-specific columns to standard fields.
- **Normaliser** parses dates and amounts into `date` and `Decimal`, and cleans merchant names (upper-case, strip card numbers).
- **De-duplicator** drops rows whose (date, amount, merchant) key was already seen.
- **Categoriser** applies the first matching rule.
- **Aggregator** groups by (month, category) using dictionaries or `Counter`.
- **Report writer** renders Markdown tables or CSV.

Data model

Type	Fields
`Transaction`	date, amount (`Decimal`, negative = spend), merchant, raw_description, source_file, line_no, category
`BankProfile`	date_column, date_format, amount_column or debit/credit columns, decimal_sep, encoding
`Rule`	category, pattern, is_regex
`MonthlySummary`	month, income, spend, by_category (dict), top_merchants (list)

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Reading	`csv.DictReader`	Handles quoting and embedded commas
Money	`decimal.Decimal`	Exact base-10 arithmetic
Grouping	`collections.Counter`, `defaultdict`	Totals in one pass
Encoding	`open(..., encoding="utf-8-sig")`	Strips the byte-order mark Excel adds

Milestones

1. **Read one bank.** Hard-code one profile and print parsed transactions. *Done when* dates and amounts are real `date` / `Decimal` objects.
2. **Profiles.** Load profiles from config and support two banks. *Done when* both sample files normalise to identical structures.
3. **Categorise.** *Done when* at least 90 % of your own sample rows are categorised and the rest are listed.
4. **Report.** Monthly summary in the terminal and as Markdown. *Done when* totals match a spreadsheet check to the cent.
5. **De-duplicate and warn.** *Done when* importing the same file twice gives the same report, and a corrupted row prints `file:line` and continues.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Why not float?** `0.1 + 0.2` is `0.30000000000000004` because binary floating point cannot represent most decimal fractions exactly. Summing thousands of amounts accumulates such errors. Parse amounts with `Decimal("12.34")` from the **string** (never from a float) and keep them as `Decimal` until display.
- **Locale-formatted numbers.** `1.234,56` in a German export means one thousand two hundred thirty-four and 56 cents. Strip the thousands separator, replace the decimal separator with `.`, then parse. Handle debit and credit in separate columns, parentheses for negatives, and trailing minus signs — profile flags make each explicit.
- **De-duplication keys.** Two real coffees for the same price on the same day look identical. Include an occurrence counter in the key (`(date, amount, merchant, n)`, where `n` counts repeats within one file) so genuine repeats survive but overlapping imports do not double-count.

Testing strategy

Small fixture CSVs for each bank profile, including nasty rows (quoted commas, BOM, blank lines). Assert exact `Decimal` totals. Parametrize amount parsing over many formats. Golden-file test: the Markdown report for a fixture month must match a committed expected file.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Keyword rules are transparent but need upkeep; a learned classifier (stretch) is smarter but harder to trust. Loading everything into memory is fine for personal data. For millions of rows, stream with generators or use pandas/polars (Project 31). Bank format changes silently break parsing, so validate headers and fail loudly when expected columns are missing.

Stretch goals

- Budgets per category with warnings when exceeded.
- A bar chart per month with matplotlib.
- Suggest rules for uncategorised merchants based on frequency.

Skills practised

- Ch 5 — Lists, tuples and arrays: sorting by key.
- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: `Counter`, `defaultdict`.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: `csv`, encodings, warnings.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `decimal`, `datetime`.

In the interview

Q: Why use `Decimal` for money? **A:** Floats are binary and cannot represent values like 0.10 exactly, so sums drift. `Decimal` does exact base-10 arithmetic with controllable rounding.

Q: Why open CSV files with `newline=""`? **A:** The `csv` module handles line endings itself, including newlines inside quoted fields. Letting Python translate them first can corrupt those rows.

Q: How do you avoid double-counting overlapping exports? **A:** Build a deterministic key per transaction, including an occurrence count for genuine repeats, and skip keys already seen.

TL;DR

Map messy bank CSVs through profiles into clean `Transaction` objects with `Decimal` amounts, then categorise, de-duplicate and aggregate into a monthly report that is correct to the cent.

5. Web server log analyser

Level: Beginner · **Time:** 1–2 weekends · **Prerequisites:** Ch 4, Ch 6, Ch 11

What it is

A CLI that reads web server **access logs** — text files where each line records one HTTP request (client IP, time, method, path, status code, bytes, user agent) — and produces a report: requests per minute, top paths, error rate, slowest endpoints, top clients and a list of suspicious patterns. It works on plain and gzip-compressed files and can follow a live log like `tail -f`.

The problem it solves

When a site slows down or gets attacked, the first evidence is in the access log, which can be gigabytes. Engineers need answers in seconds: which endpoint is failing, who is hammering us, when did it start. The project teaches regular expressions, streaming large files with generators, and aggregation with counters — all core interview topics.

Real-world examples

- GoAccess is an open-source real-time log analyser for terminals and browsers. It shows the kind of report users expect.
- The `re` module documentation covers named groups and compiled patterns used for parsing each line.

Requirements

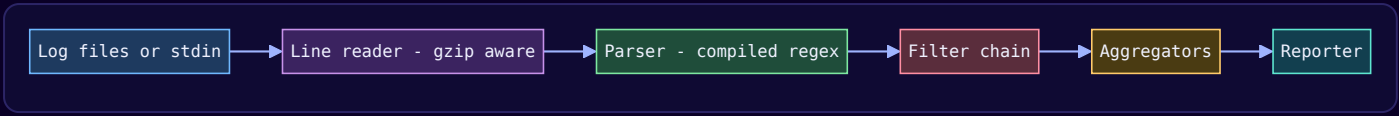
Functional

- Parse the Common and Combined Log Formats, with optional response-time field. Unknown lines are counted, not fatal.
- Filters: time range, status class (`5xx`), path prefix.
- Report: totals, requests per minute (peak and average), top N paths/IPs/user agents, status code breakdown, p50/p95/p99 latency per path.
- Read `.log` and `.gz` files, multiple files in time order, and `--follow`.

Non-functional

- Constant memory regardless of file size (except per-key counters).
- At least 200,000 lines per second on a laptop for a simple report.
- Output as a text table or JSON.

The architecture



- **Line reader** is a generator that opens each file (using `gzip.open` for `.gz`) and yields lines one at a time.
- **Parser** turns a line into a `Hit` object using one compiled regex with named groups. Malformed lines increment a counter.
- **Filter chain** is a list of predicate functions applied lazily (`filter`).
- **Aggregators** are small objects with `add(hit)` and `result()`: counter of paths, per-minute histogram, latency collectors.
- **Reporter** formats the results.

Data model

Type	Fields
`Hit`	ip, ts (`datetime`), method, path, status, size, referrer, user_agent, duration_ms
`Aggregator` protocol	`add(hit) -> None`, `result() -> dict`
Report	totals, per_minute, top_paths, status_counts, latency_percentiles

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Parsing	`re` with named groups	One pass per line, readable
Streaming	generators, `itertools`	Constant memory
Counting	`collections.Counter` with `most_common`	Top-N in one call
Percentiles	`statistics.quantiles` or sorted list	Built in
Compression	`gzip`	Read rotated logs directly

Milestones

1. **Parse.** Regex for Combined Log Format. *Done when* 100 % of a sample file parses and a deliberately broken line is counted as malformed.
2. **Stream and count.** Top paths and status codes. *Done when* memory stays flat on a 1 GB synthetic log.
3. **Time buckets.** Requests per minute and peak minute. *Done when* the peak matches a manual check.
4. **Latency percentiles.** *Done when* p95 per path is reported, matching `statistics.quantiles`.
5. **Follow mode and JSON.** *Done when* `--follow` updates counts as new lines are appended.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Regex performance.** Compile once at module level, anchor it (`^...$`), and avoid patterns with nested quantifiers like `(.*)*` that cause **catastrophic backtracking**, where the engine tries exponentially many ways to match. Use specific classes like `[^"]*` for quoted fields.
- **Parsing timestamps fast.** `datetime.strptime` is slow when called millions of times. Logs use a fixed format like `10/Oct/2026:13:55:36 +0000`, so slice the string and map the month name with a dict, or cache parsed minute prefixes: many lines share the same minute.

- **Percentiles without storing everything.** Exact percentiles need all values. For a beginner version, keep a list per path. For huge logs, use a fixed-size **histogram** of latency buckets (for example 1 ms, 2 ms, 5 ms, 10 ms...) and estimate percentiles from bucket counts, trading a little precision for constant memory.

Testing strategy

Fixture lines covering every field variant. Parametrized parser tests, including malformed lines. Test each aggregator in isolation. Generate a synthetic log with a known distribution and check the report. Benchmark lines per second with `time.perf_counter` and fail the test only if it drops dramatically.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

A single process is enough for a few GB. Beyond that, split files across processes with `multiprocessing` and merge counters (counters add up, which is why they parallelise well). Log formats vary per server configuration — make the regex configurable. Log lines contain personal data (IPs), so be careful where reports go.

Stretch goals

- Detect bursts (requests per IP per minute above a threshold) as a crude attack detector.
- Render an HTML report with a small chart.
- Parallel mode with `ProcessPoolExecutor` merging `Counter` objects.

Skills practised

- Ch 4 — Strings: regex basics.
- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: `Counter`, `defaultdict`.
- Ch 11 — Iterators, generators and functional tools: generator pipelines.
- Ch 17 — Performance, memory and internals: profiling the hot loop.

In the interview

Q: How do you process a 20 GB log on a machine with 8 GB of RAM? **A:** Stream it line by line with generators and keep only aggregates. Memory then depends on the number of distinct keys, not on file size.

Q: How would you find the top 10 IPs? **A:** `Counter` while streaming, then `most_common(10)`, which uses a heap internally — O(n log k).

Q: What is catastrophic backtracking? **A:** A regex with ambiguous nested repetition can try exponentially many matches on a non-matching line. Use precise character classes and anchors.

TL;DR

A streaming generator pipeline — read, parse with a compiled regex, filter, aggregate — that answers operational questions about huge logs in constant memory.

6. Flashcards with spaced repetition

Level: Beginner · **Time:** 1–2 weekends · **Prerequisites:** Ch 6, Ch 9, Ch 10

What it is

A terminal flashcard app. You keep decks of question/answer cards in a text file, and each day the app shows only the cards that are **due**. After each answer you grade yourself (again, hard, good, easy), and a **spaced-repetition** algorithm schedules the card's next review: cards you know well come back after weeks, cards you miss come back tomorrow.

The problem it solves

Memory fades quickly unless you review at the right moment, just before you forget. Reviewing everything every day wastes time; reviewing randomly misses the hard cards. Spaced repetition is one of the most reliable study techniques, and building it teaches state machines, date arithmetic and persistence — and you can use the app to learn this book's glossary.

Real-world examples

- Anki's FAQ on its scheduling algorithms describes its modified SM-2 scheduler and FSRS (Free Spaced Repetition Scheduler), available since Anki 23.10, which fits a memory model to your review history.
- SM-2, the algorithm from SuperMemo that Anki's classic scheduler is based on, is simple enough to implement in an afternoon, which is why this brief uses it.

Requirements

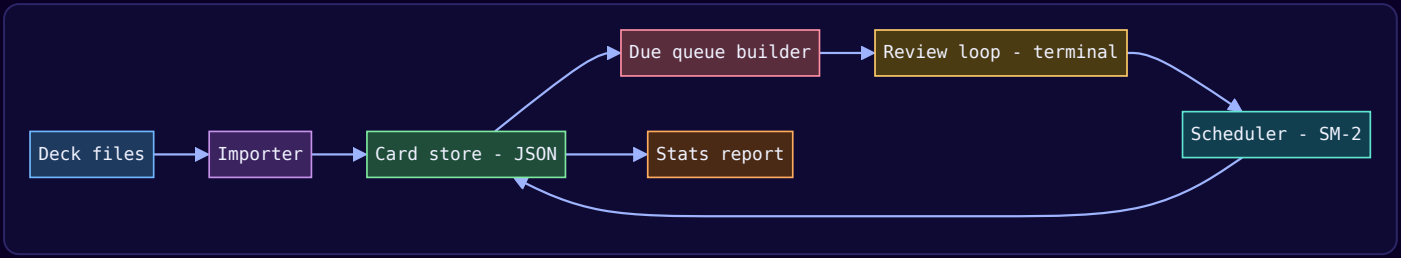
Functional

- Import decks from a simple format (`question :: answer` per line, or CSV).
- Daily session: show due cards, then up to N new cards. Reveal answer on Enter, then grade 1–4.
- Schedule with SM-2: track interval, ease factor and repetition count per card.
- Statistics: cards due today and in the next 7 days, retention rate, streak.

Non-functional

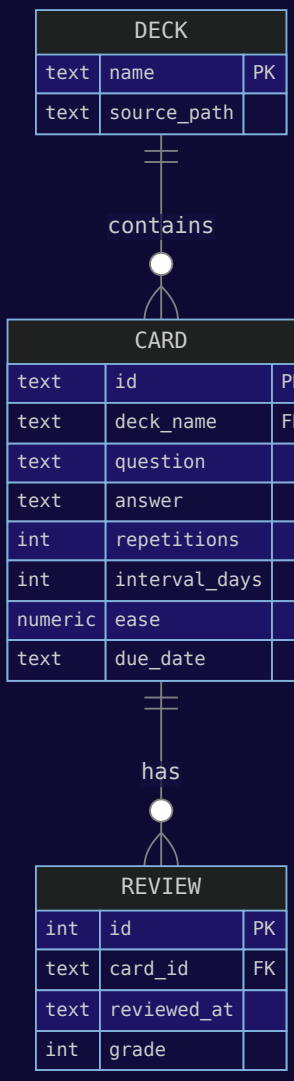
- Review state saved after every answer, so quitting mid-session loses nothing.
- A deck of 10,000 cards loads in under 300 ms.
- Editing a card's text must not reset its schedule.

The architecture



- **Importer** reads deck files and gives each card a stable id (a hash of the question text plus deck name), so re-importing updates rather than duplicates.
- **Card store** keeps cards and their review state.
- **Due queue builder** selects cards with `due <= today`, oldest first, plus a capped number of new cards.
- **Review loop** handles input and display.
- **Scheduler** is a pure function `schedule(state, grade, today) -> new_state`. Keeping it pure makes it trivial to test.

Data model



Storing every review (not just the current state) lets you change the algorithm later and replay history.

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Storage	JSON file (or `sqlite3` as stretch)	Simple, inspectable
Dates	`datetime.date`, `timedelta`	Day-level scheduling
Ids	`hashlib.sha1` of question text	Stable across edits of answer
Modelling	dataclasses	Clear state objects

Milestones

1. **Import and show.** Load a deck and loop through cards. *Done when* a 50-card deck plays end to end.
2. **SM-2.** Implement the scheduler as a pure function. *Done when* unit tests reproduce a hand-worked sequence of intervals.
3. **Persistence.** Save after each grade. *Done when* killing the app mid-session and restarting resumes correctly.
4. **Due queue and new-card cap.** *Done when* a session shows only due cards plus at most N new ones.
5. **Stats.** *Done when* the forecast for the next 7 days matches the stored due dates.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **SM-2 in plain words.** Each card has an **ease factor** (starts at 2.5) and an **interval**. On a correct answer, the interval grows: 1 day, then 6 days, then previous interval × ease. The ease rises slightly for easy answers and falls for hard ones, but never below 1.3. A failed answer resets repetitions and the interval to 1 day. That is the entire algorithm. The subtlety is clamping and rounding consistently.
- **"Today" is a moving target.** If you study at 00:30, is that today or yesterday? Many apps define a day as starting at 4 a.m. local time. Make "today" a parameter of the scheduler instead of calling `date.today()` inside it — this also makes tests deterministic.
- **Card identity.** If the id is the line number, inserting a card shifts all ids. Hashing the question gives stability, but editing the question then creates a "new" card. Decide explicitly, document it, and offer a `rename` command that moves history.

Testing strategy

Table-driven tests for `schedule()` covering each grade from each state. Freeze "today" by passing dates. Simulate 100 days of reviews with a fake student who answers correctly with some probability, and assert intervals grow and due counts stay bounded. Round-trip tests for the store.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

SM-2 is simple and predictable but ignores your actual forgetting curve; FSRS-style models adapt but need history and optimisation. A JSON store rewrites the whole file per answer, which is fine for thousands of cards; SQLite scales better and supports queries for stats. Overdue backlogs after a holiday can be overwhelming — cap daily reviews and spread the backlog.

Stretch goals

- Cloze deletions (`The GIL was made optional in {{3.13}}`).
- Load this book's glossary as a deck.
- Replace JSON with SQLite and add a "leech" flag for cards failed many times.

Skills practised

- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: indexing cards by id.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: persistence and safe saves.
- Ch 10 — OOP in Python: dataclasses for state.
- Ch 15 — Testing and debugging: deterministic tests with injected dates.

In the interview

Q: Why make the scheduler a pure function? **A:** Its output depends only on its inputs, so you can test every case without files, clocks or user input, and replay history later.

Q: How do you test date-dependent code? **A:** Inject the current date (or a clock object) instead of calling `date.today()` internally.

Q: Why store every review and not just the current state? **A:** History lets you compute statistics, debug odd schedules and re-run a better algorithm over the same data.

TL;DR

A due-queue plus a pure SM-2 scheduler and a review log: small code, real usefulness, and a clean lesson in testable state transitions.

7. Duplicate file finder

Level: Beginner · **Time:** 1 weekend · **Prerequisites:** Ch 6, Ch 9, Ch 11

What it is

A CLI that scans one or more folders and reports groups of files with identical content — the same photo copied into three places, the same installer downloaded twice — with the space you would save by removing extras. Optional actions: delete, replace with **hard links** (several directory entries pointing at the same data on disk), or move to a quarantine folder.

The problem it solves

Disks fill up with copies. Comparing every file with every other file byte by byte is $O(n^2)$ and hopelessly slow. The project teaches a classic engineering technique: use cheap filters first (size), then progressively more expensive ones (partial hash, full hash), so expensive work only happens on real candidates.

Real-world examples

- rmlint finds duplicates and other "lint" on filesystems and documents its staged approach (size grouping, then hashing) in detail.
- The `hashlib` documentation covers `hashlib.file_digest`, which hashes a file efficiently in chunks.

Requirements

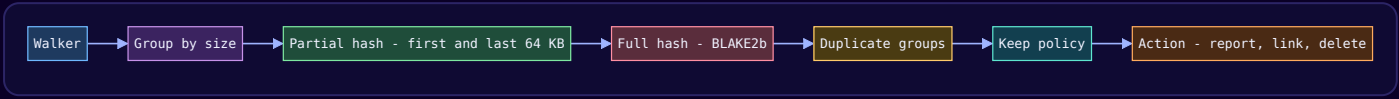
Functional

- Recursive scan with include/exclude globs and a minimum size.
- Group by identical content and print groups sorted by wasted space.
- Actions: report only (default), delete all but one (with a "keep" policy: oldest, shortest path, inside a preferred folder), hard-link, quarantine.
- JSON output for scripting.

Non-functional

- Read each byte at most once for full hashing, and only for files that share a size.
- 100,000 files scanned in under a minute on an SSD when few are duplicates.
- Never delete the last copy of anything, and default to dry run.

The architecture



- **Walker** yields regular files only, skipping symlinks to avoid loops and counting each inode once.
- **Group by size**: files with a unique size cannot have a duplicate, which usually eliminates most files without reading them.
- **Partial hash** reads a small chunk from the start and end. Different chunks prove files differ.
- **Full hash** reads the remaining candidates completely.
- **Keep policy** chooses the survivor in each group. **Action** applies the change.

Data model

Type	Fields	Notes
`FileEntry`	path, size, mtime, inode, device	`(device, inode)` identifies hard links
Size index	`dict[int, list[FileEntry]]`	First filter
Hash index	`dict[bytes, list[FileEntry]]`	Final groups
`DuplicateGroup`	digest, size, files, wasted_bytes	Report unit

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Walking	`os.scandir` / `Path.walk`	`scandir` returns cached stat info cheaply
Hashing	`hashlib.blake2b` via `file_digest`	Fast, collision-resistant
Grouping	`defaultdict(list)`	Natural fit
Parallel reads	`ThreadPoolExecutor` (stretch)	Hashing releases the GIL during I/O and on large buffers

Milestones

1. **Walk.** List files with size and inode. *Done when* symlinks and already-hard-linked files are handled.
2. **Size groups.** *Done when* the report shows how many files were eliminated without reading.
3. **Hashing stages.** Partial then full. *Done when* results equal a brute-force byte comparison on a test folder.
4. **Report.** Sorted by wasted space, human-readable sizes. *Done when* totals add up.
5. **Actions.** Delete, hard-link, quarantine with dry run. *Done when* a test proves no group ever loses its last copy.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Why staged hashing works.** Real folders have few files sharing an exact size. Size grouping is free (it comes from the directory scan), partial hashing touches a tiny slice, and full hashing runs on a small remaining set. This **funnel** pattern — cheap filter, then expensive check — appears everywhere, from databases (bloom filters) to search.
- **Hash collisions.** Two different files with the same BLAKE2b or SHA-256 digest is astronomically unlikely, so trusting the hash is reasonable for reporting. Before **deleting**, a paranoid mode can still do a byte-by-byte comparison with `filecmp.cmp(a, b, shallow=False)`. Never use a weak checksum like CRC32 for this decision.
- **Hard links and identity.** Two paths may already be the same file (same device and inode). Counting them as duplicates would make you "save" space by deleting data that only exists once. Group by `(st_dev, st_ino)` first.

Testing strategy

Build fixture folders in `tmp_path`: identical files, same-size different files, files differing only in the middle (defeats partial hash, must still be caught by full hash), symlinks and hard links. Compare results with a brute-force oracle. Test every keep policy and confirm dry run changes nothing.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Partial hashing saves time on big media but adds a pass; for many tiny files skip it. Hashing is I/O-bound on spinning disks, so threads help little there but help on SSDs and network drives. Files changing during the scan can produce wrong groups — re-check size and mtime before acting. Hard-linking makes edits to one path affect all, which surprises users.

Stretch goals

- A cache of hashes keyed by (path, size, mtime) so rescans are instant.
- Near-duplicate image detection with perceptual hashes.
- Parallel hashing with a thread pool and a progress bar.

Skills practised

- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: grouping with `defaultdict`.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: binary I/O, `pathlib`, permissions errors.
- Ch 11 — Iterators, generators and functional tools: lazy walking.
- Ch 17 — Performance, memory and internals: measuring the funnel.

In the interview

Q: How do you find duplicate files among millions efficiently? **A:** Group by size, then by a hash of a small chunk, then by a full cryptographic hash. Each stage removes most candidates before the expensive one.

Q: Is a hash match proof of identical content? **A:** Practically yes for a strong hash, but for destructive actions a final byte comparison removes even the theoretical doubt.

Q: What is a hard link? **A:** Another name for the same data on disk. Deleting one name does not free space until all names are gone.

TL;DR

A size → partial hash → full hash funnel finds duplicates while reading as little data as possible, with careful identity checks so cleanup never destroys the last copy.

8. Weather CLI with a response cache

Level: Beginner · **Time:** 1 weekend · **Prerequisites:** Ch 9, Ch 14

What it is

A command `wx "Lisbon"` that looks up a place, calls a free public weather **API** (application programming interface — a web address that returns data, here JSON, instead of a web page), and prints current conditions and a 7-day forecast. Responses are cached on disk for a few minutes so repeated calls are instant and polite to the provider.

The problem it solves

Almost every real program talks to a web service. This is the gentlest way to learn how: build URLs with query parameters, handle timeouts and HTTP errors, parse JSON into typed objects and avoid hammering a free service. Using only the standard library (`urllib.request`) shows what libraries like `requests` and `httpx` do for you.

Real-world examples

- Open-Meteo's API documentation describes a free weather API that needs no key for non-commercial use, plus a geocoding endpoint to turn place names into coordinates.
- The `urllib.request` documentation covers `urlopen`, timeouts and `HTTPError`.

Requirements

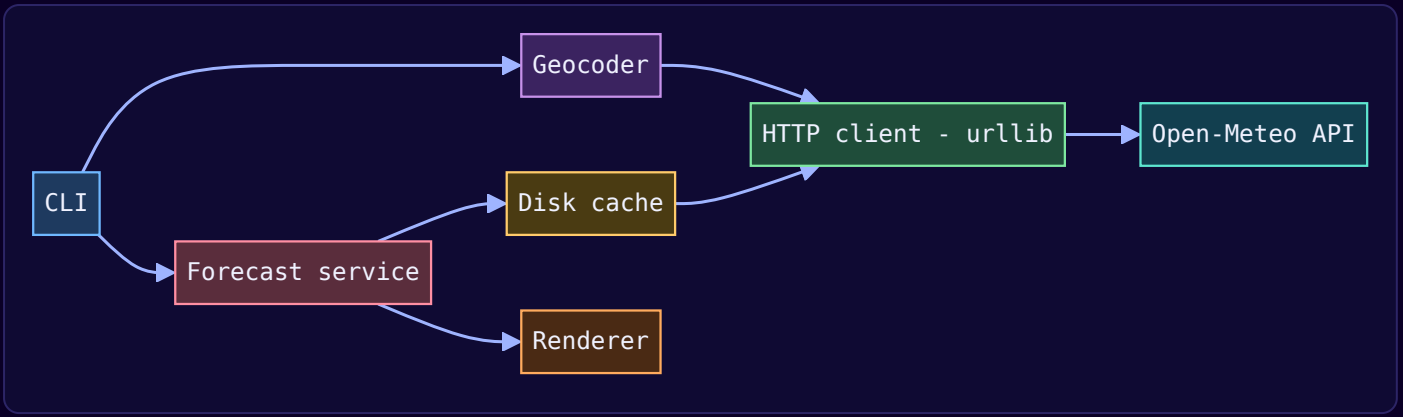
Functional

- Geocode a place name to latitude/longitude (show choices when ambiguous).
- Current temperature, wind and condition plus a daily forecast table.
- Units: metric or imperial. Remember a default location in a config file.
- `--no-cache` and `--json` flags.

Non-functional

- Network timeout of 5 seconds, with a clear message when offline.
- A cached answer prints in under 50 ms.
- At most one request per location per 10 minutes by default (respect the provider).

The architecture



- **Geocoder** turns a name into coordinates using the geocoding endpoint.
- **Forecast service** builds the forecast request and converts JSON into `Forecast` objects.
- **Disk cache** stores responses keyed by URL, with an expiry time. It sits in front of the HTTP client, so callers do not know whether data was cached.
- **HTTP client** wraps `urlopen` with timeouts, a `User-Agent` header and error translation.
- **Renderer** prints tables with weather-code descriptions.

Data model

Type	Fields
`Location`	name, country, latitude, longitude, timezone
`CurrentWeather`	time, temperature, wind_speed, weather_code
`DailyForecast`	date, t_min, t_max, precipitation_mm, weather_code
Cache entry	key (hash of URL), fetched_at, expires_at, body

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
HTTP	`urllib.request`	Standard library, teaches the basics
URLs	`urllib.parse.urlencode`	Correct escaping of query strings
JSON	`json`	Parse responses
Cache dir	`pathlib`, platform cache folder	Survives restarts
Config	`tomllib`	Default location and units

Milestones

1. **One request.** Hard-coded coordinates, print raw JSON. *Done when* a timeout and an HTTP 4xx are both handled with friendly messages.
2. **Geocoding.** *Done when* `wx Paris` asks you to choose between Paris, France and Paris, Texas.
3. **Typed parsing and rendering.** *Done when* the forecast prints as an aligned table with dates and units.
4. **Cache.** *Done when* a second call within 10 minutes makes no network request (verified in a test).
5. **Config.** *Done when* `wx` with no argument uses your saved default.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Cache keys and expiry.** Key the cache by the **full** request URL (after sorting parameters), hashed to a safe file name. Store the fetch time in the entry and treat it as stale after the TTL (time to live). Write cache files atomically (temp file plus `os.replace`) so a crash cannot leave a corrupt entry that breaks every later run — and if an entry fails to parse, delete it and refetch.

- **Error taxonomy.** Network failures come in kinds: DNS failure or no connection (`URLError`), timeout (`TimeoutError`), server says no (`HTTPError` with a status code), and bad data (`json.JSONDecodeError`, missing keys). Map each to one clear message, and on network errors fall back to a stale cache entry with a warning — stale weather beats no weather.
- **Time zones.** Forecast days are in the location's local time zone, not yours. Ask the API to return local times (`timezone=auto` style parameter) and display them with `zoneinfo`.

Testing strategy

Never hit the network in unit tests: inject the HTTP function and feed recorded JSON fixtures. Test the cache with a fake clock (advance time past the TTL and assert a refetch). Test the error mapping by making the fake raise each exception type. Keep one optional "live" test marked to run only on demand.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

A file-per-entry cache is simple but needs cleanup of old files. Short TTLs give fresher data but more requests. `urllib` lacks connection pooling and retries; for anything bigger use `httpx` (Project 17 builds retries yourself). Free APIs change or rate-limit — handle HTTP 429 (too many requests) by honouring `Retry-After`.

Stretch goals

- Hourly sparkline charts in the terminal using Unicode blocks.
- Severe-weather alerts when precipitation or wind cross thresholds.
- Async fetching of several cities at once with `asyncio.to_thread` or `httpx`.

Skills practised

- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: exception mapping, JSON, atomic cache writes.
- Ch 10 — OOP in Python: dataclasses for API results.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `urllib`, `datetime`, `zoneinfo`.
- Ch 15 — Testing and debugging: fakes instead of network calls.

In the interview

Q: How do you unit-test code that calls an HTTP API? **A:** Inject the HTTP layer and replace it with a fake that returns recorded responses or raises errors, so tests are fast and deterministic.

Q: What should happen when the API is down? **A:** Time out quickly, then serve a stale cached answer with a warning if one exists, otherwise exit with a clear message.

Q: Why always set a timeout? **A:** Without one a request can hang forever on a dead connection, freezing the whole program.

TL;DR

A stdlib-only API client that teaches URL building, timeouts, error mapping, typed parsing and a TTL disk cache that keeps the tool fast and polite.

9. Habit tracker on SQLite

Level: Beginner · **Time:** 1–2 weekends · **Prerequisites:** Ch 9, Ch 10, Ch 14

What it is

A CLI for tracking daily habits (`habit check reading`, `habit week`) that stores data in **SQLite**, a full SQL database contained in a single file and built into Python as the `sqlite3` module. It shows streaks, completion rates and a calendar heat-map in the terminal.

The problem it solves

Habit apps are simple on the surface but full of interesting questions: how to count a streak, how to handle habits that are only due on weekdays, what "today" means after midnight. Moving from JSON files to a real database teaches schemas, constraints, transactions and queries — the foundation of almost every backend.

Real-world examples

- The `sqlite3` module documentation covers connections, placeholders, transactions and adapters.
- SQLite's write-ahead logging (WAL) page explains the journal mode that lets readers and a writer work at the same time.

Requirements

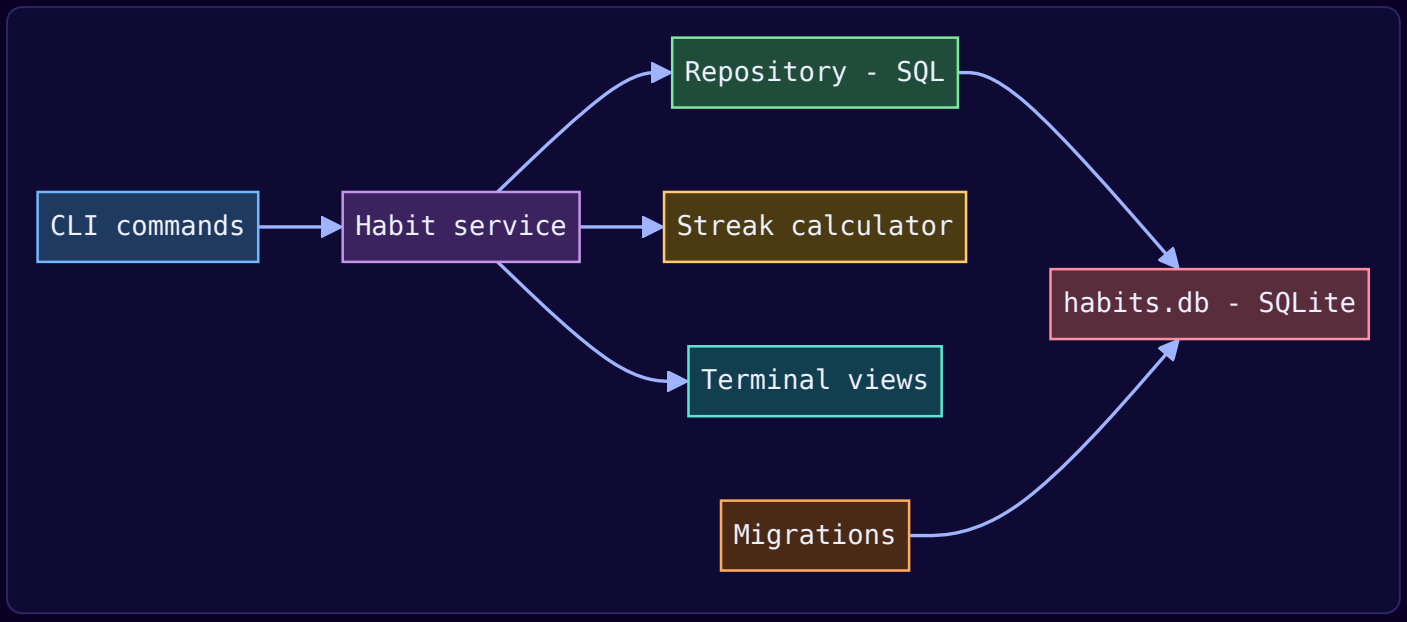
Functional

- Create habits with a schedule (daily, specific weekdays, N times per week).
- Check in for today or a past date, undo a check-in, add a note.
- Show current and longest streaks, completion rate over 30 days, and a week or month grid.
- Archive habits without losing history.

Non-functional

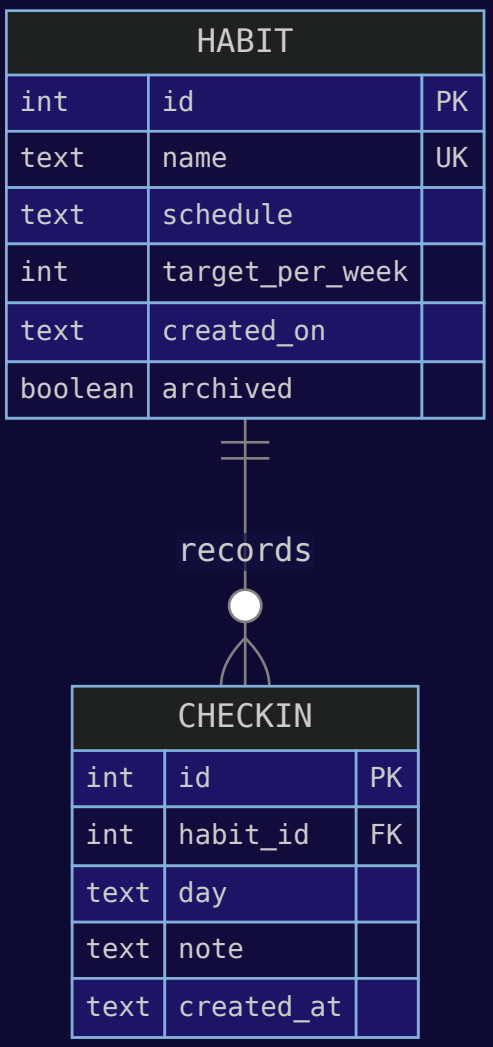
- Any command under 100 ms with five years of data.
- Data integrity enforced by the database: no duplicate check-ins for the same habit and day.
- Schema upgrades without data loss (a `user_version` based migration).

The architecture



- **Habit service** holds rules: you cannot check in to an archived habit, a habit due on weekdays does not break its streak on Saturday.
- **Repository** is the only place with SQL. It returns dataclasses.
- **Streak calculator** is a pure function over a sorted list of dates and a schedule.
- **Migrations** run at start-up, upgrading the schema step by step using SQLite's `PRAGMA user_version`.

Data model



A `UNIQUE (habit_id, day)` constraint on `CHECKIN` makes double check-ins impossible, whatever the code does.

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Database	`sqlite3`	Zero setup, ACID transactions
Dates	ISO text columns	Sort correctly as strings
Modelling	dataclasses	Rows become typed objects
CLI	`argparse`	Sub-commands

Milestones

1. **Schema and add.** Create tables and add habits. *Done when* adding a duplicate name fails with a friendly message from the unique constraint.
2. **Check-ins.** *Done when* checking in twice the same day is rejected by the database and reported nicely.
3. **Streaks.** *Done when* tests cover daily and weekday schedules, including streaks spanning month and year boundaries.
4. **Views.** Week grid and 30-day rate. *Done when* output matches the data.

5. **Migrations.** Add a `note` column in version 2. *Done when* an old database upgrades automatically and keeps its data.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Parameterised queries.** Never build SQL with f-strings — `f"... WHERE name = '{name}'"` lets a name like `x' OR '1'='1` change the query (**SQL injection**). Use placeholders: `conn.execute("SELECT ... WHERE name = ?", (name,))`. The driver sends values separately from the SQL text.
- **Transactions.** Several statements that must succeed or fail together (archive a habit and its reminders) belong in one transaction. Using the connection as a context manager (`with conn:`) commits on success and rolls back on exception. Also run `PRAGMA foreign_keys = ON` per connection — SQLite does not enforce foreign keys by default.
- **Streaks with schedules.** Walk backwards from today over **due** days only: for a weekday habit, Saturday and Sunday are skipped rather than counted as misses. Today not yet checked should not break the streak until the day is over. Write the rule down in words before coding, then turn each sentence into a test.

Testing strategy

Use an in-memory database (`sqlite3.connect(":memory:")`) per test for speed, running the real migrations. Pure tests for the streak calculator with many schedules. A migration test that builds a version 1 database file, runs the app and checks the data in version 2.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

SQLite is perfect for a single user and many readers, and handles far more data than a habit tracker needs. It allows only one writer at a time, which matters for web apps with many concurrent writes (then use PostgreSQL, Project 12). Text dates are simple and sortable, but you must always store the same format.

Stretch goals

- Reminders via desktop notifications.
- Export and import as CSV.
- A tiny local web UI using `http.server` or FastAPI.

Skills practised

- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: handling `sqlite3.IntegrityError`.
- Ch 10 — OOP in Python: repository and service classes.
- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: connections as context managers.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `sqlite3`, `datetime`.

In the interview

Q: How do you prevent SQL injection? **A:** Always use parameter placeholders, never string formatting, so user input is treated as data, not SQL.

Q: Why put a unique constraint in the database when the code already checks? **A:** Code checks can race or have bugs. The database constraint is the last line of defence and is enforced for every client.

Q: When would you outgrow SQLite? **A:** When many processes or servers need to write concurrently, or you need network access and roles — then a server database like PostgreSQL fits better.

TL;DR

A habit tracker that moves you from files to a real database: schemas, constraints, parameterised queries, transactions, migrations and a carefully specified streak rule.

10. Incremental backup tool with zstd

Level: Beginner · **Time:** 2 weekends · **Prerequisites:** Ch 9, Ch 14, Ch 17

What it is

A tool that backs up a folder to another disk. The first run copies everything; later runs copy only files that changed (**incremental** backup). Each run produces a **snapshot** you can list and restore from. Files are compressed with **Zstandard** (zstd), a fast modern compression algorithm, using the `compression.zstd` module that is new in Python 3.14 (PEP 784).

The problem it solves

Losing files to a dead disk or a mistaken delete is common and painful. Copying everything each time is slow and wastes space; copying only changes needs a way to detect changes and to rebuild any past state. This project teaches change detection, manifests, compression trade-offs and verification with checksums.

Real-world examples

- restic and BorgBackup are open-source backup programs that use content-defined chunking, de-duplication, compression and encryption — the "grown-up" version of this design.
- PEP 784 added the `compression` package with `compression.zstd`. In 3.14, `tarfile`, `zipfile` and `shutil` can also read and write Zstandard archives.

Requirements

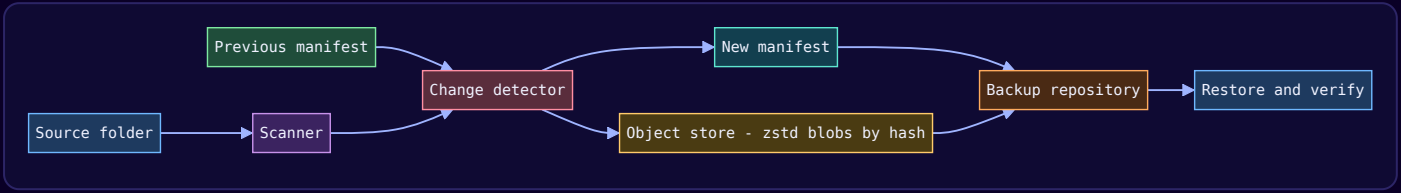
Functional

- `backup SRC DEST` creates a snapshot. Unchanged files are referenced, not copied again.
- `snapshots` lists snapshots with date, file count and size. `restore SNAPSHOT [PATH] TARGET` restores all or part.
- `verify` re-hashes stored objects and reports corruption.
- `prune --keep-daily 7 --keep-weekly 4` deletes old snapshots and unreferenced objects.

Non-functional

- A no-change run over 100,000 files finishes in under 10 seconds (no file content read).
- Each stored object's integrity is checkable by its hash.
- An interrupted backup never damages earlier snapshots.

The architecture



- **Scanner** collects path, size and modification time for every file.
- **Change detector** compares with the previous **manifest** (a list of files in a snapshot). Same size and mtime means unchanged; otherwise hash the file.
- **Object store** saves each unique file content once, compressed, named by its SHA-256 hash (**content-addressed storage**). Identical files anywhere share one object.
- **Manifest** maps every path in the snapshot to an object hash plus metadata. It is written last, so a snapshot exists only once all its objects are stored.

Data model

Item	Contents
`objects/ab/cdef...zst`	zstd-compressed file content, name = SHA-256 of the uncompressed content
`snapshots/2026-10-01T10-00-00.json`	`{"created": ..., "source": ..., "files": {path: {hash, size, mtime, mode}}}`
`ManifestEntry` dataclass	path, hash, size, mtime_ns, mode

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Compression	`compression.zstd` (3.14)	Fast with good ratios, tunable level
Hashing	`hashlib.sha256`	Integrity and de-duplication
Files	`pathlib`, `os.scandir`	Fast metadata
Manifests	`json`	Readable, diff-able

Milestones

1. **Full copy with manifest.** *Done when* a restore reproduces the source exactly (compare with `filecmp.dircmp`).
2. **Content-addressed objects.** *Done when* two identical files are stored once.
3. **Incremental runs.** *Done when* a second run with no changes reads no file contents (count reads in a test).
4. **Compression.** *Done when* objects are zstd-compressed and you have measured ratio and speed at a few levels on your data.
5. **Verify and prune.** *Done when* corrupting one object is detected by `verify`, and pruning keeps every object still referenced.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Crash safety by ordering.** Write objects first (each via temp file then rename), then write the manifest last, also atomically. If the backup dies halfway, you have some orphan objects but every existing snapshot is still complete. `prune` later removes orphans. This "data first, pointer last" ordering is the same idea databases use.
- **Change detection shortcuts.** Size plus `st_mtime_ns` is the usual quick check (rsync works this way by default). It can be fooled by tools that preserve mtime, so offer `--checksum` to hash everything. Hash in chunks to keep memory flat on big files.
- **Choosing a compression level.** Zstandard levels trade CPU time for size. Low levels are very fast and still compress text well. Already-compressed files (JPEG, MP4, ZIP) barely shrink, so skip compression for known extensions or when a trial compression saves less than a few percent.

Testing strategy

Fixture trees with nested folders, empty files, unusual names and binary data. Round-trip tests: backup, restore, compare. Crash simulation: make the object store raise after N objects and check previous snapshots restore fine. Corruption test: flip a byte in an object and run `verify`.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Whole-file objects re-store a 10 GB file if one byte changes; restic and Borg split files into **content-defined chunks** to fix that (stretch goal). A backup on the same disk protects against mistakes, not disk failure — keep a copy elsewhere. Without encryption, anyone with the backup disk reads your files.

Stretch goals

- Content-defined chunking with a rolling hash.
- Encryption with a key derived from a password (`hashlib.scrypt` plus an authenticated cipher from the `cryptography` package).
- Parallel compression of objects with a thread pool.

Skills practised

- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: binary files, atomic writes.
- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: manifests as dicts, reference sets for pruning.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `hashlib`, `json`, `datetime`.
- Ch 17 — Performance, memory and internals: measuring compression speed and ratio.

In the interview

Q: What is content-addressed storage? **A:** Data is stored under the hash of its content. Identical content gets the same name, giving de-duplication and built-in integrity checks.

Q: How does your backup stay consistent if it crashes? **A:** Objects are written first and the manifest last, each atomically, so a snapshot only becomes visible when everything it references exists.

Q: Why not compress everything at the highest level? **A:** Higher levels cost much more CPU for small gains, and already-compressed formats barely shrink.

TL;DR

Snapshots as manifests pointing at hash-named, zstd-compressed objects give incremental, de-duplicated, verifiable backups — and show off Python 3.14's new `compression.zstd`.

11. Async web scraper with httpx

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 2 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 9, Ch 11, Ch 16

What it is

A **crawler**: a program that starts from seed URLs, downloads pages, extracts links and data, and follows links within limits. It uses `asyncio` (Python's single-threaded concurrency framework where tasks pause at `await` while waiting for I/O) and the `httpx` async client to keep hundreds of requests in flight at once, while staying polite: obeying `robots.txt`, limiting requests per host and backing off on errors.

The problem it solves

Price comparison, search indexing, dataset building and link checking all need many pages fetched quickly. Fetching one page at a time spends almost all its time waiting on the network. Async I/O lets one process overlap those waits, but uncontrolled concurrency gets you blocked or crashes a small site. The real lesson is **bounded, fair concurrency**.

Real-world examples

- The httpx async documentation covers `AsyncClient`, connection pooling and timeouts.
- RFC 9309 standardises the Robots Exclusion Protocol (`robots.txt`).
- Scrapy is the best-known Python crawling framework. Its docs on per-domain concurrency, download delays and AutoThrottle describe exactly the politeness problems you will meet.

Requirements

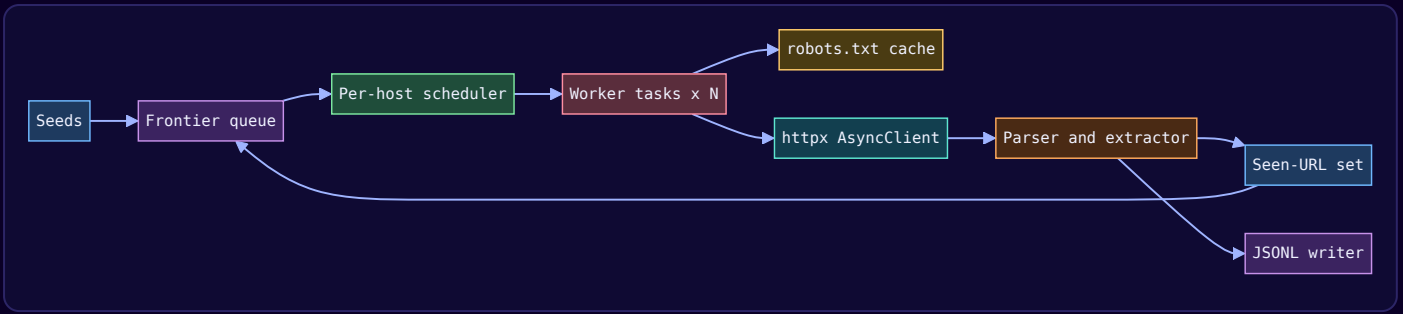
Functional

- Seeds, allowed domains, maximum depth and page count.
- Fetch with `httpx.AsyncClient`, extract links and a configurable set of fields (title, prices, meta tags) with an HTML parser.
- Obey `robots.txt` per host and a per-host delay. Retry transient failures with backoff.
- De-duplicate URLs after normalisation. Write results as JSON Lines, resumable after a crash.

Non-functional

- At least 50 pages per second overall against fast hosts, while never exceeding 2 concurrent requests per host by default.
- Memory bounded: the frontier (queue of URLs to visit) spills to disk beyond 100,000 entries.
- Clean shutdown on Ctrl-C: in-flight tasks finish or are cancelled, state is saved.

The architecture



- **Frontier** is an `asyncio.Queue` of `(url, depth)` items.
- **Per-host scheduler** enforces "at most K requests per host" with one `asyncio.Semaphore` per host and a minimum delay between requests to the same host.
- **Worker tasks** are N coroutines in a `TaskGroup`, each looping: take a URL, check robots, fetch, parse, enqueue new links.
- **robots.txt cache** fetches and parses each host's rules once (`urllib.robotparser`).
- **Seen-URL set** stores normalised URLs so each page is fetched once.
- **JSONL writer** appends results. One writer task avoids interleaved lines.

Data model

Type	Fields
`CrawlItem`	url, depth, referrer, attempts
`Page`	url, final_url, status, fetched_at, content_type, elapsed_ms
`Record`	url, extracted fields (dict), links_found
Checkpoint	frontier snapshot, seen set (or bloom filter), counters

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
HTTP	`httpx.AsyncClient`	Async, pooling, HTTP/2 option, timeouts
Concurrency	`asyncio.TaskGroup`, `Semaphore`, `Queue`	Structured concurrency, backpressure
Parsing	`selectolax` or `html.parser`	Fast or dependency-free
robots	`urllib.robotparser`	Standard library
Debugging	`python -m asyncio ps PID` (3.14)	Lists running tasks of a live process

Milestones

1. **Sequential crawler.** Fetch, parse, follow links to depth 2. *Done when* it crawls a local test site correctly.
2. **Async workers.** N workers over a queue. *Done when* a crawl of a slow test server is roughly N times faster.
3. **Politeness.** robots.txt, per-host semaphore, delays. *Done when* a test server records never more than K concurrent connections per host.
4. **Robustness.** Timeouts, retries with exponential backoff and jitter, error records. *Done when* injected 500s and timeouts are retried then logged.
5. **Resume and shutdown.** *Done when* Ctrl-C then restart continues without refetching.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Knowing when you are done.** Workers block on `queue.get()` forever if nobody tells them the crawl is over. Use `queue.join()` together with `task_done()`: when every enqueued item has been processed (including the

links it produced), `join()` returns and you cancel the workers. In 3.13+ you can also call `queue.shutdown()`.

- **URL normalisation.** `HTTP://Example.com:80/a/../b?y=2&x=1#top` and `http://example.com/b?x=1&y=2` are the same page. Lower-case scheme and host, drop default ports and fragments, resolve dot segments with `urljoin`, and optionally sort query parameters. Without this the seen-set fails and you crawl loops.
- **Backpressure.** If parsing finds links faster than fetching consumes them, the frontier grows without bound. A bounded queue makes producers wait (`await queue.put`) — that is **backpressure**. For very large crawls, keep an in-memory buffer and spill the rest to disk.
- **Never block the loop.** CPU-heavy parsing of huge pages stalls every other task. Measure with asyncio debug mode, and move heavy parsing to `asyncio.to_thread` or a process pool.

Testing strategy

Run a local test site (an ASGI app or `http.server` in a thread) that serves known link graphs, robots rules, slow endpoints and failures, so tests never touch the internet. Use `httpx.MockTransport` for unit tests of the fetcher. Assert per-host concurrency by having the test server count simultaneous connections.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Asyncio scales to thousands of connections in one process, but parsing is CPU-bound — for heavy extraction, combine async fetching with a process pool. A Python `set` of seen URLs costs about 100 bytes per URL; at hundreds of millions use a bloom filter (a compact probabilistic set that can say "maybe seen" but never misses a seen item) or a database. JavaScript-rendered sites need a headless browser, which is far slower. Respect terms of service and legal limits on scraping personal data.

Stretch goals

- HTTP/2 and conditional requests (`If-Modified-Since`, `ETag`) for recrawls.
- Distributed crawling with Redis as a shared frontier.
- Sitemap discovery and priority by depth or page importance.

Skills practised

- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: `TaskGroup`, queues, semaphores, cancellation.
- Ch 11 — Iterators, generators and functional tools: async iteration over results.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: `ExceptionGroup`, JSON Lines.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `urllib.parse`, `urllib.robotparser`.

In the interview

Q: Why asyncio rather than threads for a crawler? **A:** The work is I/O-bound with thousands of waits. Coroutines are much cheaper than threads, and one event loop can multiplex many sockets. Threads also work but cost more memory per connection.

Q: How do you limit concurrency per host? **A:** A dict of `asyncio.Semaphore` objects keyed by host, acquired around each request, plus a per-host minimum delay.

Q: How do workers know the crawl is finished? **A:** `queue.join()` returns when every item has been marked `task_done()`, then cancel the workers (or shut down the queue).

Q: What happens if you call `requests.get` inside a coroutine? **A:** It blocks the event loop, freezing every task until it returns. Use an async client or `asyncio.to_thread`.

TL;DR

A frontier queue feeding N async workers, with per-host semaphores, robots.txt and backoff, teaches bounded and polite concurrency — the hard part of scraping is not fetching, it is restraint.

12. REST API with FastAPI and PostgreSQL

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 2–3 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 10, Ch 13, Ch 15, Ch 16

What it is

A backend for a small "reading list" service: users save links, tag them, mark them read and search them. It exposes a **REST API** — HTTP endpoints where URLs name resources (`/links/42`) and HTTP methods name actions (GET reads, POST creates, PATCH updates, DELETE removes) — built with FastAPI and backed by PostgreSQL, with authentication, pagination, validation and an OpenAPI spec generated automatically.

The problem it solves

Most Python jobs involve a web API in front of a database. Getting one right means far more than routing: input validation, consistent errors, authentication, database transactions, migrations, connection pooling, pagination that does not slow down, and tests that run against a real database. This project collects all of those in one service.

Real-world examples

- The FastAPI documentation shows how type hints drive validation (via Pydantic), dependency injection and the generated OpenAPI docs.
- Psycopg 3 is the PostgreSQL driver for Python with sync and async APIs and a connection pool.
- Roy Fielding's dissertation chapter on REST defines the architectural style the term comes from.

Requirements

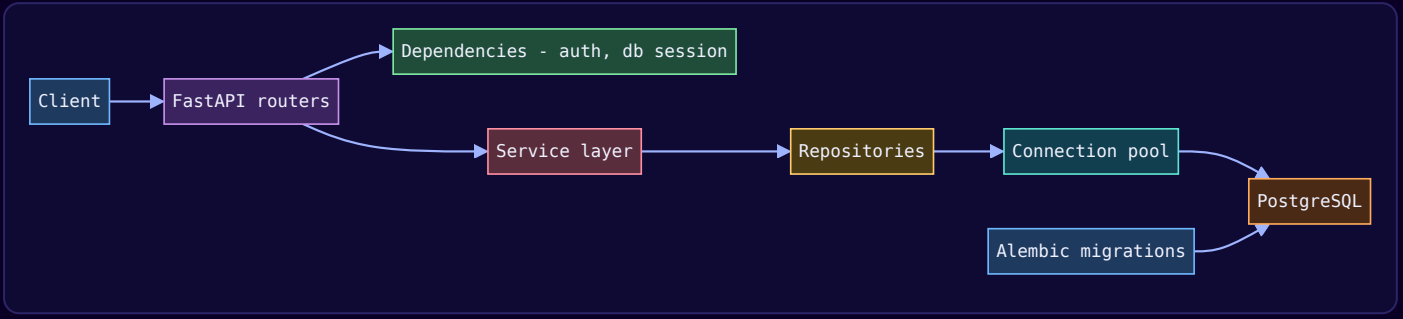
Functional

- Users sign up and log in. Requests carry a bearer token.
- CRUD (create, read, update, delete) for links and tags. Each user sees only their own data.
- List with filters (tag, read/unread), full-text search on title and notes, and cursor pagination.
- Consistent error bodies (`{"error": {"code": ..., "message": ...}}`) and correct status codes (400, 401, 404, 409, 422).

Non-functional

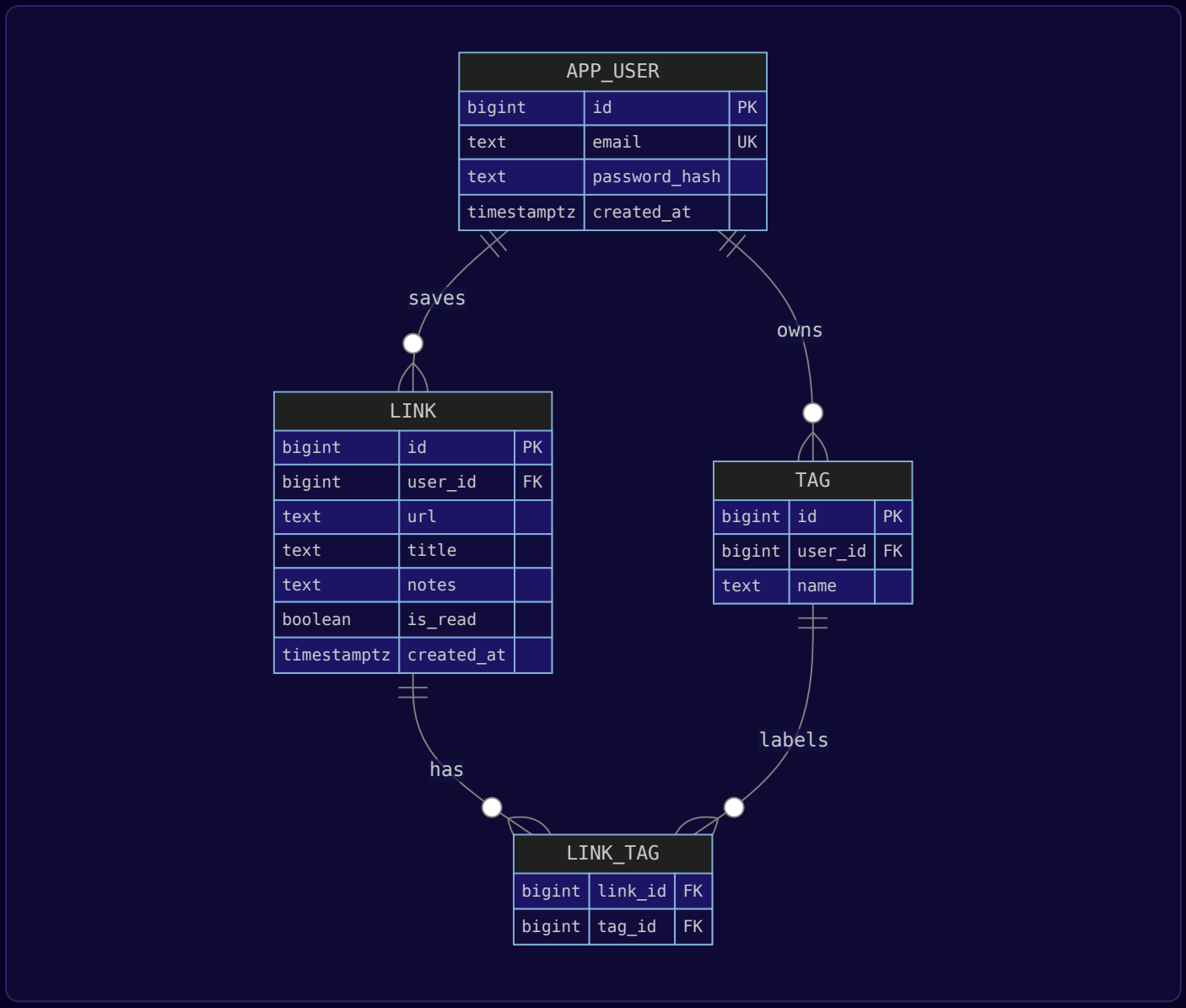
- p95 latency under 50 ms for reads at 200 requests per second on one machine.
- Zero downtime schema migrations for additive changes.
- Passwords stored with a slow hash (argon2 or bcrypt). Nothing secret in logs.

The architecture



- **Routers** declare endpoints with Pydantic request and response models. They translate HTTP into service calls and nothing more.
- **Dependencies** are FastAPI's way of injecting shared things: the current user (from the token) and a database connection from the pool for the request's duration.
- **Service layer** holds business rules (a user cannot tag someone else's link) and owns transactions.
- **Repositories** contain the SQL (hand-written or via SQLAlchemy).
- **Migrations** version the schema with Alembic.

Data model



Add `UNIQUE (user_id, url)` on links, `UNIQUE (user_id, name)` on tags, a composite primary key on `LINK_TAG`, and a GIN index on a `tsvector` of title and notes for search.

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Framework	FastAPI	Type-hint-driven validation, async, OpenAPI
Validation	Pydantic	Parses and validates request bodies
Database	PostgreSQL	Constraints, full-text search, robust concurrency
Driver	psycopg 3 with pool	Async support, server-side parameters
Migrations	Alembic	Versioned schema changes
Server	Uvicorn	ASGI server
Tests	pytest + a throwaway Postgres (container)	Real SQL behaviour

Milestones

1. **Hello API.** Health endpoint, settings from environment, OpenAPI docs. *Done when* `/docs` lists the endpoint.

2. **Schema and CRUD for links.** *Done when* create, read, update, delete work with validation errors returning 422.
3. **Auth.** Sign-up, login, token, current-user dependency. *Done when* user A gets 404 for user B's link.
4. **Tags, filters, search, pagination.** *Done when* listing 100,000 links pages through without slowing down.
5. **Hardening.** Error format, logging with request ids, rate limit on login. *Done when* a load test meets the latency target.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Async and the database.** FastAPI runs `async def` endpoints on the event loop. Calling a blocking driver there stalls all requests. Either use an async driver (psycopg's async connection and pool) or declare the endpoint with plain `def`, which FastAPI runs in a thread pool. Mixing them carelessly is the most common FastAPI performance bug.
- **Cursor pagination.** `OFFSET 50000 LIMIT 50` makes PostgreSQL read and discard 50,000 rows. Instead return a cursor encoding the last seen `(created_at, id)` and query `WHERE (created_at, id) < (%s, %s) ORDER BY created_at DESC, id DESC LIMIT 50`. With a matching index, every page costs the same.
- **Authorisation in queries.** Always include `user_id = current_user` in the SQL rather than fetching then checking. Returning 404 (not 403) for someone else's resource avoids revealing that it exists.
- **Idempotency and conflicts.** Saving the same URL twice should return 409 or the existing link, enforced by the unique constraint and `INSERT ... ON CONFLICT`, not by a check-then-insert that races.

Testing strategy

Unit-test services with fake repositories. Integration-test the API with `httpx` against the app and a real PostgreSQL started for the test session (for example with Testcontainers), wrapping each test in a transaction that is rolled back. Test auth boundaries explicitly. Run a short load test with a tool like Locust to check latency.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

FastAPI plus async shines for I/O-heavy APIs, but CPU-heavy work in a handler blocks everything. The database is usually the bottleneck: watch the connection pool size (too big overloads PostgreSQL, too small queues requests). JWTs avoid a session lookup but cannot be revoked easily; opaque tokens in a table are simpler to revoke. Scale reads with replicas and caching later.

Stretch goals

- Background job to fetch page titles (Project 26's queue).
- ETags and conditional GETs.
- Row-level security in PostgreSQL as defence in depth.

Skills practised

- Ch 13 — Type hints: Pydantic models, typed dependencies.
- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: async endpoints and blocking calls.
- Ch 10 — OOP in Python: service and repository layers.
- Ch 15 — Testing and debugging: fixtures, integration tests.

In the interview

Q: What happens if an `async def` endpoint calls a blocking database driver? **A:** It blocks the event loop, so every concurrent request waits. Use an async driver or a sync `def` endpoint, which runs in a thread pool.

Q: Why cursor pagination over offset? **A:** Offset scans and discards rows, so deep pages get slower, and inserts shift pages. A keyset cursor uses an index and is stable.

Q: How do you stop users seeing each other's data? **A:** Scope every query by the authenticated user id, enforce it in the repository layer, and return 404 for foreign resources.

Q: Where do validation errors come from in FastAPI? **A:** Pydantic validates request data against the declared types and FastAPI turns failures into 422 responses.

TL;DR

A production-shaped API — typed models, layered code, real constraints, keyset pagination, async-aware database access and integration tests — is the most job-relevant project in this book.

13. Markdown static site generator

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 2 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 4, Ch 9, Ch 11, Ch 14

What it is

A tool that turns a folder of Markdown files with **front matter** (a block of metadata like title and date at the top of each file) into a complete static website: HTML pages from templates, an index, tag pages, an RSS feed, copied assets and a local preview server that rebuilds when files change. **Static** means the output is plain files any web server can host — no database, no server code.

The problem it solves

Blogs, documentation and personal sites rarely need a dynamic backend. Static sites are fast, cheap and secure. Building a generator teaches text processing, templating, dependency tracking (which pages must be rebuilt when one file changes) and a clean plugin-friendly pipeline.

Real-world examples

- Pelican is a Python static site generator using Markdown or reStructuredText and Jinja templates.
- MkDocs builds documentation sites from Markdown with a YAML configuration and a live-reload dev server.
- markdown-it-py is a Python port of markdown-it that follows the CommonMark specification and supports plugins.

Requirements

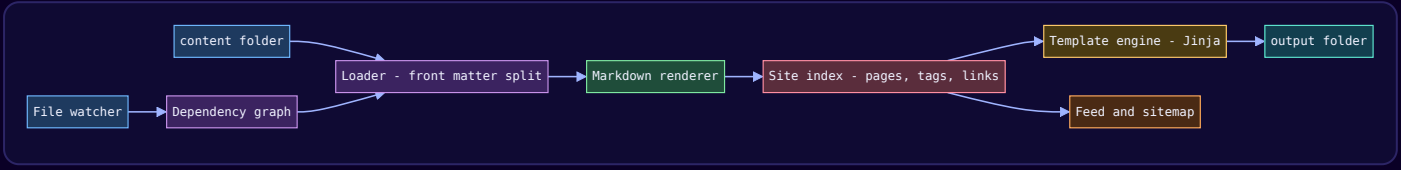
Functional

- Parse front matter (title, date, tags, draft, template) and Markdown body.
- Render with templates (layouts, partials), generate index and tag pages, RSS/Atom feed, sitemap.
- Copy static assets. Pretty URLs (`/posts/hello/`).
- `serve` command: local server plus rebuild on change.

Non-functional

- Full build of 1,000 pages in under 5 seconds. Incremental rebuild of one edited page in under 300 ms.
- Deterministic output: same input gives byte-identical output.
- Broken internal links fail the build with file and line.

The architecture



- **Loader** splits each file into metadata and body, validates metadata and builds `Page` objects.
- **Markdown renderer** converts the body to HTML and collects headings and links.
- **Site index** is the in-memory model of the whole site: all pages, tags, dates, URL map. Templates query it.
- **Template engine** renders each page with its layout.
- **Dependency graph** records which outputs depend on which inputs (a post, its template, the tag pages listing it), so an edit rebuilds only affected outputs.

Data model

Type	Fields
`Page`	source_path, url, title, date, tags, draft, template, html, toc, links_out
`Site`	pages_by_url, tags (dict tag to pages), config, build_time
`Config`	base_url, title, theme, permalink pattern
Dependency edge	output path to set of input paths

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Markdown	markdown-it-py	CommonMark compliant, plugins
Front matter	`tomllib` (TOML) or PyYAML	Structured metadata
Templates	Jinja	Inheritance, autoescape
Watching	`watchfiles`	Efficient change events
Serving	`http.server`	Good enough locally

Milestones

1. **One page.** Markdown plus front matter to HTML with a layout. *Done when* output validates and has the right title.
2. **Whole site.** Index, tag pages, pretty URLs, assets. *Done when* the site browses correctly from the output folder.
3. **Feeds and checks.** RSS, sitemap, broken-link checker. *Done when* a deliberately broken link fails the build.
4. **Serve and watch.** *Done when* saving a file refreshes the browser output within a second.
5. **Incremental builds.** *Done when* editing one post rebuilds only that post, its tag pages and the index.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Two-pass builds.** A page may link to another page's title or show "related posts", so you cannot render page A before every page is loaded. Pass 1 loads and parses everything into the site index. Pass 2 renders. This also lets you check links before writing output.
- **Escaping.** Markdown authors may write raw HTML, but data from front matter (titles, tags) must be escaped when inserted into templates or a title like `<script>` executes. Jinja's autoescape handles template variables; mark only the rendered Markdown body as safe.
- **Incremental correctness.** The danger of incremental builds is stale output — a tag page still listing a post whose tag was removed. Track dependencies conservatively (a change to any template rebuilds everything that uses it, a change to front matter rebuilds index and tag pages) and keep a `--clean` full build as the ground truth. Test that incremental output equals a clean build.

Testing strategy

Golden-file tests: a fixture site builds to an expected output folder (compare file trees). Unit tests for front matter parsing edge cases (no front matter, invalid date). A property: incremental build after random edits equals full build. Link checker tests with broken and valid links.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Static output cannot do per-user content or search on the server; client-side search with a prebuilt JSON index covers many sites. Rebuilding everything is simplest and often fast enough — incremental builds add complexity and stale-output bugs. Large image folders dominate build time, so cache processed images by content hash.

Stretch goals

- Syntax highlighting with Pygments and a table of contents.
- Client-side search index.
- Plugins via entry points (Project 14) for shortcodes.

Skills practised

- Ch 4 — Strings: text processing, slugs.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: walking folders, encodings.
- Ch 11 — Iterators, generators and functional tools: pipelines over pages.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `http.server`, `datetime`.

In the interview

Q: Why render in two passes? **A:** Pages reference each other, so you need the complete index before rendering any page, and you can validate links before writing.

Q: How do you prevent XSS in a static site generator? **A:** Autoescape all template variables and only mark trusted, already-rendered HTML as safe.

Q: How do you know an incremental build is correct? **A:** Compare it with a clean build in tests, and track dependencies conservatively.

TL;DR

Load everything, build a site index, render through templates, and track dependencies for fast rebuilds — a compact lesson in text pipelines and build systems.

14. Plugin system with entry points

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 1–2 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 8, Ch 10, Ch 13

What it is

A small host application — say, a CLI that converts data between formats — whose features come from **plugins**: separately installed packages that register themselves through **entry points**, a packaging standard where a package's `pyproject.toml` advertises named objects that other programs can discover at runtime with `importlib.metadata.entry_points()`. Installing `pip install myapp-yaml` adds YAML support without touching the host.

The problem it solves

Successful tools grow more features than one team can maintain. A plugin system lets others extend your tool safely, keeps the core small and lets users install only what they need. Designing one well teaches interfaces (what a plugin must provide), discovery, versioning and fault isolation.

Real-world examples

- The Python Packaging User Guide's Creating and discovering plugins compares naming conventions, namespace packages and entry points.
- pytest's plugin guide shows a large ecosystem built on entry points and hook specifications (via the `pluggy` library).
- The `importlib.metadata` documentation documents `entry_points(group=...)`.

Requirements

Functional

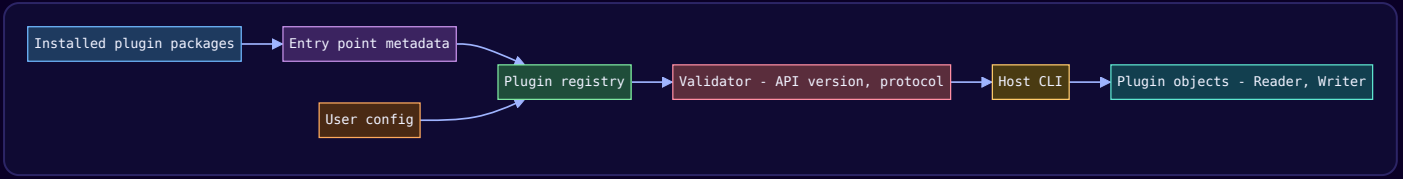
- Plugins provide readers and writers for formats, and optional CLI sub-commands.
- Discovery via the entry point group `convertkit.formats`. List installed plugins with versions.
- Plugins declare an API version. Incompatible ones are skipped with a warning.

- Users can disable a plugin via config. Built-in formats use the same mechanism.

Non-functional

- Discovery adds under 50 ms to start-up (load plugins lazily).
- A crashing plugin cannot crash the host at import time.
- The plugin interface is typed and checked by mypy.

The architecture



- **Entry point metadata** is written into each installed package's `entry_points.txt` at install time, so discovery reads small text files instead of importing code.
- **Plugin registry** lists entry points, but only loads (imports) a plugin when its format is needed — **lazy loading**.
- **Validator** checks the loaded object satisfies the `FormatPlugin` protocol and API version.
- **Host** asks the registry for "reader for .yaml" and calls it.

Data model

Type	Contents
`FormatPlugin` (Protocol)	`name`, `api_version`, `extensions`, `read(stream) -> Records`, `write(records, stream)`
`PluginInfo`	entry point name, value (`pkg.module:attr`), distribution name and version, loaded flag, error
Registry	`dict[str, PluginInfo]` keyed by format name
Config	disabled plugins, preferred plugin per extension

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Discovery	`importlib.metadata.entry_points`	Standard, no import needed to list
Interface	`typing.Protocol`	Structural typing, no inheritance required
Packaging	`pyproject.toml` `[project.entry-points."convertkit.formats"]`	Standard metadata
Hooks (stretch)	`pluggy`	Battle-tested hook calling

Milestones

1. **Protocol and built-ins.** Define `FormatPlugin`, implement CSV and JSON in the host. *Done when* conversion works with built-ins registered by hand.
2. **Entry point discovery.** Register built-ins through the host's own `pyproject.toml`. *Done when* listing shows them via metadata.
3. **External plugin.** A separate package `convertkit-yaml` in a sibling folder, installed in editable mode. *Done when* installing it adds the format with no host change.
4. **Validation and isolation.** *Done when* a plugin that raises on import or has the wrong API version is reported and skipped.
5. **Config and CLI extension.** *Done when* plugins can add sub-commands and users can disable them.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Lazy loading.** `entry_points()` returns `EntryPoint` objects with a `name` and `value` string; calling `.load()` imports the module. Listing is cheap, loading may be expensive. Load on first use, and cache the result. This keeps start-up fast even with dozens of plugins installed.
- **Versioning the plugin API.** Your interface will change. Give it an integer `API_VERSION`, accept a range, and add new optional methods rather than changing existing ones. Check `hasattr` or protocol membership at load time. Document a deprecation window.
- **Isolation limits.** Plugins run in your process with full power — a plugin can do anything your user can. Wrapping `load()` and calls in `try/except` stops a buggy plugin from crashing the host, but not a malicious one. True isolation needs separate processes or interpreters (Project 35).

Testing strategy

Create test plugin distributions in a temporary directory, or monkeypatch `entry_points` to return fake `EntryPoint` objects pointing to test modules. Test discovery, lazy loading (assert a module is not in `sys.modules` until used), bad plugins and version mismatches. Run mypy against the protocol and the example plugin.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Entry points need installation, so dropping a `.py` file in a folder will not work — a folder scan is friendlier for scripts but bypasses dependency management. Two plugins claiming the same format need a deterministic rule (config preference, then name). Plugins can pin conflicting dependencies; you cannot fix that inside the host.

Stretch goals

- Hook-based extension with `pluggy` (before-write, after-read hooks).
- A `plugins doctor` command checking versions and conflicts.
- A cookiecutter-style template for new plugins.

Skills practised

- Ch 8 — Modules, packages and environments: imports, `pyproject.toml`, editable installs.
- Ch 10 — OOP in Python: protocols and ABCs.
- Ch 13 — Type hints: `Protocol`, checking plugins with mypy.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: isolating failures.

In the interview

Q: How does a program find plugins installed by pip? **A:** Plugins declare entry points in their package metadata. The host calls `importlib.metadata.entry_points(group=...)` and loads the ones it needs.

Q: Why use `Protocol` instead of a base class? **A:** Plugins do not need to import or inherit from the host's class, which avoids version coupling, while type checkers still verify the shape.

Q: Can try/except make plugins safe? **A:** It contains bugs, not malice. Real isolation needs process boundaries or sandboxes.

TL;DR

Entry points give discovery without imports, a Protocol gives a typed contract, and lazy loading plus validation keeps the host fast and robust as the ecosystem grows.

15. Typed configuration loader

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 1–2 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 10, Ch 12, Ch 13

What it is

A library that loads application settings from several **layers** — built-in defaults, a TOML file, environment variables and command-line flags — and turns them into a typed, validated, immutable settings object defined by a plain dataclass. It reads the dataclass's type hints at runtime to know how to convert `"8080"` to `int`, `"true"` to `bool` and `"a,b"` to `list[str]`, using the `annotationlib` module that arrives with deferred annotations in Python 3.14 (PEP 649 and PEP 749).

The problem it solves

Configuration bugs cause many outages: a typo in a key silently ignored, a port read as a string, a secret printed in logs. A loader that validates everything at start-up and reports *all* errors at once, with where each value came from, turns those runtime surprises into immediate, clear failures.

Real-world examples

- pydantic-settings loads settings from environment variables and files into validated models — the established library for this job.
- The Twelve-Factor App on config argues for keeping deploy-specific config in environment variables.
- The `annotationlib` documentation explains the 3.14 formats (`VALUE`, `FORWARDREF`, `STRING`) for reading annotations safely.

Requirements

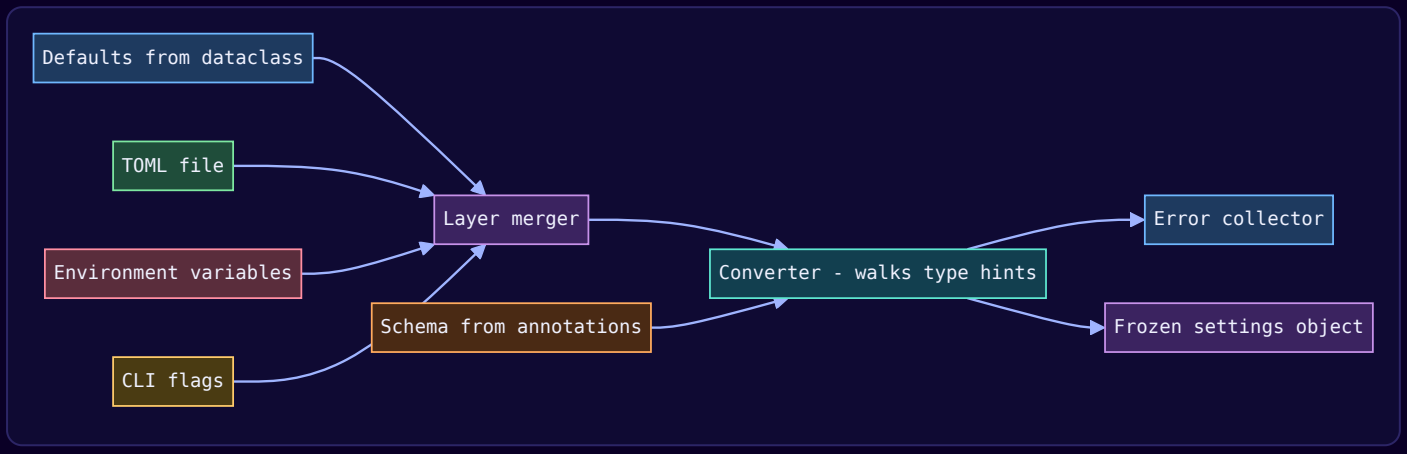
Functional

- Define settings as nested frozen dataclasses with defaults.
- Layers in precedence order: defaults < file < environment (`APP_DB__PORT=5433`) < CLI.
- Types: `str`, `int`, `float`, `bool`, `Path`, `Enum`, `Literal`, `list[T]`, `dict[str, T]`, `T | None`, nested dataclasses, and a `Secret[str]` wrapper that never prints its value.
- Collect all validation errors and report them together with the source of each value. Unknown keys are errors.
- `explain` command shows each final value and which layer set it.

Non-functional

- Loading takes under 20 ms for a 100-field config.
- Zero required dependencies beyond the standard library.
- Fully typed: `load(Settings)` returns `Settings` for the type checker.

The architecture



- **Schema from annotations** inspects the dataclass with `dataclasses.fields()` and `annotationlib.get_annotations()` to get the type of every field, recursing into nested dataclasses.
- **Layer merger** produces one nested dict, remembering the source of each leaf value (provenance).
- **Converter** walks the schema and converts each raw value according to its type, dispatching on `typing.get_origin()` and `get_args()` for generics like `list[int]`.

- **Error collector** gathers every failure with its dotted path (`db.port`) and source, raised together as one exception (or an `ExceptionGroup`).

Data model

Type	Purpose
`Settings` (user dataclass)	The target, e.g. `db: DbSettings`, `debug: bool = False`
`RawValue`	value, source (default / file:line / env:NAME / cli)
`FieldSpec`	path, type, default, required
`ConfigError`	path, message, source
`Secret[T]`	Wrapper with masked `__repr__` and a `.get()` method

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
File format	`tomllib`	Standard, typed values
Schema	`dataclasses`, `annotationlib` (3.14)	No dependency, safe annotation access
Generics	`typing.get_origin`, `get_args`	Inspect `list[int]`, unions
CLI	`argparse` generated from schema	One source of truth

Milestones

1. **Flat dataclass from TOML.** Convert basic types. *Done when* wrong types produce path-specific errors.
2. **Nesting and generics.** *Done when* nested dataclasses, lists, dicts, optionals and literals convert correctly.
3. **Layers and provenance.** *Done when* `explain` shows the source of every value, and env overrides file.
4. **All errors at once.** *Done when* a config with five mistakes reports all five.
5. **Secrets and CLI.** *Done when* `repr(settings)` never shows the password and `--db-port` overrides everything.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Deferred annotations in 3.14.** Before 3.14, annotations were evaluated when the class was defined, so referring to a class defined later needed quotes or `from __future__ import annotations` (which turned all annotations into strings). With PEP 649/749, annotations are evaluated lazily, on first access. `annotationlib.get_annotations(cls, format=Format.FORWARDREF)` returns real types where it can and `ForwardRef` placeholders where a name is not yet defined, instead of raising `NameError`. Your loader should use `Format.VALUE` at load time (by then everything is defined) and handle `ForwardRef` gracefully in error messages.
- **Unions and bool parsing.** Converting `"0"` to `bool` with `bool("0")` gives `True` — a classic bug. Accept an explicit set (`true/false/1/0/yes/no/on/off`). For `int | None`, decide what string means `None` (empty string, or the literal `null`). For unions of several types, try them in order and report all failures if none match.
- **Environment variable mapping.** Env vars are flat strings. A convention like `APP_DB__PORT` (double underscore for nesting) maps to `db.port`. Lists need a format: comma-separated or JSON. Be explicit and document it, because guessing causes surprises.

Testing strategy

Parametrized tests per type with valid and invalid raw values. Property-based tests: generate random settings values, serialise to TOML and env, load back, compare. Snapshot tests for error messages. A type-checking test: run mypy or pyright on an example using `load(Settings)` and assert the inferred type.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Writing your own loader teaches typing internals but pydantic-settings is more complete. Frozen settings prevent accidental mutation but make hot reload harder (you swap the whole object instead). Strict "unknown key is an error" catches typos but makes rolling upgrades harder when new config keys appear before the code — allow a warn-only mode.

Stretch goals

- Hot reload on file change with a callback that receives old and new settings.
- JSON Schema export for editor completion of the TOML file.
- Secret providers (read `Secret` values from files or a vault).

Skills practised

- Ch 13 — Type hints: generics, `get_origin` / `get_args`, `Literal`, deferred annotations.
- Ch 10 — OOP in Python: dataclasses, `__repr__`.
- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: introspection.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: `ExceptionGroup`, TOML.

In the interview

Q: What changed about annotations in Python 3.14? **A:** They are evaluated lazily (PEP 649/749). Forward references work without quotes, and the new `annotationlib` module can read annotations as values, forward references or strings.

Q: Why validate all config at start-up? **A:** Fail fast: a bad value found at start-up is a deploy error, while one found at 3 a.m. in a rarely used code path is an outage.

Q: How do you keep secrets out of logs? **A:** Wrap them in a type whose `__repr__` and `__str__` are masked, so accidental printing shows `***`.

TL;DR

Use dataclass type hints as the schema, merge layered sources with provenance, convert by walking the types, and report every error at once — a deep, practical tour of runtime typing in 3.14.

16. Publish a library to PyPI with uv

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 1 week · **Prerequisites:** Ch 8, Ch 13, Ch 15

What it is

Take a small useful library — for example the typed config loader (Project 15) or a slugify helper — and ship it properly: a `pyproject.toml`-based package with a `src/` layout, type information, tests across several Python versions, documentation, semantic versioning, a changelog, and automated publishing to **PyPI** (the Python Package Index, where `pip install` downloads from) using **uv**, a fast Python package and project manager, and **Trusted Publishing**, which lets a CI job upload without a stored password.

The problem it solves

Code on your laptop helps one person. A package anyone can `pip install` helps everyone, but publishing badly breaks people: missing files in the wheel, wrong Python version bounds, unpinned build tools, leaked API tokens. This project teaches the packaging pipeline that every professional Python developer eventually needs.

Real-world examples

- The Python Packaging User Guide's publishing with GitHub Actions guide walks through building and uploading from CI.
- The uv packaging guide covers `uv build` and `uv publish`.
- PyPI's Trusted Publishers documentation explains how short-lived OpenID Connect tokens from CI replace long-lived API tokens.

Requirements

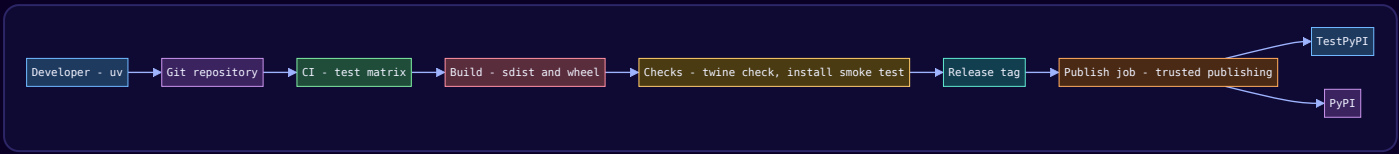
Functional

- `pyproject.toml` with name, version, description, readme, license, `requires-python`, dependencies, optional extras, classifiers and URLs.
- `src/` layout, a `py.typed` marker, a console script entry point if relevant.
- Build an sdist (source distribution) and a wheel (pre-built installable archive). Publish to TestPyPI, then PyPI, from a tagged release.
- Docs site and a changelog following "Keep a Changelog" style.

Non-functional

- CI tests on Python 3.12, 3.13 and 3.14 (plus 3.14t, the free-threaded build, as a bonus) on Linux, macOS and Windows.
- A fresh `pip install` of the wheel into a clean venv passes a smoke test.
- No secrets stored in the repository or CI settings for publishing.

The architecture



- **uv** manages the virtual environment, lock file and dev dependencies locally (`uv sync`, `uv run pytest`).
- **CI matrix** runs lint, type check and tests on every push.
- **Build** uses the build backend declared in `[build-system]` (for example hatchling or uv's own backend) to produce artifacts.
- **Checks** validate metadata rendering and install the built wheel in a clean environment — testing the artifact, not the source tree.
- **Publish job** runs only on version tags, with permission to request an OIDC token that PyPI trusts for this repository and workflow.

Data model

Artifact	Contents
`pyproject.toml`	`[build-system]`, `[project]`, `[project.optional-dependencies]`, `[project.scripts]`, tool configs
sdist (`.tar.gz`)	Source plus `PKG-INFO` metadata
Wheel (`.whl`)	Installable files plus `METADATA`, `RECORD`, `entry_points.txt`
`uv.lock`	Exact resolved dev environment (not shipped to users)
`CHANGELOG.md`	Human summary per version

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Env and tasks	uv	Fast installs, lock file, `uv build`, `uv publish`
Build backend	hatchling or uv_build	Standard PEP 517 backends
Tests	pytest, coverage	Standard
Types	mypy or pyright, `py.typed`	Ship type info
Lint and format	Ruff	One fast tool
Docs	MkDocs	Markdown docs

Milestones

1. **Local package.** `src/` layout, `pyproject.toml`, `uv sync`, tests pass. *Done when* `uv build` produces both artifacts.
2. **Artifact test.** *Done when* installing the wheel in a clean venv and importing it works, and the wheel contains `py.typed`.
3. **CI matrix.** *Done when* tests pass on three Python versions and three operating systems.
4. **TestPyPI release.** Configure trusted publishing. *Done when* `pip install -i https://test.pypi.org/simple/ yourpkg` works.
5. **Real release.** Tag `v1.0.0`, publish, docs live. *Done when* a stranger can install and follow the README.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Why `src/` layout.** With the package at the repository root, `import yourpkg` in tests imports the source folder from the current directory, not the installed package. Tests pass even when the wheel is missing files. Putting code under `src/` forces tests to use the installed version, catching packaging mistakes early.
- **Version bounds.** Libraries should declare **loose** dependency ranges (`httpx>=0.27`) so they can coexist with other libraries; applications pin exactly via lock files. Upper bounds like `<2` on dependencies often cause more harm than good because they block users from upgrading. Set `requires-python` honestly — pip uses it to pick a compatible version of your package.
- **Single source of version.** The version must match in metadata, the tag and the changelog. Either keep it only in `pyproject.toml` and read it at runtime with `importlib.metadata.version("yourpkg")`, or derive it from git tags with a plugin. Never hard-code it in two places.

Testing strategy

Unit tests as usual, plus **artifact tests**: build, install into a fresh venv, run a smoke script. Test the console script entry point by invoking it as a subprocess. Use `twine check` (or uv's checks) to validate metadata. Run the publish workflow against TestPyPI before the first real release.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Pure-Python wheels are universal (`py3-none-any`); C extensions need a wheel per platform and Python version, typically built with cibuildwheel. A version on PyPI can be yanked but never replaced, so a broken release must be fixed with a new version. Too-strict pins make your library uninstallable alongside others.

Stretch goals

- Automated changelog and version bump from conventional commits.
- Build provenance attestations.
- A free-threaded test job and a note in the README about thread safety.

Skills practised

- Ch 8 — Modules, packages and environments: `pyproject.toml`, venvs, uv, publishing.
- Ch 13 — Type hints: shipping `py.typed`.

- Ch 15 — Testing and debugging: CI test matrix.

In the interview

Q: What is the difference between an sdist and a wheel? **A:** An sdist is source that must be built on install. A wheel is a pre-built archive that is simply unpacked, faster and needs no build tools.

Q: Why the `src/` layout? **A:** It stops tests from importing the working copy by accident, so they exercise the installed package and catch missing files.

Q: How does trusted publishing work? **A:** PyPI is configured to trust a specific CI workflow. The job gets a short-lived OIDC token from the CI provider, exchanges it for a temporary upload token, and no long-lived secret exists.

TL;DR

Ship a small library the professional way: `src/` layout, honest metadata, artifact tests on a version matrix, and tag-triggered publishing through uv and trusted publishing.

17. Resilient HTTP client library

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 1–2 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 7, Ch 12, Ch 16

What it is

A thin library on top of `httpx` that makes calls to unreliable web services safe: **timeouts** on everything, **retries** with exponential backoff and jitter for transient failures, a client-side **rate limiter** (token bucket), a **circuit breaker** that stops calling a service that is clearly down, and structured logging of every attempt. It works in both sync and async code, exposed as decorators and a client wrapper.

The problem it solves

Networks fail in small ways all the time: a dropped connection, a 503 during a deploy, a 429 "slow down". Naive code either crashes on the first error or retries in a tight loop, making outages worse for everyone. Production systems survive by retrying carefully and failing fast when retrying will not help. These patterns appear in almost every backend interview.

Real-world examples

- AWS's architecture blog post Exponential Backoff and Jitter shows with simulations why adding randomness to retry delays reduces load and completion time.
- httpx provides the transports and timeouts this library builds on.
- stripe-python retries network errors with backoff and sends idempotency keys so retried writes are safe — a real-world reference for the API design.

Requirements

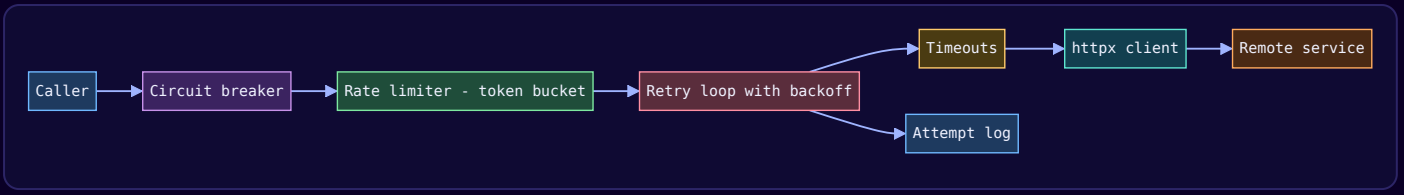
Functional

- Configurable per-call timeouts (connect, read, total).
- Retry policy: which exceptions and status codes are retryable, maximum attempts, base and cap delay, full jitter, honouring `Retry-After`.
- Retries only for idempotent methods (GET, PUT, DELETE) unless the caller supplies an idempotency key.
- Token-bucket rate limiter per host. Circuit breaker per host with closed, open and half-open states.
- Sync and async APIs with the same configuration.

Non-functional

- Overhead per successful call under 0.2 ms.
- Thread-safe and task-safe state (limiter and breaker shared across threads or tasks).
- Every attempt logged with attempt number, delay and reason.

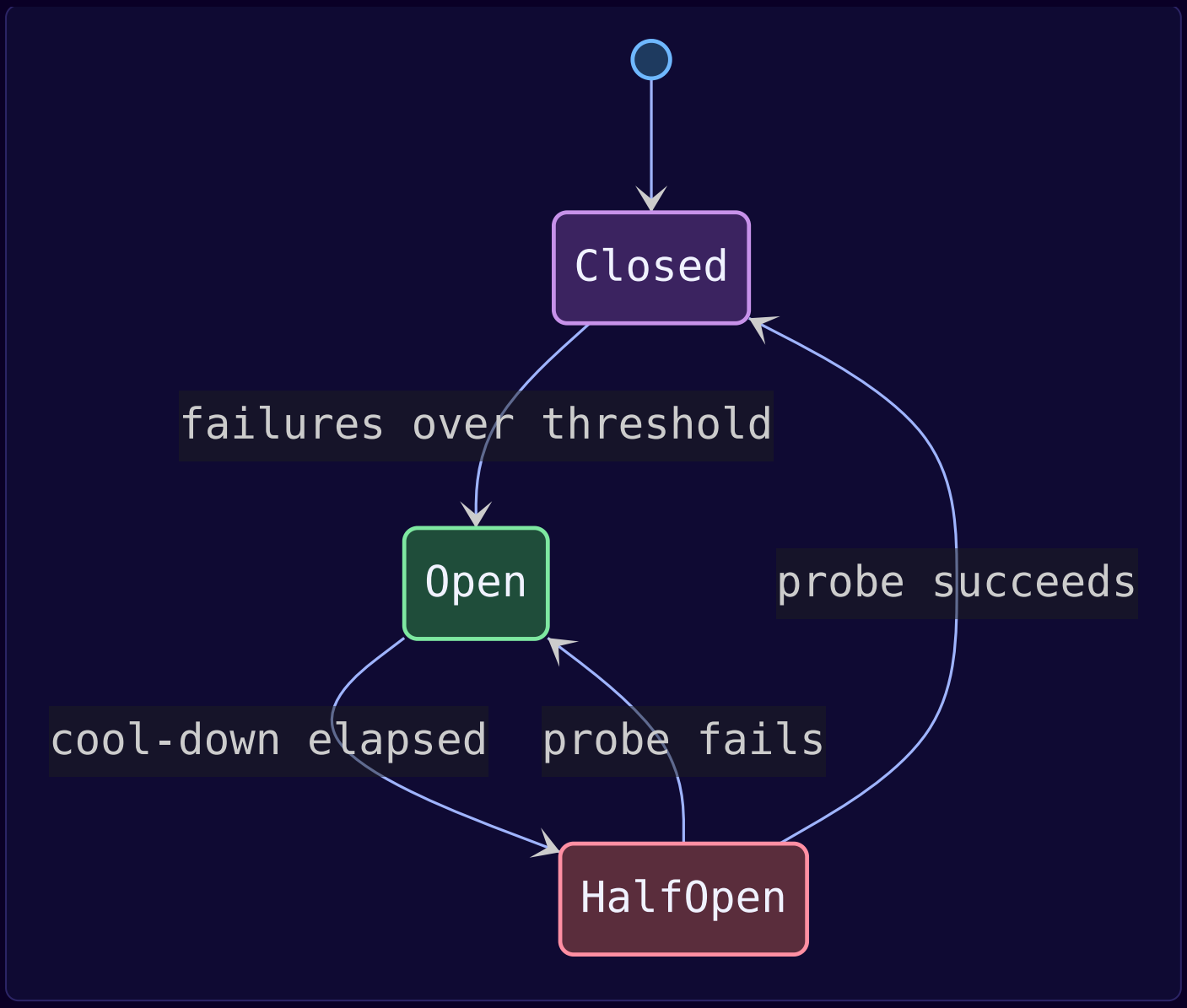
The architecture



- **Circuit breaker** fails immediately with `CircuitOpen` when recent calls mostly failed, protecting both caller and service.
- **Rate limiter** waits (or fails) until a token is available, keeping you under the service's limit.
- **Retry loop** classifies each failure, sleeps with jittered backoff and tries again up to the limit.
- **Timeouts** bound every network wait.
- **Attempt log** emits structured events for observability.

Data model

Type	Fields
`RetryPolicy`	max_attempts, base_delay, max_delay, retry_on_status, retry_on_exceptions, respect_retry_after
`TokenBucket`	capacity, refill_rate, tokens, last_refill
`CircuitBreaker`	state, failure_count, window, open_until, half_open_probes
`Attempt`	number, started_at, outcome, status, delay_before_next



Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
HTTP	httpx (sync and async clients)	Same API in both worlds
Clock	`time.monotonic`	Not affected by system clock changes
Sync locking	`threading.Lock`	Shared limiter across threads
Async waiting	`asyncio.sleep`, `asyncio.Lock`	Non-blocking delays
Decorators	`functools.wraps`	Preserve function metadata

Milestones

1. **Timeouts and classification.** *Done when* every failure is classified as retryable or not, with tests for each status and exception.
2. **Retries with jitter.** *Done when* delays follow `random.uniform(0, min(cap, base * 2**attempt))` and `Retry-After` overrides them.
3. **Token bucket.** *Done when* 1,000 calls at 10 per second take about 100 seconds of simulated time.
4. **Circuit breaker.** *Done when* the state machine passes tests for every transition.
5. **Async parity and decorators.** *Done when* `@resilient(policy)` works on both `def` and `async def` functions.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Why jitter.** If 1,000 clients fail at the same moment and all retry after exactly 1, 2, 4 seconds, they hit the recovering service in synchronised waves. **Full jitter** (a random delay between 0 and the exponential cap) spreads them out. The AWS post shows it cuts total work significantly.
- **Idempotency.** Retrying a POST that timed out may create a second order if the first actually succeeded. Only retry non-idempotent requests when the server supports an **idempotency key** — a unique id sent with the request so the server can recognise and ignore duplicates.
- **Time and testing.** Real sleeps make tests slow and flaky. Inject a clock and a sleep function. Tests then advance a fake clock instantly and assert on the exact delays requested.
- **One decorator for sync and async.** Detect coroutine functions with `inspect.iscoroutinefunction` and return an `async def` wrapper for them, a plain wrapper otherwise. Share the policy logic in pure functions so the two wrappers differ only in how they sleep.

Testing strategy

`httpx.MockTransport` to script responses (two 503s then 200, a 429 with `Retry-After: 3`). Fake clock for limiter and breaker. Concurrency test: 50 threads sharing a limiter never exceed the rate. Property test: delays are always within bounds.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Retries multiply load: three retries at each of four layers can turn one request into 4^4 = 256 calls (**retry amplification**). Retry at one layer only, and use a total deadline. Client-side rate limits are per process; across many processes you need a shared limiter (Redis) or server feedback. Circuit breakers need tuning — too sensitive and they open on noise.

Stretch goals

- Retry budgets (retries limited to a percentage of recent calls).
- Hedged requests: send a second request if the first is slow, use whichever returns first.
- OpenTelemetry spans per attempt.

Skills practised

- Ch 7 — Functions: closures and higher-order functions.
- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: parametrised decorators.
- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: locks, async sleeps, thread safety.
- Ch 15 — Testing and debugging: fake clocks and mock transports.

In the interview

Q: Which errors should you retry? **A:** Transient ones: connection errors, timeouts, 502/503/504 and 429 (after the indicated delay). Not 400, 401, 403 or 404 — retrying will not change the answer.

Q: What is a circuit breaker? **A:** A state machine that stops calls to a failing dependency for a cool-down period, then lets a probe through to test recovery.

Q: Why add jitter to backoff? **A:** To de-synchronise clients so retries do not arrive in waves that knock the service over again.

TL;DR

Timeouts, classified retries with jittered backoff, idempotency, a token bucket and a circuit breaker — packaged as one decorator that works for sync and async code.

18. Async chat server

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 2 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 9, Ch 16

What it is

A multi-room chat server built directly on `asyncio` streams (TCP sockets wrapped as `StreamReader` / `StreamWriter`), with a simple line-based text protocol inspired by IRC: `/nick alice`, `/join #python`, `/msg bob hi`, plain lines go to the current room. Clients can be `telnet`, `nc` or a small Python client you write. Later you add a WebSocket gateway so a browser can join too.

The problem it solves

Real-time systems — chat, games, live dashboards, trading — must hold many long-lived connections and push messages to them. Doing this with one thread per connection works but scales poorly. An asyncio server handles thousands of idle connections in one thread. The project teaches protocol design, broadcast fan-out, slow-consumer handling and graceful shutdown.

Real-world examples

- RFC 1459 defines the original Internet Relay Chat protocol: nicknames, channels, line-based commands.
- The asyncio streams documentation shows `start_server`, `readline`, `drain` and closing.

Requirements

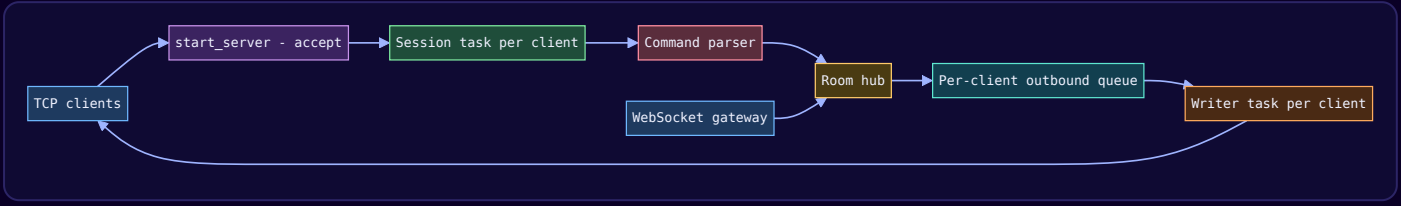
Functional

- Commands: `/nick`, `/join`, `/part`, `/msg`, `/who`, `/rooms`, `/quit`. Plain text broadcasts to the room.
- Unique nicknames, room membership, join and leave notices.
- Message history: the last 50 messages of a room on join.
- Optional WebSocket bridge sharing the same rooms.

Non-functional

- 5,000 concurrent idle connections on one process with under 200 MB of memory.
- Broadcast latency under 50 ms at 1,000 messages per second.
- A slow client must never delay others. Maximum line length 4 KB.

The architecture



- **Session task** reads lines from one client, parses commands and calls the hub.
- **Room hub** owns state: nick to session, room to members, room history. Because asyncio runs one task at a time between `await`s, hub methods that do not `await` need no locks.
- **Per-client outbound queue** decouples broadcasting from slow sockets: the hub puts messages on each member's bounded queue, and a **writer task** per client drains it to the socket.
- **WebSocket gateway** (stretch) adapts browser connections to the same session interface.

Data model

Type	Fields
`Session`	id, nick, reader, writer, outbound (`asyncio.Queue`), rooms (set), connected_at
`Room`	name, members (set of session ids), history (`deque(maxlen=50)`)
`Message`	ts, room, sender, text, kind (chat, notice, private)
`Hub`	sessions_by_nick, rooms

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Networking	`asyncio.start_server`	Streams API, built in
Structure	`TaskGroup` per session (reader plus writer)	Cancels both together
Buffers	`asyncio.Queue(maxsize=...)`	Backpressure per client
History	`collections.deque(maxlen=50)`	Bounded ring buffer
WebSockets	`websockets` library (stretch)	Mature asyncio implementation

Milestones

1. **Echo server.** *Done when* several `nc` clients connect and get their lines echoed.
2. **Nicknames and one room.** *Done when* messages broadcast to everyone else with nick prefixes.
3. **Rooms, private messages, history.** *Done when* all commands work and history replays on join.
4. **Slow consumers and limits.** *Done when* a client that stops reading is disconnected after its queue fills, without affecting others.
5. **Graceful shutdown and load test.** *Done when* Ctrl-C sends a goodbye to every client and a load script holds 5,000 connections.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Slow consumers.** `writer.write()` only buffers; `await writer.drain()` waits until the OS buffer has room. If the hub awaited `drain()` for each member during a broadcast, one stalled client would freeze the room. With per-client bounded queues, the hub uses `put_nowait` and, on `QueueFull`, disconnects (or drops messages for) that client. Choose and document the policy.
- **Framing and limits.** TCP is a byte stream, not messages. Line-based framing uses `readline()`, which by default raises if a line exceeds the stream limit (64 KiB) — set a smaller `limit` in `start_server` and handle `LimitOverrunError` and `IncompleteReadError` (client disconnected mid-line).
- **Cleanup on every exit path.** A session can end by `/quit`, network error, server shutdown or cancellation. Put the leave-rooms and release-nick logic in `finally` so state never keeps ghosts. Remember `CancelledError` is a `BaseException` in modern Python — do not swallow it with `except Exception` hopes, and re-raise it after cleanup.

Testing strategy

Start the server on port 0 (the OS picks a free port) inside the test, connect real client streams with `asyncio.open_connection`, and assert on received lines with timeouts. Test the hub separately with fake sessions. A slow-consumer test: a client that never reads must be disconnected while others keep receiving.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

One process holds all state, so it is a single point of failure and cannot scale horizontally. To scale out, put a pub/sub broker (Redis, NATS) between servers so rooms span processes. Line protocols are easy to debug but need escaping rules. History in memory disappears on restart; persist to SQLite or PostgreSQL if it matters.

Stretch goals

- TLS with `ssl.SSLContext`.
- WebSocket gateway and a tiny HTML client.
- Multi-process scaling with Redis pub/sub.

Skills practised

- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: streams, tasks, queues, cancellation, `TaskGroup`.
- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: `deque`, sets for membership.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: `finally` cleanup, exception groups.

In the interview

Q: Why do hub methods not need locks in asyncio? **A:** Only one task runs at a time and switches happen only at `await`. A method with no `await` runs atomically with respect to other tasks.

Q: How do you stop one slow client slowing everyone? **A:** Give each client a bounded outbound queue and a writer task. Broadcasting never awaits a socket, and full queues trigger a disconnect or drop.

Q: How would you scale to several servers? **A:** Make servers stateless with respect to rooms by publishing messages to a shared broker and subscribing per room.

TL;DR

One task pair per connection, a lock-free hub and bounded per-client queues give a fast, fair chat server — and a clear lesson in backpressure and cleanup.

19. Safe templating with t-strings

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 1–2 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 4, Ch 10, Ch 13

What it is

A small library of **template processors** built on Python 3.14's **template strings** (t-strings, PEP 750). A t-string looks like an f-string with a `t` prefix — `t"SELECT * FROM users WHERE name = {name}"` — but instead of producing a `str` it produces a `string.templatelib.Template` object that keeps the literal text parts and the interpolated values *separate*. Your library provides `html(t"...")` that escapes values safely, `sql(t"...")` that turns interpolations into database parameters, and `shell(t"...")` that quotes arguments.

The problem it solves

f-strings are so convenient that developers use them to build SQL, HTML and shell commands — producing SQL injection, cross-site scripting (XSS) and command injection bugs. The fix has always been "use parameters or escaping", which is easy to forget. t-strings let a library see which parts the programmer wrote and which came from values, so the safe path is also the convenient one.

Real-world examples

- PEP 750 specifies template strings, with motivating examples of HTML and SQL processing.
- The `string.templatelib` documentation defines `Template`, `Interpolation` (with `value`, `expression`, `conversion` and `format_spec`) and iteration over parts.
- Jinja shows the established approach to safe HTML: autoescaping plus an explicit "markup is safe" type.

Requirements

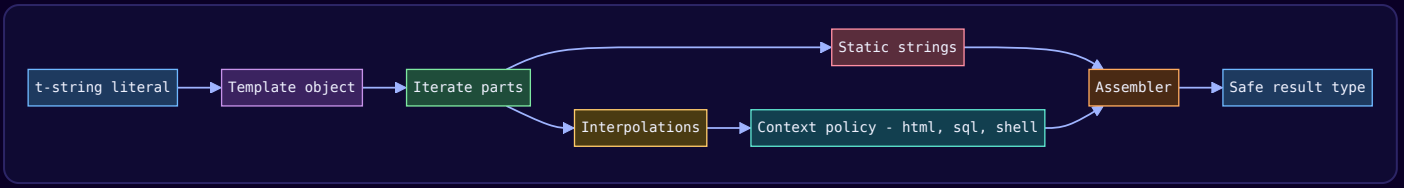
Functional

- `html(template) -> Markup`: escape every interpolated value unless it is already `Markup`. Support nested templates and lists of templates.
- `sql(template) -> (query, params)`: replace each interpolation with a placeholder (`%s` or `?`) and collect values. Allow identifiers only through an explicit `Identifier` wrapper that is validated and quoted.
- `shell(template) -> list[str]`: build an argument list with values as single arguments, never re-parsed by a shell.
- Honour format specs (`{price:.2f}`) and conversions (`{x!r}`) where it makes sense.

Non-functional

- Processing a template with 20 interpolations under 20 microseconds.
- No way to produce unsafe output without an explicit opt-in type.
- Fully typed, with a mypy test that passing a plain `str` to `sql()` is a type error.

The architecture



- **Template object**: Python evaluates the interpolated expressions eagerly (like an f-string) but does not join them. `template.strings` holds the literal parts and `template.interpolations` the values.
- **Context policy** decides what to do with each value for the target language: escape for HTML, parametrise for SQL, keep as one argument for shell.
- **Assembler** walks the parts in order and builds the output.
- **Safe result types** (`Markup`, `SqlQuery`, `Argv`) record that the output has been processed, so processors can compose without double-escaping.

Data model

Type	Role
`Template` (stdlib)	`strings: tuple[str, ...]`, `interpolations: tuple[Interpolation, ...]`, iterable
`Interpolation` (stdlib)	`value`, `expression` (source text), `conversion`, `format_spec`
`Markup(str)`	Already-safe HTML
`SqlQuery`	text with placeholders, params tuple
`Identifier`	Validated SQL identifier wrapper

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Templates	`string.templatelib` (3.14)	New standard type
Escaping	`html.escape`	Correct for text and attribute contexts
Shell	`shlex.quote` / argument lists	No shell parsing
DB test	`sqlite3`	Verify placeholders really work
Typing	mypy or pyright	Enforce `Template` not `str`

Milestones

1. **Explore.** Print parts of several t-strings. *Done when* you can explain `strings`, `interpolations` and iteration order, including why `strings` always has one more item than `interpolations` (empty strings fill the gaps) while iteration skips empty strings.
2. **HTML.** *Done when* `html(t"<p>{user_input}</p>")` escapes `<script>` and `Markup` passes through unchanged.
3. **SQL.** *Done when* `sql(t"... WHERE name = {name}")` runs against SQLite with injection attempts failing harmlessly.
4. **Shell and formats.** *Done when* a filename with spaces and quotes is passed as one argument, and format specs apply.
5. **Typing and composition.** *Done when* nested templates work and mypy rejects `sql("SELECT " + x)`.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **What t-strings are not.** A `Template` has no built-in render method that joins it into the final text. That is intentional: something must decide how each value is treated. Values are evaluated eagerly when the t-string runs, exactly like f-strings, so t-strings are not lazy templates you fill in later.
- **Context matters in HTML.** Escaping `<`, `>`, `&`, and quotes is correct for element text and quoted attributes but not for URLs (`href="javascript:..."`), inline scripts or CSS. A small library should refuse

interpolation inside `<script>` or event-handler attributes, or require explicit wrappers. Be honest in docs about what contexts you support.

- **SQL identifiers vs values.** Placeholders work only for values, never for table or column names. Allow identifiers only through `Identifier("users")`, validated against a strict pattern and quoted with double quotes. This keeps "dynamic column" features possible without reopening injection.
- **Typing as a guard rail.** Annotate processors as accepting `Template`, not `str`. A type checker then flags `sql(f"...")` — the exact mistake t-strings exist to prevent.

Testing strategy

Table tests of malicious inputs per context (OWASP-style XSS strings, SQL injection strings, shell metacharacters). Round-trip SQL tests against SQLite. Property tests: for any string value, `html()` output never contains an unescaped `<` from that value. Type-check tests with mypy in CI.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

t-strings need Python 3.14, so libraries supporting older versions must keep another API. A tiny homemade HTML escaper is not a full templating engine — for full pages Jinja is still the better tool; t-strings shine for small fragments and SQL. Contextual escaping bugs are subtle, so keep the supported contexts narrow.

Stretch goals

- An HTML processor that parses the static parts to know the context of each interpolation.
- A structured-logging processor that records both the message template and the values (see Project 20).
- Benchmarks against f-strings plus manual escaping.

Skills practised

- Ch 4 — Strings: f-strings, format specs, escaping.
- Ch 10 — OOP in Python: `str` subclasses, dunder methods.
- Ch 13 — Type hints: using types to block unsafe calls.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `html`, `shlex`, `sqlite3`.

In the interview

Q: What is the difference between an f-string and a t-string? **A:** Both evaluate expressions immediately. An f-string joins everything into a `str`. A t-string returns a `Template` with literal parts and values kept separate, so a function can process values safely.

Q: Why does that help with SQL injection? **A:** The processor knows exactly which parts are values and can send them as parameters instead of splicing them into the SQL text.

Q: Can you parametrise a table name? **A:** No — placeholders are for values. Use a validated identifier wrapper and quoting.

TL;DR

PEP 750 t-strings keep code and data apart until a processor decides how to combine them, letting you build HTML, SQL and shell helpers where the safe way is the easy way.

20. Structured logging library

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 1–2 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 12, Ch 14

What it is

A logging library that emits **structured logs** — each event is a set of key/value fields (`event="order_paid" order_id=42 amount=19.99 duration_ms=31`) rendered as JSON in production and as colourful readable lines in development. It adds **context propagation** (a request id set once appears on every log line in that request, even across `await`s), processors (redaction, sampling, timestamps) and integration with the standard `logging` module.

The problem it solves

Plain text logs like `"Payment for order 42 took 31ms"` are easy to write and hard to query. At scale, logs go to search systems where you filter by fields: all errors for `order_id=42`, p95 of `duration_ms` per endpoint. Structured logging, plus correlation ids, makes logs data. Building the library teaches context variables, decorators, processors as function pipelines and how `logging` works inside.

Real-world examples

- structlog is a widely used Python structured-logging library built around processor chains and context binding.
- OpenTelemetry for Python standardises traces, metrics and logs, including correlating logs with trace and span ids.

Requirements

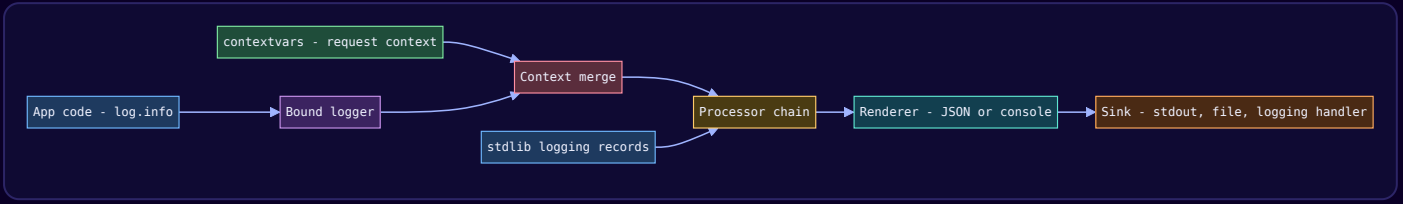
Functional

- `log = get_logger(); log.info("order_paid", order_id=42)`. Bind context: `log = log.bind(user_id=7)`.
- Request-scoped context via `contextvars` that works across threads and asyncio tasks.
- Processor chain: add timestamp, level, logger name, caller info, redact keys like `password` or `token`, sample debug logs, render JSON or console.
- Bridge: records from the standard `logging` module go through the same processors.
- `@log_call` decorator logging entry, exit, duration and exceptions.

Non-functional

- Under 10 microseconds per event when the level is disabled, under 50 when enabled with JSON rendering.
- Never raise from a logging call. Rendering errors are reported once to stderr.
- Thread-safe output (no interleaved lines).

The architecture



- **Bound logger** is an immutable object holding bound key/values. `bind()` returns a new logger, so passing loggers between functions is safe.
- **Context merge** combines the `contextvars` dict (request id, user id) with bound values and call arguments.
- **Processor chain** is a list of functions `(logger, method, event_dict) -> event_dict`. Each adds, removes or transforms fields. Raising a special `DropEvent` stops the chain (sampling).
- **Renderer** is the last processor, turning the dict into a string.
- **Sink** writes it.

Data model

Type	Contents
Event dict	`{"event": str, "level": str, "timestamp": str, ...fields}`
`BoundLogger`	processors, bound context (immutable mapping), sink
Context var	`ContextVar[dict]` for request-scoped fields
Config	processor list, minimum level, renderer choice

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Context	`contextvars`	Correct per-task and per-thread isolation
Integration	`logging.Handler`, `logging.Formatter`	Capture third-party logs
JSON	`json` with a `default=` fallback	Never fail on unknown types
Decorators	`functools.wraps`, `inspect`	Sync and async `@log_call`
Time	`time.time_ns`, `datetime.isoformat`	Precise timestamps

Milestones

1. **Event dicts and JSON.** *Done when* `log.info("x", a=1)` prints one valid JSON line.
2. **Bind and processors.** *Done when* redaction and timestamp processors work and the chain is configurable.
3. **Context propagation.** *Done when* two concurrent asyncio tasks each log their own request id on every line.
4. **stdlib bridge.** *Done when* a `logging.getLogger("urllib3").warning(...)` appears as structured JSON.
5. **Decorator and performance.** *Done when* `@log_call` works on sync and async functions and benchmarks meet targets.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Why `contextvars`, not thread-locals.** A thread-local is shared by all asyncio tasks on the same thread, so two concurrent requests would overwrite each other's request id. A `ContextVar` is copied into each task when it is created, so each task sees its own values. Set it in middleware at request start and reset it with the token returned by `set()` at the end.
- **Cheap when disabled.** Most debug logs are filtered out. Check the level *before* building the event dict, merging context or formatting anything. Avoid formatting values eagerly in call sites — pass them as fields and let the renderer do the work only if needed.
- **Never crash the app.** A field holding an unserialisable object (a socket, a custom class) would make `json.dumps` raise. Use `default=repr` as a fallback, wrap the whole chain in `try/except`, and on failure write a minimal line with the error. A logging library that can bring the app down is worse than none.

Testing strategy

Capture sink output in tests and parse JSON lines to assert fields. Test context isolation with `asyncio.gather` on several tasks and with a thread pool. Test redaction with nested dicts. Microbenchmark disabled and enabled paths with `timeit`. Test that a broken processor does not raise into application code.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

JSON logs are verbose; at high volume, sampling and level control matter more than speed. Too many fields per event increase cost in log storage systems that charge per gigabyte. Logging personal data creates legal risk — redaction should be a default, not an afterthought. Synchronous writes to a slow disk or network block the app; a queue handler with a background thread decouples them.

Stretch goals

- Queue-based async sink using `logging.handlers.QueueHandler`.
- Trace and span ids from OpenTelemetry automatically added.
- A t-string message processor that records both the template text and the values (Project 19).

Skills practised

- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: decorators for sync and async functions, context managers for scoped context.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `logging` internals, `json`.
- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: `contextvars` across tasks and threads.
- Ch 7 — Functions: processors as composable functions.

In the interview

Q: What is structured logging and why use it? **A:** Logging events as key/value data instead of free text, so logs can be filtered, aggregated and correlated by field.

Q: How do you attach a request id to every log line in an async app? **A:** Set it in a `ContextVar` at the start of the request. Each asyncio task gets its own copy of the context, so concurrent requests do not mix.

Q: How do you keep logging cheap? **A:** Check the level first, pass values as fields rather than pre-formatted strings, and move I/O to a background thread if needed.

TL;DR

Events as dicts, a processor pipeline, immutable bound loggers and `contextvars` for request context — the design behind modern Python logging, built and benchmarked yourself.

21. Mini Git

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 2–3 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 6, Ch 9, Ch 14

What it is

A minimal version-control system, `pygit`, that implements Git's core ideas: `init`, `add`, `commit`, `log`, `status`, `diff`, `branch`, `checkout` and a simple three-way `merge`. It stores data the way Git does — **blobs** (file contents), **trees** (directory listings) and **commits** (a tree plus parents, author and message), each named by the hash of its content and compressed with zlib.

The problem it solves

Every developer uses Git, few understand it, and confusion about "detached HEAD" or "what a branch actually is" costs real time. Rebuilding the core shows that Git is a simple content-addressed object database plus a few movable pointers. It also teaches hashing, tree structures, graph traversal and diff algorithms in one project.

Real-world examples

- *Pro Git*'s chapter Git Internals — Git Objects describes blobs, trees, commits, object headers and zlib storage.
- The `difflib` documentation provides unified diffs you can use before writing your own diff.

Requirements

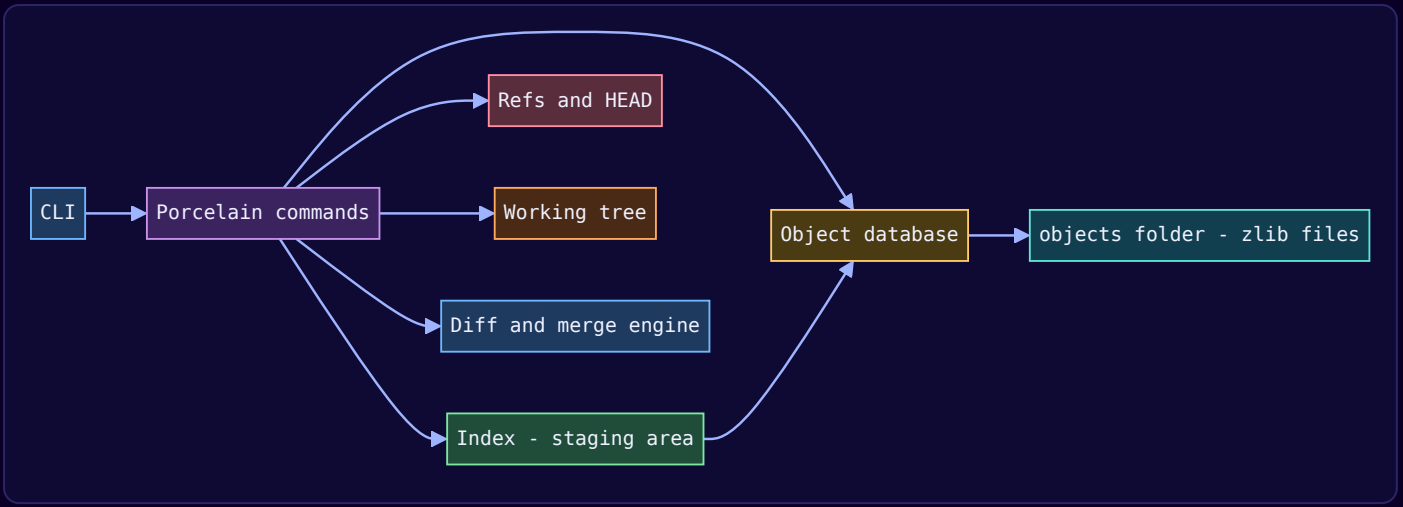
Functional

- `init` creates `.pygit/` with `objects/`, `refs/heads/` and `HEAD`.
- `add` writes blobs and updates an index (staging area). `commit` writes trees and a commit and moves the branch.
- `log` follows parents. `status` compares working tree, index and HEAD. `diff` shows unified diffs.
- `branch` and `checkout` (refuse to overwrite uncommitted changes). `merge` with fast-forward and three-way merge with conflict markers.

Non-functional

- Object ids are SHA-1 of `"<type> <size>\0" + content`, so a blob's id matches what real Git computes for the same content (a good test).
- `status` on 10,000 files under 1 second when nothing changed (use cached stat data in the index).
- Repository corruption is detectable: every object's hash can be re-verified.

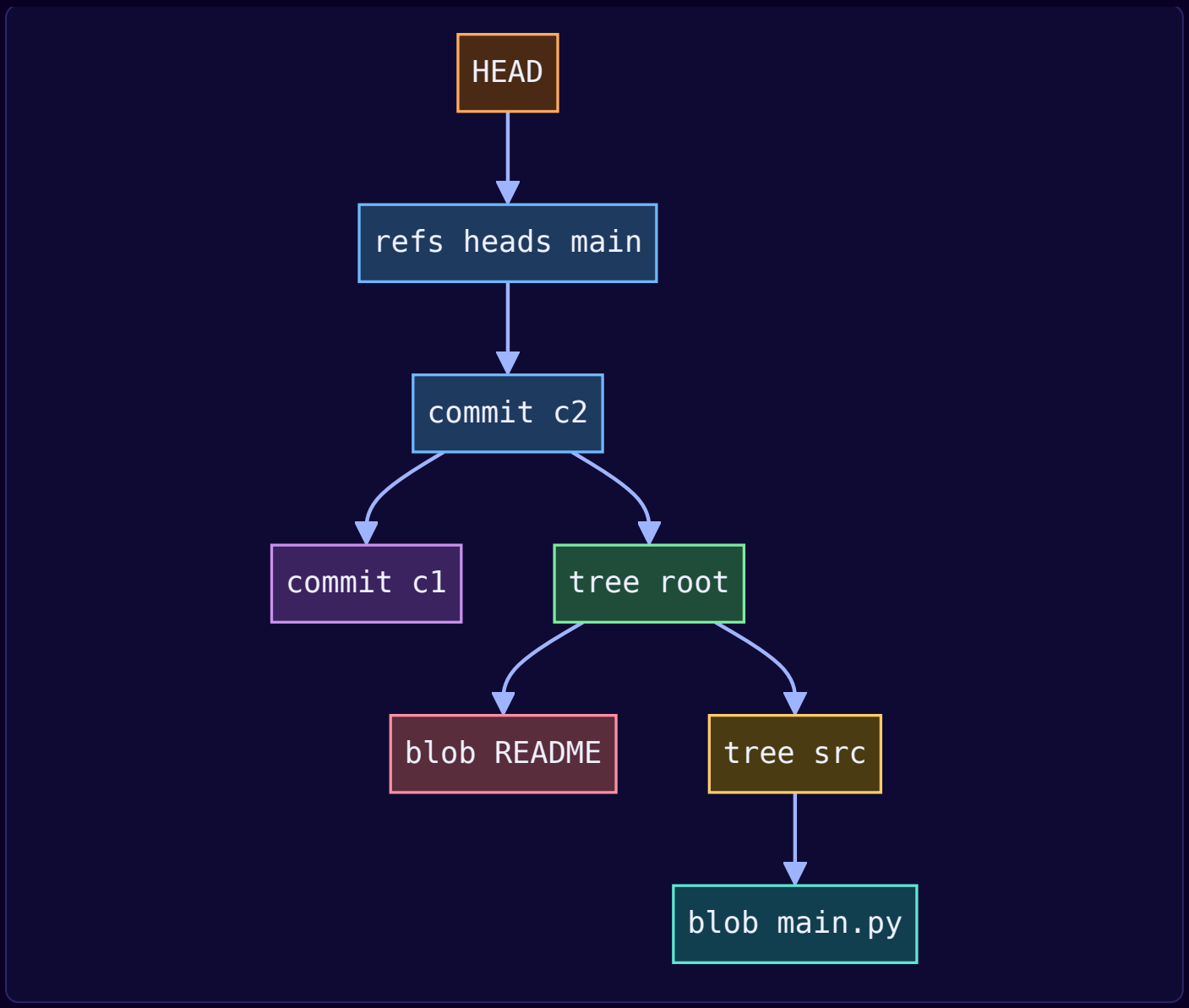
The architecture



- **Object database** stores and loads objects by id. Path: `objects/ab/cdef...` (first two hex chars as folder).
- **Refs** are tiny files holding a commit id (`refs/heads/main`). `HEAD` holds either `ref: refs/heads/main` or, when detached, a commit id directly.
- **Index** lists staged paths with blob id and cached size and mtime — the snapshot that the next commit will record.
- **Porcelain commands** (Git's word for user-facing commands) combine these.
- **Diff and merge engine** compares trees and files.

Data model

Object	Content
Blob	Raw file bytes
Tree	Sorted entries: mode, name, object id (blob or subtree)
Commit	tree id, parent ids, author, committer, timestamp, message
Ref	File with a commit id
Index entry	path, blob id, size, mtime_ns, mode



Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Hashing	`hashlib.sha1`	Same ids as Git's default format
Compression	`zlib`	Git's object compression
Diff	`difflib` first, then Myers diff yourself	Learn the algorithm
Files	`pathlib`, `os.stat`	Working tree scan

Milestones

1. **Objects.** `hash-object` and `cat-file`. *Done when* your blob id for a file equals `git hash-object file`.
2. **Commit.** Index, trees, commits, refs. *Done when* `log` shows a chain of commits.
3. **Status and diff.** *Done when* status correctly reports staged, unstaged and untracked files.
4. **Branches and checkout.** *Done when* switching branches rewrites the working tree and refuses when it would lose changes.
5. **Merge.** Fast-forward and three-way. *Done when* a conflicting merge writes conflict markers and a non-conflicting one creates a merge commit with two parents.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Trees are recursive hashes.** A tree's id depends on its entries' ids, which depend on their contents. Changing one file changes its blob, its parent tree, every tree up to the root and therefore the commit. Unchanged subtrees keep their ids and are shared between commits — that is why Git snapshots are cheap. Sort entries consistently or the same directory gets different ids.
- **Three-way merge.** Find the **merge base** (the nearest common ancestor of both branch tips) with a breadth-first search over parents. For each file: if only one side changed it relative to the base, take that side. If both changed it identically, take it. Otherwise merge line by line, and mark overlapping changes as conflicts.
- **Fast status.** Hashing every file on every `status` is slow. The index caches size and mtime: if they match the file on disk, assume unchanged. Git has extra protection for files modified in the same second as the index was written ("racy" entries) — re-hash those.
- **Diff algorithm.** The **Myers algorithm** finds the shortest edit script between two sequences by exploring diagonals in an edit graph. Implement it once — it is a great dynamic-programming exercise — then compare with `difflib`, which uses a different heuristic matcher.

Testing strategy

Interoperability tests: compare blob ids with real `git hash-object`. Scenario tests in temp folders: commit, branch, modify, merge, check working tree contents. Property test: committing then checking out any commit reproduces exactly the committed files. Corruption tests: modify an object file and verify detection.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Loose objects (one file each) are simple but waste space; Git packs them into packfiles with delta compression. SHA-1 has known collision attacks; Git supports SHA-256 repositories. No locking means two concurrent commands can corrupt refs — write refs atomically via temp file and rename, as Git does with lock files.

Stretch goals

- Read real Git loose objects and show `log` of a real repository.
- Packfiles with delta compression.
- `push` and `pull` between two local repositories by copying missing objects.

Skills practised

- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: binary files, atomic writes.
- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: object caches, sets of visited commits.
- Ch 19 — Python for coding interviews: BFS for merge bases, DP for diff.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `hashlib`, `zlib`, `difflib`.

In the interview

Q: What is a Git branch? **A:** A file containing a commit id. Committing writes a new commit whose parent is that id and moves the pointer.

Q: Why are Git snapshots cheap if each commit stores the whole tree? **A:** Objects are content-addressed, so unchanged files and subtrees have the same ids and are stored once and shared.

Q: How does a three-way merge decide what to keep? **A:** It compares each side with the common ancestor. Changes made on only one side win automatically. Overlapping different changes are conflicts.

TL;DR

Git is a content-addressed store of blobs, trees and commits plus movable refs — build that core and branching, status, diff and merge stop being magic.

22. LRU and TTL caching library

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 1–2 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 6, Ch 7, Ch 12, Ch 16

What it is

A caching library with an in-memory **LRU** cache (least recently used — when full, evict the entry unused for longest), **TTL** expiry (time to live — entries vanish after a set time), a `@cached` decorator for sync and async functions, statistics, and protection against the **thundering herd** (many callers missing at once and all recomputing the same expensive value).

The problem it solves

Caching is the easiest big performance win and the most common source of stale-data bugs. `functools.lru_cache` is great but has no expiry, no async support and caches per process forever. Building your own teaches O(1) data structure design (an interview classic), concurrency control and the policy decisions — what to key on, when to expire, what to do on errors.

Real-world examples

- `functools.lru_cache` is the standard library's memoising decorator, implemented in C.
- cachetools provides LRU, LFU, TTL and other cache classes plus decorators, and is a good API reference.

Requirements

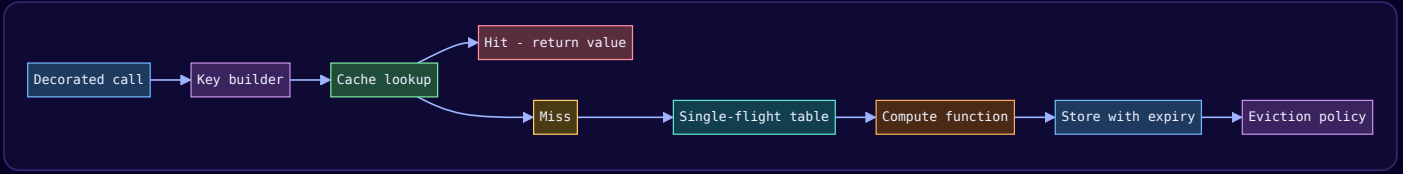
Functional

- `LRUCache(maxsize)`, `TTLCache(maxsize, ttl)` with `get`, `set`, `delete`, `clear`, `__contains__`, `__len__`.
- `@cached(cache, key=...)` for functions and methods, sync and `async`. Custom key functions. `cache_info()` with hits, misses, evictions.
- Single-flight: concurrent misses for the same key share one computation.
- Optional "stale while revalidate": serve an expired value briefly while refreshing in the background.

Non-functional

- `get` and `set` O(1), with a target of under 2 microseconds of overhead per cache hit in pure Python.
- Thread-safe and asyncio-safe variants.
- Exceptions are not cached by default.

The architecture



- **Key builder** turns arguments into a hashable key (a tuple of args and sorted kwargs), with a hook for custom keys.
- **Cache lookup** checks presence and expiry. An expired entry is treated as a miss.
- **Single-flight table** maps keys in progress to a future. Later callers await that future instead of recomputing.
- **Eviction policy** removes the least recently used entry when size exceeds `maxsize`.

Data model

Type	Fields
Entry	key, value, expires_at (monotonic seconds)
`LRUCache`	`OrderedDict[key, Entry]`, maxsize, lock, stats
In-flight table	`dict[key, Future]` (concurrent or asyncio)
`CacheInfo`	hits, misses, evictions, currsize, maxsize

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Ordering	`collections.OrderedDict.move_to_end`	O(1) recency updates
Clock	`time.monotonic`	Immune to wall-clock jumps
Thread safety	`threading.Lock`	Protect compound operations
Async single-flight	`asyncio.Future`	Share one result between tasks
Sync single-flight	`concurrent.futures.Future`	Same for threads

Milestones

1. **LRU core.** *Done when* tests show O(1) behaviour (timing roughly flat from 1,000 to 1,000,000 entries) and correct eviction order.
2. **TTL.** *Done when* a fake clock expires entries exactly on time.
3. **Decorator.** Sync functions, methods, custom keys, `cache_info`. *Done when* it matches `lru_cache` behaviour in shared tests.
4. **Async and single-flight.** *Done when* 100 concurrent awaits of a cold key call the function once.
5. **Thread safety.** *Done when* a stress test with 16 threads finds no corrupted state or wrong counts.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **O(1) LRU.** You need fast lookup (a hash map) and fast "move to most recent" and "remove least recent" (a doubly linked list). `OrderedDict` is exactly that combination. In interviews you may be asked to build it from a dict plus your own linked-list nodes — do both versions.
- **Expiry strategy.** Checking expiry on read (**lazy expiry**) is cheap but leaves dead entries using memory. Add an occasional sweep (every N operations) or a heap of expiry times. Never use `time.time()`: if the system clock jumps backwards, entries live far too long.
- **Thundering herd and single-flight.** When a hot key expires, hundreds of callers miss at once and all hit the database. With single-flight, the first caller registers a future in the in-flight table, computes, sets the result and removes the entry; others await the same future. If the computation raises, every waiter receives the exception and nothing is cached.
- **Caching methods.** Decorating a method makes `self` part of the key, which keeps instances alive forever (a memory leak) and fails for unhashable objects. Offer a per-instance cache or a key function that excludes `self`.

Testing strategy

Unit tests with a fake clock. Model-based testing with Hypothesis stateful testing: random sequences of get/set/delete compared against a simple reference model. Concurrency stress tests with threads and with `asyncio.gather`. Benchmarks with `timeit` against `functools.lru_cache`.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

LRU suits most workloads; LFU (least frequently used) is better when a few keys are always hot but adapts slowly. In-process caches are fastest but not shared between processes or servers and vanish on restart — use Redis or memcached for shared caches. Every cache risks serving stale data; pick TTLs with the business, and add explicit invalidation for writes you control.

Stretch goals

- A size-aware cache that evicts by total bytes, not item count.
- A two-level cache: in-process LRU in front of Redis.
- An implementation of a modern policy such as W-TinyLFU and a hit-rate comparison on a real trace.

Skills practised

- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: `OrderedDict`, hashing.

- Ch 7 — Functions: closures and `functools`.
- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: parametrised decorators.
- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: locks, futures.

In the interview

Q: Design an LRU cache with O(1) get and put. **A:** A hash map from key to node, plus a doubly linked list ordered by recency. Get moves the node to the front; put inserts at the front and evicts from the back when full.

Q: What is the thundering herd problem? **A:** Many requests miss the same expired key at once and all recompute it. Single-flight makes one compute while the others wait for its result.

Q: Why use `time.monotonic` for TTLs? **A:** It never goes backwards, unlike wall-clock time, which can jump with NTP or manual changes.

TL;DR

An `OrderedDict`-backed LRU with lazy TTL expiry, a sync/async decorator and single-flight protection — the classic interview structure turned into a real, concurrency-safe library.

23. Full-text search engine

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 2–3 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 4, Ch 6, Ch 11, Ch 17

What it is

A search engine for a collection of documents (for example this book's chapters, or Wikipedia abstracts). It builds an **inverted index** — a map from each word to the list of documents containing it — and answers queries with ranked results using **BM25**, the standard relevance formula used by search engines like Lucene. It supports phrase queries, boolean operators, prefix search and highlighted snippets.

The problem it solves

`grep` finds exact strings but cannot rank results, handle word variants or search a million documents instantly. Search is everywhere — in-app search, documentation, log tools — and understanding how it works tells you when SQL `LIKE` is enough and when you need a real engine. The project mixes text processing, data structures, ranking maths and performance work.

Real-world examples

- Apache Lucene is the search library behind Elasticsearch, OpenSearch and Solr. Its design (inverted index segments, BM25 by default) is the reference.
- Okapi BM25 on Wikipedia gives the scoring formula and its parameters `k1` and `b`.

Requirements

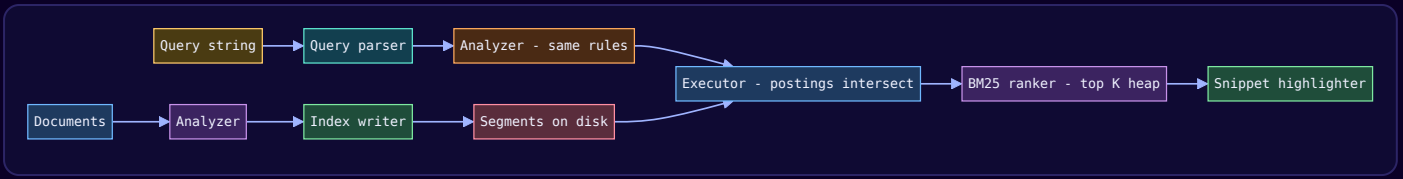
Functional

- Index documents from a folder (Markdown, text) or JSON Lines. Fields: title, body, path.
- Analysis pipeline: lower-casing, Unicode normalisation, tokenisation, stop words, optional stemming.
- Queries: terms (OR by default), `AND`, `NOT`, `"exact phrases"`, `prefix*`, field boosts (title matches score higher).
- Ranked results with BM25, highlighted snippets and pagination. Incremental add and delete.

Non-functional

- Index 100,000 short documents in under 60 seconds. Query latency p95 under 50 ms.
- Index persisted to disk and loaded in under 2 seconds.
- Memory usage reported, with a target under 500 MB for the 100,000-document set.

The architecture



- **Analyzer** turns text into tokens with positions. The same analyzer must run on documents and queries, or "Running" will never match "running".
- **Index writer** builds postings lists in memory and flushes immutable **segments** (self-contained mini-indexes).
- **Query parser** turns the query string into a tree (AND, OR, NOT, PHRASE, PREFIX).
- **Executor** fetches postings and intersects or unions them.
- **Ranker** computes BM25 scores and keeps the top K with a heap.
- **Highlighter** finds the best window of matched positions for a snippet.

Data model

Structure	Shape
Postings list	term to sorted list of (doc_id, term_frequency, positions)
Document store	doc_id to stored fields (title, path, length)
Field stats	document count, average field length
Term dictionary	sorted terms (enables prefix search with `bisect`)
Deletions	set of deleted doc_ids per segment

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Tokenising	`re`, `unicodedata.normalize`	Unicode-aware splitting
Postings	lists of ints, `array` module for compactness	Lower memory than lists of objects
Top K	`heapq.nlargest`	O(n log k)
Prefix search	`bisect` on sorted term list	Logarithmic range lookup
Persistence	`struct` plus `compression.zstd` or `pickle` for a first version	Compact files

Milestones

1. **In-memory index and term queries.** *Done when* single-word queries return matching documents.
2. **BM25 ranking.** *Done when* rankings on a small labelled set look right and match a hand calculation for two documents.
3. **Query language.** AND, NOT, phrases, prefixes. *Done when* parser tests cover precedence and quoting.
4. **Persistence and segments.** *Done when* the index survives restart and adding documents writes a new segment.
5. **Snippets and performance.** *Done when* latency and memory targets are met and documented.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **BM25 in plain words.** Each matching term contributes `IDF × (tf × (k1 + 1)) / (tf + k1 × (1 − b + b × len/avglen))`. **IDF** (inverse document frequency) rewards rare words. **tf** (term frequency) rewards repetition but with diminishing returns controlled by `k1` (often about 1.2). `b` (often 0.75) penalises long documents that match just because they are long. Precompute IDF per term and length norms per document.
- **Fast intersection.** For `python AND asyncio`, walk the two sorted postings lists in step (like merge in merge sort), starting from the shorter one. Skip lists or galloping search speed up very unequal lengths. Phrase queries additionally check that positions are consecutive.

- **Immutable segments.** Updating one giant index in place is slow and fragile. Instead write new small segments, mark deletions in a bitmap or set, and occasionally **merge** segments in the background. Queries search all segments and combine results. This is the core of Lucene's design.
- **Memory.** Millions of Python `int` objects in tuples cost far more than the numbers themselves. Store postings as `array('I')` or delta-encoded bytes and decode lazily.

Testing strategy

Analyzer tests with tricky text (accents, punctuation, hyphens). Query parser tests. Ranking tests on a tiny hand-scored corpus. Property test: results of `a AND b` are exactly the intersection of results for `a` and `b`. Benchmarks with a fixed corpus checked into the repo.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Stemming improves recall (finding more relevant documents) but can hurt precision (`universe` and `university` may stem together). Stop-word removal shrinks the index but breaks phrase queries like "to be or not to be". PostgreSQL full-text search or SQLite FTS5 is often enough for an application — a custom engine wins only when you need control. Semantic search (Project 40) handles synonyms that keyword search misses; hybrid systems use both.

Stretch goals

- Fuzzy matching with Levenshtein automata or n-gram indexes.
- A web UI with as-you-type suggestions.
- Hybrid ranking combining BM25 with vector similarity.

Skills practised

- Ch 4 — Strings: Unicode normalisation, regex tokenising.
- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: dicts of lists, heaps, `bisect`.
- Ch 11 — Iterators, generators and functional tools: streaming postings merge.
- Ch 17 — Performance, memory and internals: object overhead, `array`, profiling.

In the interview

Q: What is an inverted index? **A:** A map from each term to the sorted list of documents (and positions) that contain it, so a query reads only the lists for its terms.

Q: Why does BM25 beat raw term counts? **A:** It rewards rare terms (IDF), saturates repeated terms and normalises for document length.

Q: How do you answer an AND query quickly? **A:** Intersect sorted postings lists with a two-pointer merge, starting from the rarest term.

TL;DR

Analyzer, inverted index, BM25 and segment-based storage — the core of every search engine, small enough to build and measure in Python.

24. Webhook receiver and event dispatcher

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 2 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 12, Ch 14, Ch 16

What it is

A service that receives **webhooks** — HTTP POST requests that other services (GitHub, Stripe, a payment provider) send to you when something happens — verifies each one's signature, stores it durably, acknowledges quickly and dispatches it to handler functions registered with a decorator (`@on("payment.succeeded")`). It handles retries, duplicates and out-of-order delivery.

The problem it solves

Integrations with third-party services are built on webhooks, and they fail in predictable ways: forged requests, slow handlers causing the sender to time out and retry, the same event delivered twice, events arriving out of order. A receiver that gets these right is reusable across every integration you build. The project teaches HMAC signatures, idempotency, the outbox/inbox pattern and decorator-based registries.

Real-world examples

- GitHub's validating webhook deliveries guide explains HMAC-SHA256 signatures in the `X-Hub-Signature-256` header and constant-time comparison.
- Stripe's webhook documentation covers signature verification with timestamps to prevent replay, retries and handling duplicate events.

Requirements

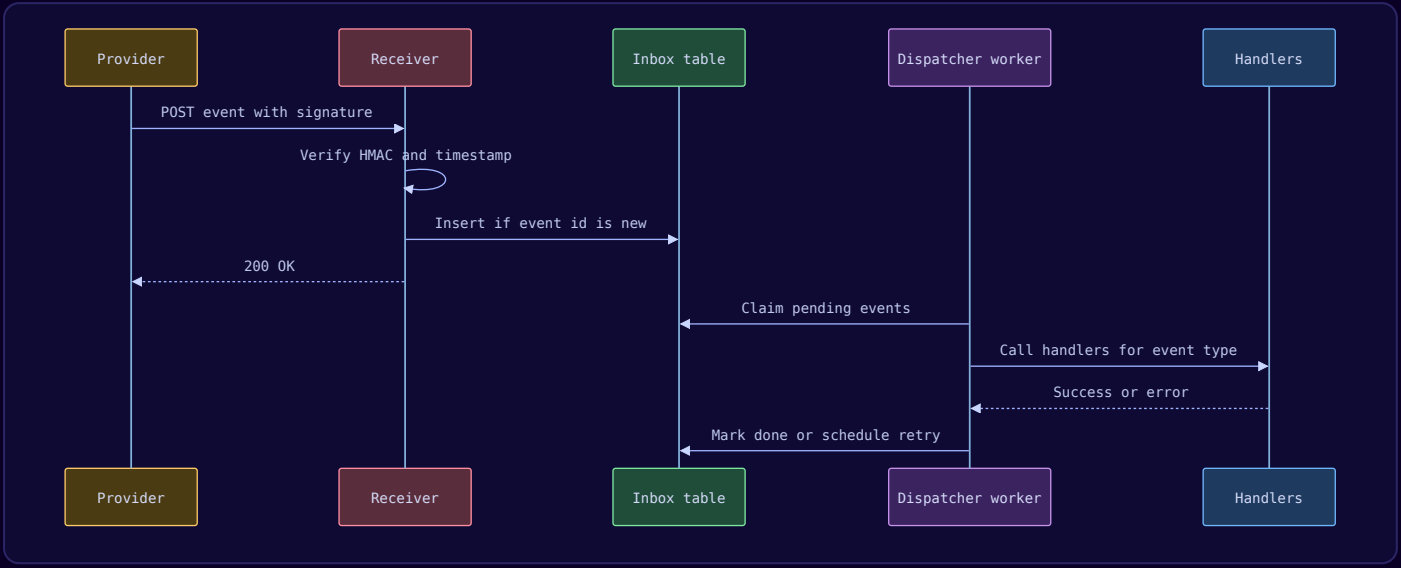
Functional

- Endpoints per provider (`/hooks/github` , `/hooks/stripe`) with pluggable signature verifiers.
- Store every verified event in an **inbox** table before acknowledging with 2xx.
- Dispatch to handlers registered by event type. Multiple handlers per type. Retry failed handlers with backoff, then move to a dead-letter list.
- De-duplicate by provider event id. Admin commands to list, replay and inspect events.

Non-functional

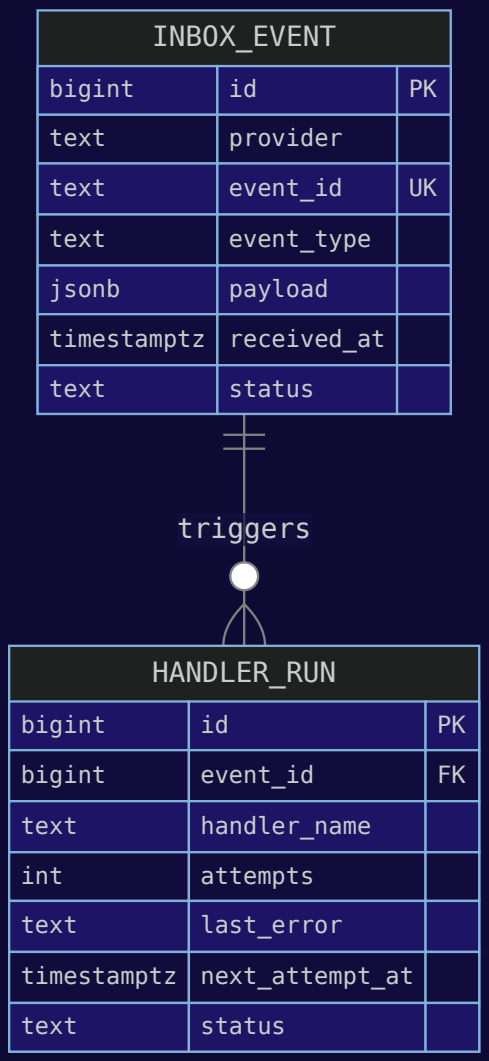
- Acknowledge within 200 ms (providers time out after a few seconds).
- No event lost after a 2xx response, even if the process crashes.
- Reject events older than 5 minutes (replay protection) where the provider signs timestamps.

The architecture



- **Receiver** does the minimum synchronously: read the raw body, verify, insert, respond. No business logic, so it stays fast.
- **Inbox table** is the durable buffer. A unique constraint on `(provider, event_id)` makes duplicates harmless.
- **Dispatcher worker** claims pending rows, calls handlers, records results and schedules retries.
- **Handler registry** maps event types to functions via a decorator.

Data model



Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
HTTP	FastAPI or Starlette	Access to raw request body, async
Signatures	`hmac.new`, `hmac.compare_digest`	Standard, constant-time comparison
Storage	PostgreSQL (or SQLite to start)	Durable, unique constraints
Worker	asyncio loop or Project 26's queue	Retry scheduling
Registry	decorator plus dict of lists	Simple and explicit

Milestones

1. **Verify.** *Done when* a GitHub-style signed request passes and a tampered body fails, using test vectors.
2. **Store and ack.** *Done when* events are stored before the 200 and duplicates return 200 without a second row.
3. **Dispatch.** Decorator registry and worker. *Done when* handlers run once per event.
4. **Retries and dead letters.** *Done when* a handler failing three times lands in dead letters and `replay` works.
5. **Hardening.** Replay window, size limits, metrics. *Done when* a load test of 200 events per second keeps ack latency under target.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Verify the raw bytes.** The signature is computed over the exact bytes sent. Parsing JSON and re-serialising changes whitespace and key order, and the signature no longer matches. Read the raw body first, verify, then parse. Compare signatures with `hmac.compare_digest`, which takes the same time whether the first or last byte differs, so attackers cannot guess the signature byte by byte from response times (a **timing attack**).
- **Ack fast, process later.** If you run business logic before responding and it takes 10 seconds, the provider times out and resends — now you process twice. Storing first and processing asynchronously (the **inbox pattern**) decouples sender timeouts from your work.
- **Idempotent handlers.** Even with de-duplication on event id, a handler can run twice: it succeeds, then the worker crashes before marking it done. Handlers must therefore be **idempotent** — running them twice has the same effect as once (check "already applied" by a business key, use upserts).
- **Ordering.** Providers do not guarantee order: `subscription.updated` may arrive before `subscription.created`. Either fetch the current state from the provider's API in the handler, or compare event timestamps or versions and ignore older updates.

Testing strategy

Signature tests with known vectors from provider docs. Integration tests posting signed requests to the app. Crash tests: kill the worker between handler success and status update, restart, verify idempotent outcome. Out-of-order tests delivering events in shuffled order.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

A database-backed inbox is simple and transactional; a message broker scales further but adds infrastructure. Storing full payloads helps debugging and replay but may store personal data — set a retention policy. Failing to return 2xx quickly causes provider retries and, for some providers, automatic disabling of your endpoint.

Stretch goals

- Outgoing webhooks: your service sending signed events to customers, with retries and a delivery log.
- Per-handler concurrency limits and priorities.
- A small dashboard of events and failures.

Skills practised

- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: registration decorators.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `hmac`, `hashlib`, `json`.
- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: background workers.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: retry and error recording.

In the interview

Q: How do you verify a webhook is genuine? **A:** Recompute the HMAC of the raw body with the shared secret and compare it with the header using a constant-time comparison. Check the signed timestamp to block replays.

Q: Why respond before running handlers? **A:** Providers time out and retry slow endpoints. Storing then acknowledging prevents duplicate deliveries caused by your own slowness.

Q: How do you handle duplicates? **A:** A unique constraint on the provider's event id, plus idempotent handlers for the cases that still slip through.

TL;DR

Verify raw bytes with constant-time HMAC, store before acknowledging, dispatch from a durable inbox with retries, and write idempotent, order-tolerant handlers.

25. Database schema migration tool

Level: Intermediate · **Time:** 2 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 8, Ch 9, Ch 14

What it is

A command-line tool, `migrate`, that manages changes to a database schema over time. Each change is a numbered **migration** file (SQL or Python) with an `up` step and optionally a `down` step. The tool records which migrations have been applied in a table, applies pending ones in order inside transactions, detects edited or missing files with checksums and prevents two deploys from migrating at the same time.

The problem it solves

Code and database schema must evolve together. Without tooling, teams run ad-hoc SQL by hand, environments drift apart and deploys fail because a column is missing. A migration tool makes schema changes reviewable, repeatable and ordered. Building one teaches transactional DDL (data definition language — `CREATE`, `ALTER`), locking, checksums and module loading.

Real-world examples

- Alembic is SQLAlchemy's migration tool, with revision files forming a chain (or graph) and autogeneration from models.
- Django's migrations documentation explains dependency graphs between migrations across apps and the recorded-migrations table.

Requirements

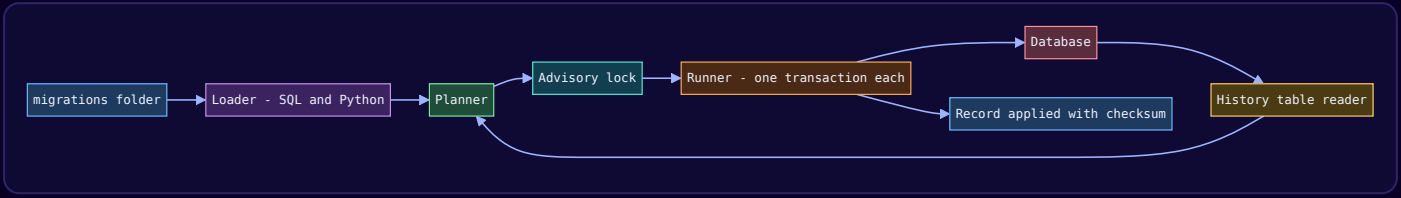
Functional

- `new "add users email index"` creates a timestamped file. `status` shows applied and pending. `up [target]` and `down [target]`.
- SQL migrations and Python migrations (a function receiving a connection, for data changes).
- Checksums of applied files: warn or fail if an applied migration was edited.
- Advisory lock so concurrent runs wait or fail. `--dry-run` prints the SQL.
- Support PostgreSQL and SQLite.

Non-functional

- Each migration runs in its own transaction where the database allows it, and a failure leaves the database at the previous version.
- Tool start-up and status under 200 ms.
- Works offline in CI to verify that migrations apply cleanly to an empty database.

The architecture



- **Loader** reads files, parses ids and names, computes SHA-256 checksums and imports Python migrations with `importlib.util.spec_from_file_location`.
- **History table reader** loads the `schema_migrations` table.
- **Planner** compares the two: which are pending, which applied files changed, which applied migrations are missing from disk.
- **Advisory lock** (PostgreSQL `pg_advisory_lock`) ensures one runner at a time.
- **Runner** executes each migration and its history insert in one transaction, so both happen or neither does.

Data model

SCHEMA_MIGRATIONS		
text	version	PK
text	name	
text	checksum	
timestamptz	applied_at	
int	duration_ms	
text	applied_by	

In-memory types: `Migration(version, name, kind, up_sql_or_callable, down, checksum, path)` and `Plan(to_apply, changed, missing)`.

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Drivers	psycopg 3 and `sqlite3` behind a small adapter	Two real databases
Python migrations	`importlib.util`	Load files outside packages
Checksums	`hashlib.sha256`	Detect edits
CLI	`argparse`	Sub-commands
Locking	`pg_advisory_lock`, SQLite `BEGIN IMMEDIATE`	Prevent concurrent runs

Milestones

1. **History and SQL up.** *Done when* pending SQL files apply in order and are recorded.
2. **Transactions.** *Done when* a failing migration leaves no partial schema and no history row (on PostgreSQL).
3. **Checksums and status.** *Done when* editing an applied file is reported clearly.
4. **Python migrations and down.** *Done when* a data migration backfills a column and `down` reverts the previous step.

5. **Locking and CI.** *Done when* two concurrent `up` commands never apply the same migration twice, and a CI job runs all migrations on an empty database.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Transactional DDL varies.** PostgreSQL runs most DDL inside transactions, so a failed migration rolls back fully. Some statements cannot run in a transaction (`CREATE INDEX CONCURRENTLY`), so allow a per-migration "no transaction" flag. MySQL commits implicitly on DDL, which is why tools for it warn about partial failures. Know what your database does.
- **Locking.** Two app instances starting at once could both see migration 7 as pending. A session-level advisory lock taken before planning serialises them: the second waits, re-reads the history and finds nothing to do.
- **Zero-downtime changes.** Renaming a column breaks old code still running during a rolling deploy. Use **expand and contract**: add the new column, deploy code writing both, backfill, switch reads, then drop the old column in a later release. Your tool can't enforce this, but your docs and a lint rule (warn on `DROP COLUMN` or `RENAME`) can encourage it.
- **Ordering with branches.** Two developers create migrations on separate branches with the same "next number". Timestamps as versions reduce clashes; detecting out-of-order unapplied migrations (an older version pending after newer ones applied) and refusing by default avoids surprises.

Testing strategy

Integration tests against real PostgreSQL (container) and SQLite. Fault injection: a migration with a syntax error halfway. Concurrency test with two processes. Round-trip test: apply all, revert all, apply all, and compare the schema dump each time.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Down migrations are nice in development but often impossible to make safe for data (a dropped column's data is gone) — many teams roll forward only. Autogeneration from models saves time but misses renames and data moves. Long-running migrations on big tables lock writes; use online techniques and small batches.

Stretch goals

- Schema diff between a database and a target SQL file.
- A lint step that flags dangerous operations.
- Dependency graphs between migrations instead of a linear list.

Skills practised

- Ch 8 — Modules, packages and environments: importing files by path.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: rollback on error.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `sqlite3`, `hashlib`, `argparse`.
- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: transactions and locks as context managers.

In the interview

Q: How do you stop two deploys from running migrations together? **A:** Take a database advisory lock before reading the history table and release it after applying.

Q: How do you rename a column without downtime? **A:** Expand and contract: add the new column, dual-write, backfill, switch reads, then drop the old column in a later release.

Q: Why record checksums of applied migrations? **A:** Editing an applied migration means environments that already ran it differ from new ones. The checksum detects that drift.

TL;DR

Versioned files, a history table with checksums, one transaction per migration and an advisory lock — plus expand-and-contract discipline — make schema changes safe and repeatable.

26. Async job queue on PostgreSQL

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 3–4 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 9, Ch 15, Ch 16

What it is

A background **job queue**: application code enqueues work (`send_email.defer(user_id=7)`), and separate **worker** processes pick jobs up and run them, with retries, scheduling ("run at 9:00"), priorities, timeouts, concurrency limits and a dead-letter state for jobs that keep failing. Instead of Redis or RabbitMQ, the queue lives in PostgreSQL and uses `SELECT ... FOR UPDATE SKIP LOCKED` so many workers can claim jobs concurrently without blocking each other. Workers are asyncio-based and run many jobs concurrently.

The problem it solves

Web requests must return quickly, but much work is slow or unreliable: sending email, generating reports, calling partner APIs. Moving it to a queue makes the app responsive and lets failed work retry. Using the database you already have avoids a new piece of infrastructure and gives a superpower: enqueuing a job in the *same transaction* as the business change, so you never send an email for an order that was rolled back.

Real-world examples

- The PostgreSQL `SELECT` documentation describes `FOR UPDATE` with `SKIP LOCKED`, noting it is suited to queue-like tables.
- Celery is the long-standing Python distributed task queue, with retries, routing, scheduling (beat) and result backends.
- RQ (Redis Queue) is a simpler Redis-backed queue whose docs show the essential job lifecycle.

Requirements

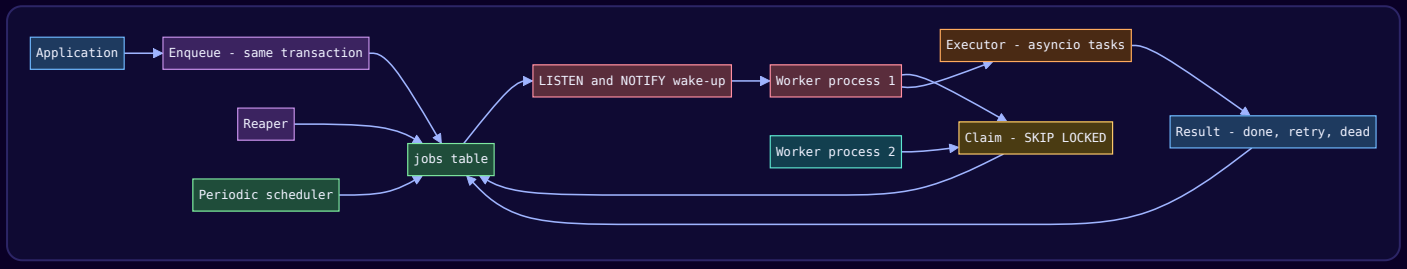
Functional

- Decorator `@task(queue="email", retries=5, timeout=30)` registers a function. `.defer(**kwargs)` enqueues, `.defer(run_at=...)` schedules.
- Workers claim jobs by queue and priority, run them with a timeout, mark success or schedule a retry with exponential backoff.
- Dead-letter state after max attempts, with a CLI to inspect, retry or cancel.
- Unique jobs (at most one pending job per key). Periodic jobs (cron-like).
- Transactional enqueue using the caller's connection.

Non-functional

- At least 1,000 trivial jobs per second with 8 workers on one PostgreSQL instance.
- At-least-once execution: no job lost if a worker crashes. Stuck jobs recovered within 1 minute.
- Graceful shutdown: a worker stops claiming, finishes or re-queues in-flight jobs within 30 seconds.

The architecture



- **Enqueue** inserts a row. If the caller passes its own connection, the insert joins the caller's transaction.
- **Claim** runs one SQL statement that selects the next available jobs with `FOR UPDATE SKIP LOCKED`, marks them `running` with a lease expiry and returns them.
- **Executor** runs up to N jobs concurrently in a `TaskGroup` (sync functions go to a thread pool), each with `asyncio.timeout`.
- **Result** updates status in a short transaction.

- **Reaper** finds `running` jobs whose lease expired (worker died) and returns them to `queued`.
- **LISTEN/NOTIFY** is PostgreSQL's built-in pub/sub: enqueue sends a notification so idle workers wake immediately instead of polling every second.

Data model



Index `(queue, status, priority, run_at)` for claims. Make `unique_key` a partial unique index over pending statuses only.

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Storage and locking	PostgreSQL	`SKIP LOCKED`, transactions, `LISTEN/NOTIFY`
Driver	psycopg 3 async	Async connections and notifications
Worker runtime	asyncio `TaskGroup`, `to_thread`	Many concurrent I/O jobs
Serialisation	JSON args	Language-neutral, inspectable
Testing	pytest, real Postgres container	Locking behaviour cannot be faked

Milestones

1. **Enqueue and single worker.** *Done when* jobs run once and are marked done.

2. **Concurrent claims.** *Done when* 8 workers process 10,000 jobs with zero duplicates and no deadlocks (checked from attempt rows).
3. **Retries, timeouts, dead letters.** *Done when* a flaky task succeeds on attempt 3 and a broken one ends as `dead` after max attempts.
4. **Leases and reaper.** *Done when* `kill -9` on a worker mid-job leads to the job re-running within a minute.
5. **Scheduling, uniqueness, NOTIFY, shutdown.** *Done when* delayed jobs run on time, duplicates are rejected, latency from enqueue to start is under 50 ms, and SIGTERM drains cleanly.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Why `SKIP LOCKED`.** With plain `FOR UPDATE`, all workers try to lock the same first row and queue up behind each other. `SKIP LOCKED` lets each worker skip rows another worker has locked and take the next one, so claims proceed in parallel. Claim and mark in one statement (`UPDATE jobs SET status='running' ... WHERE id IN (SELECT id ... FOR UPDATE SKIP LOCKED LIMIT 10) RETURNING *`) and commit immediately — do not hold the row lock while the job runs.
- **At-least-once and idempotency.** A worker can finish a job and crash before recording success. The reaper re-queues it and it runs again. Exactly-once execution is not achievable in general across a crash boundary, so job functions must be idempotent, or record their effect in the same database transaction as the status update.
- **Leases vs heartbeats.** A lease (`lease_until = now() + 60s`) marks how long a worker owns a job. Long jobs must extend the lease periodically (heartbeat) or the reaper will hand them to another worker while the first is still running. Pick the lease length from your longest normal job, not the average.
- **Table bloat.** In PostgreSQL every update writes a new row version, so a busy queue table accumulates dead rows. Keep the hot table small: move finished jobs to an archive table or delete them in batches, and make sure autovacuum keeps up.

Testing strategy

Integration tests against real PostgreSQL. Concurrency tests with multiple worker processes asserting each job's attempt count. Chaos tests: kill workers randomly during a run of 10,000 jobs and verify every job is eventually done or dead and none is lost. Time-dependent tests with an injectable clock for scheduling. Load test to measure throughput and enqueue-to-start latency.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

PostgreSQL queues are simple, transactional and fine into thousands of jobs per second, but they share load with your main database; a dedicated broker (Redis, RabbitMQ, Kafka) scales further and isolates load. Polling adds latency and load; NOTIFY reduces both but notifications are lost if nobody listens, so keep a slow poll as a backstop. Priorities can starve low-priority jobs — add aging or per-queue worker pools.

Stretch goals

- Job chaining and fan-out/fan-in (a job that waits for children).
- Rate limits per task type shared across workers.
- A web dashboard showing queue depth, latency and failures.

Skills practised

- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: `TaskGroup`, timeouts, cancellation, `to_thread`, signals.
- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: task registration decorators.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: error capture and retry policy.
- Ch 15 — Testing and debugging: integration and chaos tests.

In the interview

Q: How do several workers take jobs from one table without double-processing? **A:** Each claims rows with `FOR UPDATE SKIP LOCKED`, which locks the chosen rows and skips rows already locked by others, then marks them running in the same statement.

Q: Can you guarantee exactly-once execution? **A:** Not across crashes in general. You get at-least-once delivery and make jobs idempotent so a repeat has no extra effect.

Q: Why enqueue in the same transaction as the business change? **A:** So the job exists if and only if the change committed — no emails for rolled-back orders, no missing jobs for committed ones.

Q: What happens if a worker dies mid-job? **A:** Its lease expires and the reaper re-queues the job for another worker.

TL;DR

`SKIP LOCKED` claims, leases with a reaper, retries with backoff and transactional enqueue turn PostgreSQL into a reliable at-least-once job queue for asyncio workers.

27. Mini ORM with descriptors and metaclasses

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 3 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 10, Ch 12, Ch 13

What it is

A small **ORM** (object-relational mapper — a library that maps database rows to Python objects and builds SQL from Python expressions). You declare models as classes with typed fields, and the ORM creates tables, inserts, updates and queries them: `User.objects.filter(User.age >= 18).order_by(User.name).limit(10)`. Under the hood it uses **descriptors** (objects that control attribute access on a class through `__get__` / `__set__`), `__set_name__`, `__init_subclass__` or a **metaclass** (the class of a class, which can customise class creation), and operator overloading to build query expressions.

The problem it solves

Every Django or SQLAlchemy user relies on this machinery without seeing it. Building it yourself demystifies Python's most powerful features — descriptors, metaclasses, dunder methods — and shows the real costs of ORMs: N+1 queries, identity, lazy loading and the difference between Python expressions and SQL.

Real-world examples

- Django's model field reference shows the declarative style: fields as class attributes with options like `null`, `default` and `unique`.
- SQLAlchemy builds SQL expressions from overloaded Python operators (`User.age >= 18`) and separates its Core expression language from the ORM.
- The `annotationlib` documentation matters here: in 3.14, class annotations are evaluated lazily, so reading them inside a metaclass needs care.

Requirements

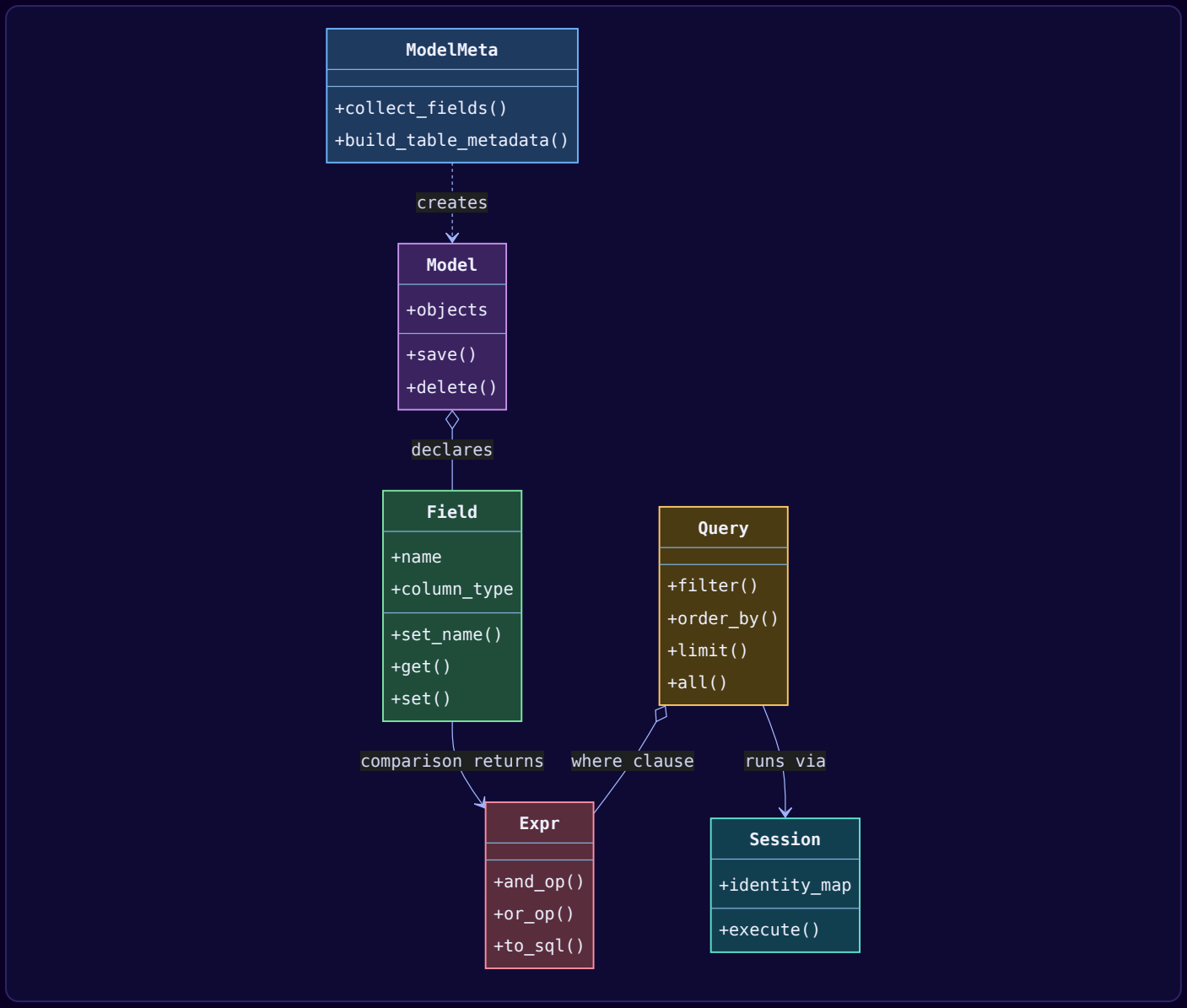
Functional

- Declare models: `class User(Model): id = IntegerField(primary_key=True)`, `name = TextField()`, `email = TextField(unique=True)`, or via type hints `name: Mapped[str]`.
- Validation on assignment via descriptors (type, nullability, max length).
- `create_table`, `save` (insert or update), `delete`, `get(pk)`.
- Query builder: `filter` with `==, !=, <, <=, >, >=`, `&`, `|`, `~`, `in_`, `like`, plus `order_by`, `limit`, `offset`, `count`. All values bound as parameters.
- Foreign keys with lazy loading and an explicit `select_related` to avoid N+1 queries. Identity map per session.

Non-functional

- Works with SQLite and PostgreSQL via a dialect object.
- Hydrating 10,000 rows into objects in under 100 ms.
- Type-checker friendly: `User.objects.get(1)` is typed as `User`.

The architecture



- **ModelMeta** (or `__init_subclass__`; in the diagram `set_name`, `get`, `set`, `and_op` and `or_op` stand for the dunder methods `__set_name__`, `__get__`, `__set__`, `__and__` and `__or__`) runs once per model class: it collects `Field` instances, builds table metadata and attaches a `Manager` as `objects`.
- **Field** is a descriptor. On the class (`User.age`) it returns itself, so `User.age >= 18` calls `Field.__ge__` and builds an `Expr`. On an instance (`user.age`) it returns the stored value.
- **Expr** is a small tree (column, operator, value) that compiles to SQL text plus a parameter list.
- **Query** is immutable: each method returns a new `Query`, so partial queries can be reused.
- **Session** runs SQL through a dialect and keeps an **identity map** (one Python object per primary key per session).

Data model

Type	Role
`TableMeta`	table name, ordered fields, primary key, indexes
`Field`	name, python type, SQL type, nullable, default, unique
`ForeignKey(Field)`	target model, on_delete
`Expr`	`Column`, `BinaryOp`, `BoolOp`, `Not`, `Value` nodes
`Dialect`	placeholder style, type mapping, quoting

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Attribute control	descriptors with `__set_name__`	Per-field validation and query expressions
Class creation	`__init_subclass__` first, metaclass if needed	Simplest tool that works
Annotations	`annotationlib.get_annotations` (3.14)	Safe access to lazy annotations
Drivers	`sqlite3`, psycopg 3	Two dialects
Typing	`Generic`, `Self`, overloads on `__get__`	Precise types for class vs instance access

Milestones

1. **Fields and validation.** *Done when* assigning a string to an `IntegerField` raises a clear error and values are stored per instance.
2. **Model metadata and DDL.** *Done when* `create_table(User)` emits correct SQL for both dialects.
3. **CRUD.** *Done when* save, get, update and delete round-trip with an identity map.
4. **Query expressions.** *Done when* complex filters compile to parameterised SQL and match hand-written queries.
5. **Relations.** *Done when* lazy loading works and `select_related` turns N+1 queries into one join (count queries in a test).

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Descriptors on class vs instance.** `__get__(self, instance, owner)` receives `instance=None` when accessed on the class. Return the field itself in that case (so you can build expressions) and the value otherwise. Store values in the instance's `__dict__` under the field name; since `Field` defines `__set__`, it is a **data descriptor** and takes priority over the instance dict, so your `__get__` still runs. `__set_name__` tells each field its attribute name automatically.
- **`__eq__` returning expressions.** Overloading `==` on fields to return `Expr` objects means `Field.__eq__` no longer returns a bool. If you also need fields in sets or dicts, define `__hash__` explicitly (defining `__eq__` sets `__hash__` to `None`). Never use Python's `and` / `or` / `not` in filters — they cannot be overloaded — which is why ORMs use `&`, `|`, `~`. Remember operator precedence: `(a == 1) & (b == 2)` needs parentheses.
- **Lazy annotations in 3.14.** If fields come from type hints (`name: Mapped[str]`), the metaclass reads annotations while the class is being created. With deferred evaluation, a hint that refers to a class defined later (`author: Mapped["User"]` or even unquoted) is not resolvable yet. Use `annotationlib.get_annotations(ns_or_cls, format=Format.FORWARDREF)` during class creation and resolve forward references lazily, on first query.
- **N+1 queries.** Looping over 100 posts and touching `post.author` runs 100 extra queries when relations load lazily. Provide `select_related` (join and hydrate both objects) or `prefetch_related` (one extra query with `IN`), and add a debug mode that logs a warning when the same query shape repeats many times in one request.

Testing strategy

Compile-only tests: expressions to SQL and params, no database. Round-trip tests on SQLite in memory and PostgreSQL in a container. Query-count assertions via a session hook. mypy tests confirming `User.name` is typed as a field and `user.name` as `str`. Property tests generating random filter trees and comparing results with filtering in Python.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

ORMs speed up common CRUD and keep SQL injection away, but hide query costs and make complex SQL awkward; good ORMs let you drop to raw SQL. Identity maps prevent duplicate objects but grow with the session — keep sessions short. Metaclasses conflict when two libraries each want one for the same class; `__init_subclass__` avoids that in most cases.

Stretch goals

- Migrations generated by diffing model metadata with the live schema (link to Project 25).
- Async session using psycopg's async API.
- Unit of work: track dirty objects and flush all changes in one transaction.

Skills practised

- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: descriptors, metaclasses, `__init_subclass__`.
- Ch 10 — OOP in Python: data model, operator overloading, `__hash__` and `__eq__`.
- Ch 13 — Type hints: generics and overloads for descriptors, lazy annotations.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `sqlite3`.

In the interview

Q: How does `User.age >= 18` become SQL? **A:** `User.age` is a descriptor that returns the field object on class access. Its `__ge__` returns an expression node, which the query compiles to `age >= ?` with 18 as a parameter.

Q: What is a data descriptor and why does it matter here? **A:** A descriptor defining `__set__` (or `__delete__`). It takes precedence over the instance dict, so validation and access always go through the field.

Q: Metaclass or `__init_subclass__`? **A:** Prefer `__init_subclass__` — it customises subclasses without a metaclass and avoids metaclass conflicts. Use a metaclass only when you must control class creation itself, such as the namespace.

Q: What is the N+1 problem? **A:** One query for a list, then one query per item for a relation. Fix with a join or a batched `IN` query.

TL;DR

Descriptors give fields both validation and query-building powers, class hooks collect them into table metadata, and immutable expression trees compile to safe SQL — the core of every Python ORM.

28. Interpreter for a small language

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 4–6 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 3, Ch 10, Ch 19

What it is

A complete interpreter for a small dynamically typed language — call it *Lox-like*: numbers, strings, booleans, `nil`, variables, `if`/`while`/`for`, functions with closures, and classes with methods and inheritance. You write a **lexer** (turns source text into tokens), a **parser** (turns tokens into an **AST**, an abstract syntax tree representing program structure), a **resolver** (works out which variable each name refers to) and a **tree-walking interpreter** (evaluates the AST directly), plus a REPL and helpful error messages.

The problem it solves

Interpreters and compilers sit behind every language, template engine, query language and configuration DSL (domain-specific language). Building one gives you deep intuition for how Python itself works — scopes, closures, call stacks, objects — and the techniques (recursive descent parsing, visitors, environments) reappear whenever you need to parse anything.

Real-world examples

- Crafting Interpreters by Robert Nystrom is a free online book that builds a tree-walking interpreter and then a bytecode VM for the Lox language — the best companion to this project.
- The `ast` module documentation shows Python's own AST node types, a useful model for designing yours.

Requirements

Functional

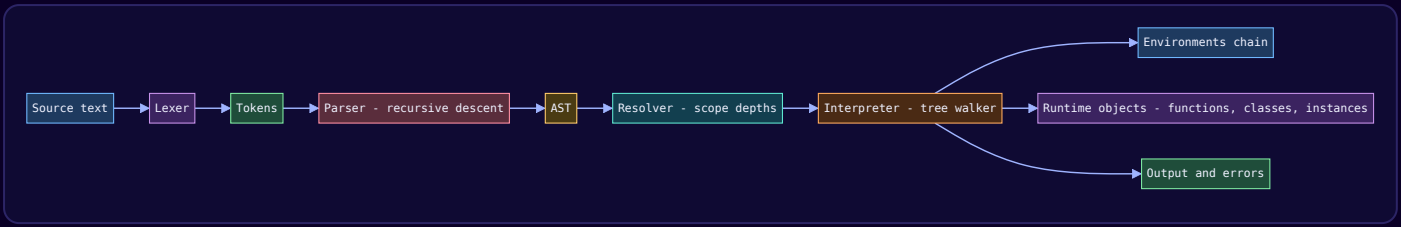
- Lexer with line and column tracking, string escapes, comments.

- Recursive-descent parser with correct precedence and associativity, error recovery (report several syntax errors per run).
- Static resolver for lexical scoping; errors for using a local in its own initialiser or `return` outside a function.
- Interpreter: expressions, statements, functions, closures, classes, `this`, `super`, built-ins like `clock()` and `print`.
- REPL with multi-line input and file execution mode.

Non-functional

- Errors show file, line, column and a caret under the problem.
- Recursive Fibonacci of 25 in under 5 seconds in CPython (tree-walkers are slow, that is fine).
- Deep recursion in user programs produces a language-level "stack overflow" error, not a Python crash.

The architecture



- **Lexer** scans characters into tokens (`IDENTIFIER`, `NUMBER`, `LEFT_PAREN` ...), keeping position for errors.
- **Parser** has one method per grammar rule, from lowest to highest precedence (`expression → assignment → or → and → equality → comparison → term → factor → unary → call → primary`).
- **Resolver** walks the AST once, recording for each variable use how many scopes up its declaration lives. This fixes closure bugs and makes lookups faster.
- **Interpreter** evaluates nodes; `match` on node types (or a visitor) dispatches.
- **Environments** are dictionaries linked to their enclosing environment.

Data model

Type	Contents
`Token`	kind, lexeme, literal, line, column
Expression nodes	`Literal`, `Variable`, `Assign`, `Binary`, `Logical`, `Unary`, `Call`, `Get`, `Set`, `This`, `Super`, `Grouping`
Statement nodes	`ExprStmt`, `Print`, `Var`, `Block`, `If`, `While`, `Function`, `Return`, `Class`
`Environment`	values dict, enclosing environment
Runtime	`LoxFunction(decl, closure)`, `LoxClass(name, superclass, methods)`, `LoxInstance(cls, fields)`

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
AST nodes	frozen dataclasses with `slots=True`	Compact, immutable, pattern-matchable
Dispatch	structural `match` / `case` on node classes	Readable evaluator
Errors	custom exception hierarchy	Syntax vs runtime errors
Control flow	exceptions for `return`	Unwind nested evaluation simply
REPL	`input` loop or `code` module	Interactive testing

Milestones

1. **Lexer.** *Done when* every token kind is tested, including unterminated strings reporting the right line.

2. **Expressions.** Parser and evaluator for arithmetic, comparison, logic. *Done when* `1 + 2 * 3 == 7` is true and precedence tests pass.
3. **Statements and scope.** Variables, blocks, `if`, `while`, `for`. *Done when* shadowing and nested blocks behave correctly.
4. **Functions and closures.** With the resolver. *Done when* a counter-making closure works and the classic closure-capture test from Crafting Interpreters passes.
5. **Classes.** Methods, `this`, initialisers, inheritance, `super`. *Done when* a small object-oriented program runs.
6. **Polish.** Error recovery, REPL, stack overflow handling. *Done when* a test suite of 100 small programs with expected output passes.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Precedence by grammar layering.** Each precedence level is a function that calls the next-higher level for its operands and loops over operators at its own level. That loop makes operators left-associative (`1 - 2 - 3` is `(1 - 2) - 3`). Right-associative assignment uses recursion instead of a loop. Getting this structure right removes most parser bugs.
- **Closures and the resolver.** A closure captures the *environment* where a function was defined, not the values. Without static resolution, a variable declared later in an enclosing block can change which binding an earlier closure sees. The resolver fixes the depth of each variable reference at parse time, and the interpreter then looks up exactly that many environments up.
- **Return via exceptions.** `return` deep inside nested loops and blocks must unwind to the function call. Raising a private `ReturnSignal(value)` and catching it in `call()` is simple and correct. It is slow in hot loops; a bytecode VM uses explicit jumps instead.
- **Host recursion limits.** A tree-walker uses Python recursion for both parsing and evaluation, so a deeply nested user program hits Python's recursion limit. Track your own call depth and raise a language-level "stack overflow" error before Python's limit, rather than raising the limit and risking a real crash.

Testing strategy

Golden tests: a folder of `.lox` programs, each with expected stdout and errors in comments, run by a pytest parametrised test. Unit tests per lexer and parser rule. Fuzz the parser with random token streams to check it never raises an unexpected Python exception — only language errors.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Tree-walking is simple and great for learning but 10–100× slower than a bytecode VM; the second half of Crafting Interpreters shows the VM approach. Dynamic typing keeps the interpreter small but moves all type errors to runtime. Error recovery adds complexity but makes the language usable.

Stretch goals

- Compile to a stack-based bytecode and run a VM loop, then compare speed.
- A standard library (lists, maps, string methods) written partly in the language itself.
- Use the same lexer/parser architecture to build a configuration language or a query DSL.

Skills practised

- Ch 3 — Control flow: structural pattern matching for dispatch.
- Ch 10 — OOP in Python: dataclasses, class hierarchies for nodes and runtime objects.
- Ch 7 — Functions: scopes and closures, mirrored in your language.
- Ch 19 — Python for coding interviews: recursion and tree traversal.

In the interview

Q: What are the phases of an interpreter? **A:** Lexing into tokens, parsing into an AST, optional static analysis such as scope resolution, then evaluation by walking the tree or compiling to bytecode.

Q: How does a recursive-descent parser handle precedence? **A:** One function per precedence level, each calling the next tighter level for its operands, so tighter operators bind first.

Q: How are closures implemented? **A:** A function value stores a reference to the environment in which it was created, and calls create a new environment whose parent is that captured one.

Q: Why is a tree-walking interpreter slow? **A:** Every node evaluation is a dynamic dispatch and pointer chase; bytecode VMs flatten the program into compact instructions with a tight loop.

TL;DR

Lexer, recursive-descent parser, resolver and tree-walking evaluator with environments — the classic pipeline that explains how every language, including Python, actually runs.

29. Sampling and tracing profiler

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 3 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 16, Ch 17

What it is

A Python profiler with two modes. A **tracing** (deterministic) mode records every function call and return using the `sys.monitoring` API (PEP 669, Python 3.12+), giving exact call counts. A **sampling** mode wakes up many times per second, captures every thread's current call stack and counts which stacks appear most, giving low-overhead statistics. Both produce text reports, a **flame graph** (a visualisation where each box is a function, width shows time spent) and the "collapsed stack" format other tools read.

The problem it solves

"Measure, don't guess" is the first rule of performance work, but profilers themselves can distort what they measure: deterministic profilers slow programs heavily, especially those with many small calls. Building both kinds teaches why sampling is the tool of choice in production, how Python stacks and frames work, and how to present performance data so humans can act on it.

Real-world examples

- py-spy is a sampling profiler that reads a running Python process's memory from outside, so it can profile production without code changes.
- Scalene profiles CPU, GPU and memory, separating time spent in Python from time in native code.
- PEP 669 introduced `sys.monitoring`, a low-overhead event API for profilers and debuggers. The standard `profile` and `cProfile` documentation covers the built-in deterministic profiler.

Requirements

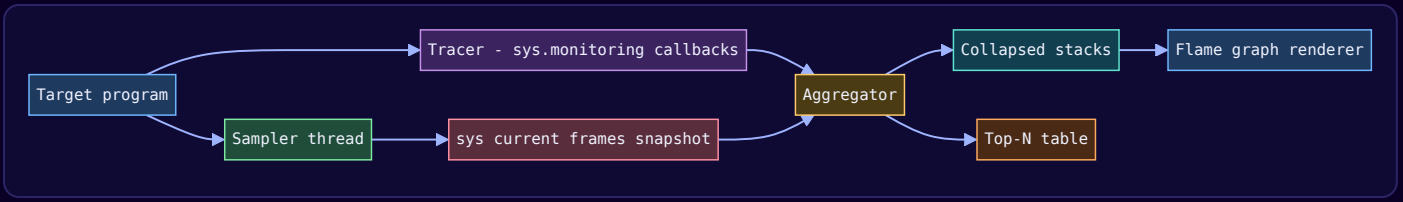
Functional

- `pyprof run script.py` and a context manager/decorator API.
- Tracing mode: per-function call counts, total time and own time (excluding callees), caller–callee pairs.
- Sampling mode: configurable rate (default 100 Hz), all threads, wall-clock or CPU time, idle frames filtered.
- Outputs: top-N table, collapsed stacks, an SVG or HTML flame graph.
- Annotate time spent waiting in asyncio vs running.

Non-functional

- Sampling overhead under 5 % at 100 Hz on a CPU-bound benchmark.
- Tracing overhead measured and reported (expect much higher, especially on call-heavy code).
- The profiler never changes program results and is safe to stop at any time.

The architecture



- **Tracer** registers a tool id with `sys.monitoring` and enables `PY_START`, `PY_RETURN` (and related) events, maintaining a shadow stack with timestamps per thread.
- **Sampler** is a background thread that sleeps for the interval, then calls `sys._current_frames()` to get each thread's top frame and walks `f_back` to build the stack.
- **Aggregator** converts stacks to tuples of `(file, function, first line)` keys and counts them in a `Counter`.
- **Renderers** produce tables and flame graphs.

Data model

Type	Contents
`FrameKey`	filename, qualname, first line number
Stack	tuple of `FrameKey` from root to leaf
Sample counts	`Counter[Stack]`
Tracing stats	per function: calls, total_ns, own_ns, callers (dict)
Collapsed line	`root;child;leaf 42` (semicolon-separated frames and a count)

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Event tracing	`sys.monitoring`	Lower overhead than `sys.setprofile`, per-code-object control
Sampling	`threading`, `sys._current_frames`	In-process, no extra privileges
Timing	`time.perf_counter_ns`, `time.thread_time_ns`	Wall vs CPU time
Flame graph	own SVG writer	Learn the layout algorithm
Comparison	cProfile, py-spy	Validate your numbers

Milestones

1. **Tracing basics.** *Done when* call counts on a known program match cProfile.
2. **Own vs total time.** *Done when* a function calling a slow child shows small own time and large total time.
3. **Sampler.** *Done when* a busy loop in one function receives roughly 100 % of samples and overhead is measured.
4. **Flame graph.** *Done when* the SVG for a recursive program shows the expected nested shape.
5. **Threads and asyncio.** *Done when* samples are attributed per thread and tasks awaiting I/O are labelled idle.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Why sampling has low overhead.** Tracing runs code on every call and return — for code making millions of small calls, the profiler's work dwarfs the program's. Sampling does a fixed amount of work per interval regardless of how many calls happen. The cost is statistical error: a function using 1 % of time gets about 1 sample per second at 100 Hz, so short runs need higher rates or longer runs.
- **`sys.monitoring` vs `sys.setprofile`.** The older hooks call your function for every event in every code object. `sys.monitoring` lets tools enable events globally or per code object and return

`sys.monitoring.DISABLE` from a callback to switch off that event at that location, which makes targeted tracing cheap. Several tools (a debugger and a profiler) can coexist using separate tool ids.

- **In-process sampling and the GIL.** On the default build, the sampler thread needs the GIL to read frames, so it samples only at points where the interpreter switches threads and can be delayed by long-running C calls that hold the GIL. External samplers like py-spy avoid this by reading memory from another process. On the free-threaded build (3.14t), reading another thread's frames while it runs needs extra care — document what your sampler guarantees.
- **Flame graph layout.** Sort sibling frames alphabetically (not by time) so the same code always appears in the same place, merge identical prefixes into one box, and make width proportional to sample count. This is a straightforward recursive tree layout once stacks are counted.

Testing strategy

Synthetic programs with known profiles (one function spinning for 70 % of the time, another for 30 %), asserting sample shares within tolerance. Compare tracing counts with cProfile. Overhead benchmarks run with and without the profiler. Snapshot tests of collapsed stack output.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Tracing gives exact counts but distorts timings; sampling gives realistic timings but misses rare short calls. In-process profilers need code changes or a launcher; external ones need OS permissions. Python 3.14 adds `sys.remote_exec` (PEP 768), which lets a tool ask a running process to execute code at a safe point — useful for attaching an in-process profiler to a live program, but it requires appropriate permissions and should be used carefully.

Stretch goals

- Memory profiling with `tracemalloc` snapshots, diffed between two points.
- Attach to a running process with `sys.remote_exec` to start and stop sampling.
- A differential flame graph comparing two runs.

Skills practised

- Ch 17 — Performance, memory and internals: frames, profiling, overhead.
- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: threads, the GIL, asyncio scheduling.
- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: `Counter` of stacks.
- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: profiler as context manager.

In the interview

Q: Sampling or tracing profiler for production? **A:** Sampling — its overhead is bounded and roughly constant, and it shows where time really goes. Tracing distorts call-heavy code.

Q: What is the difference between own time and total time? **A:** Own time excludes callees; total time includes them. High own time means the function itself is slow; high total but low own means look at what it calls.

Q: What does `sys.monitoring` improve over `sys.settrace`? **A:** Events can be enabled selectively and disabled per location, so tools pay only for what they monitor, and multiple tools can coexist.

TL;DR

Build both a `sys.monitoring` tracer and a stack sampler, compare them honestly, and render flame graphs — you will understand profiler overhead and Python frames for good.

30. Free-threaded parallel pipeline

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 2–3 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 16, Ch 17

What it is

A CPU-bound data-processing pipeline — for example, parse millions of JSON log records, compute features, and aggregate statistics — that runs truly in parallel on threads using the **free-threaded build** of Python 3.14

(`python3.14t`), in which the **GIL** (global interpreter lock, which normally lets only one thread run Python bytecode at a time) is disabled. You design stages connected by bounded queues, make shared state safe, and benchmark against the default build, multiprocessing and sub-interpreters.

The problem it solves

For decades, CPU-bound Python could only use multiple cores through processes, paying for pickling data between them. PEP 703 made the GIL optional in 3.13 as an experiment, and PEP 779 made the free-threaded build officially supported (though still optional, not the default) in 3.14. Knowing when it helps, what it costs and what new bugs it exposes is now a practical skill and a hot interview topic.

Real-world examples

- PEP 779 sets the criteria under which the free-threaded build became supported in 3.14, and PEP 703 describes the design (biased reference counting, per-object locks, a thread-safe allocator).
- The Python docs' free-threading HOWTO explains how to identify the build, how the GIL can be re-enabled by incompatible extensions, and known limitations.
- The community-run py-free-threading guide tracks library compatibility and porting advice.

Requirements

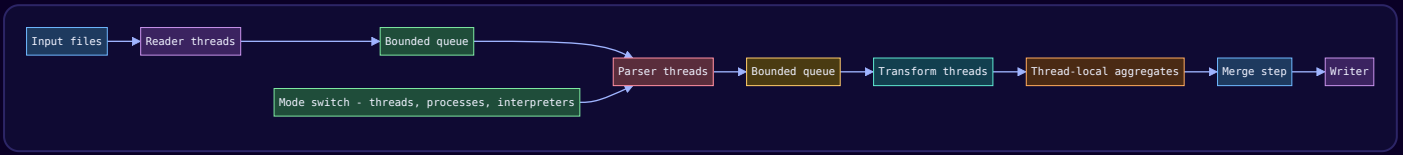
Functional

- Stages: reader (file chunks), parser, transformer, aggregator, writer. Each stage has N worker threads.
- Bounded queues between stages for backpressure; clean shutdown with sentinels or `Queue.shutdown()` (3.13+).
- Per-worker local aggregation merged at the end (no shared hot counters).
- A switch to run the same stages with `ProcessPoolExecutor` and with `InterpreterPoolExecutor` (3.14) for comparison.
- Report the build type and whether the GIL is actually disabled at runtime.

Non-functional

- On 3.14t with 8 cores, at least 5× speed-up over a single thread for the CPU-heavy stages.
- Identical output across all modes and thread counts.
- No data races detected under a stress test with randomised thread counts.

The architecture



- **Readers** read files in large chunks (I/O is fine on any build).
- **Parser and transform threads** do the CPU-heavy work. On the free-threaded build they run simultaneously on different cores.
- **Bounded queues** (`queue.Queue(maxsize=...)`) stop fast stages from flooding memory.
- **Thread-local aggregates** keep each worker's counts in its own dict, avoiding lock contention, merged once at the end.
- **Mode switch** reuses the stage functions with other executors so you can compare honestly.

Data model

Type	Contents
`Chunk`	file id, byte range, list of raw lines
`Record`	parsed fields (timestamp, user, endpoint, latency)
`Features`	derived numbers per record
`Partial`	per-worker `Counter` and sums
`RunReport`	mode, threads, GIL enabled flag, wall time, CPU time, records per second

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Interpreter	CPython 3.14t (free-threaded) and 3.14 (default)	Compare GIL vs no GIL
Threads	`threading`, `concurrent.futures.ThreadPoolExecutor`	Shared memory parallelism
Queues	`queue.Queue` with `shutdown()`	Thread-safe, bounded
Comparison	`ProcessPoolExecutor`, `InterpreterPoolExecutor`	Alternatives to compare
Detection	`sys._is_gil_enabled()`, `sysconfig.get_config_var("Py_GIL_DISABLED")`	Know what you are measuring

Milestones

1. **Single-threaded baseline.** *Done when* output is correct and you have a timed baseline on both builds.
2. **Threaded stages.** *Done when* the pipeline gives identical results with 1, 2, 4 and 8 threads per stage.
3. **Free-threaded speed-up.** *Done when* a scaling chart shows speed-up vs thread count on 3.14t and flat performance on the default build.
4. **Contention fixes.** *Done when* replacing a shared locked counter with per-thread partials measurably improves scaling.
5. **Comparison.** *Done when* a table compares threads (both builds), processes and interpreters on time, memory and code complexity.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Races become real.** With the GIL, many races were rare because threads switched only at certain points. Without it, two threads truly run at the same moment. Built-in containers are protected by internal per-object locks, so a `dict` will not be corrupted, but compound operations like `d[k] = d.get(k, 0) + 1` are still not atomic. Use per-thread state and merge, or explicit locks around compound updates.
- **Contention kills scaling.** A single lock or even a single shared object written by every thread becomes a bottleneck: threads queue for it and cache lines bounce between cores. The fastest parallel code shares nothing during the hot loop. Measure with thread counts 1 to N and look for where the curve flattens.
- **Single-thread cost and extensions.** The free-threaded build runs single-threaded code somewhat slower (the docs give a rough figure of a 5–10 % penalty, depending on platform). Importing a C extension not marked as free-threading-compatible re-enables the GIL for the whole process, with a warning — your speed-up silently disappears. Check `sys._is_gil_enabled()` at runtime and print it in the report.
- **Picking the right tool.** Processes isolate memory and work on every build but pay to pickle data. Sub-interpreters (`InterpreterPoolExecutor`) each have their own GIL and isolated state, cheaper than processes but with limits on sharing objects. Free-threaded threads share everything directly — fastest data sharing, highest race risk. Your comparison table should show these trade-offs with numbers.

Testing strategy

Determinism tests: outputs identical across modes and thread counts (sort before comparing). Stress tests running many iterations with random thread counts and small queue sizes to shake out races. Benchmarks repeated several times with median and spread reported. A test that fails if the GIL is unexpectedly enabled on the free-threaded run.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Free-threading helps pure-Python CPU work; numpy-heavy code already releases the GIL inside C, so the gain is smaller. Memory use is higher on the free-threaded build. Library support is improving but uneven — check every dependency. If stages are imbalanced, the slowest stage limits throughput; give it more threads.

Stretch goals

- Dynamic thread allocation per stage based on queue depth.
- A version using `concurrent.interpreters` directly with interpreter queues.
- Profile with your Project 29 profiler on 3.14t.

Skills practised

- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: the GIL, free-threading, executors, queues, locks.
- Ch 17 — Performance, memory and internals: benchmarking, reference counting internals.
- Ch 11 — Iterators, generators and functional tools: staged processing.

In the interview

Q: Is the free-threaded build the default in 3.14? **A:** No. PEP 779 made it officially supported but optional; you install and run `python3.14t` explicitly.

Q: Does removing the GIL make my code thread-safe? **A:** The opposite: built-ins stay internally consistent, but compound operations race more often. You still need locks or share-nothing designs.

Q: Why did my free-threaded program not speed up? **A:** Common causes: an extension re-enabled the GIL, contention on shared state, the work was I/O-bound or already in C, or one stage is the bottleneck.

Q: Threads, processes or sub-interpreters for CPU work? **A:** Free-threaded threads for shared-memory work with compatible dependencies, processes for isolation and compatibility, sub-interpreters for isolated parallelism with less overhead than processes.

TL;DR

A staged, share-nothing pipeline benchmarked on 3.14t against the default build, processes and sub-interpreters — the practical way to learn what PEP 779's free-threading buys and costs.

31. Data pipeline with pandas and polars

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 3 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 13, Ch 15, Ch 18

What it is

A batch **ETL** pipeline (extract, transform, load) that ingests raw data — for example a year of public bike-share trip CSVs plus weather data — validates it, cleans it, joins and aggregates it, and writes analysis-ready **Parquet** files (a compressed, column-oriented file format) and a small report. You implement the transformation layer twice, once in **pandas** and once in **polars** (a DataFrame library written in Rust with a lazy, query-optimised API), behind a common interface, and compare correctness, speed and memory.

The problem it solves

Data work in companies is mostly pipelines: messy inputs, schema drift, duplicates, time zones, joins that silently multiply rows, and jobs that must re-run safely. Notebook code rarely survives that. This project turns analysis code into a tested, reproducible, incremental pipeline, and teaches when the eager pandas model or the lazy polars model fits better.

Real-world examples

- The Polars user guide explains its expression API, lazy execution with query optimisation (predicate and projection pushdown) and streaming for larger-than-memory data.
- The pandas documentation covers groupby, merge, reshaping, time series and, in pandas 3.x, copy-on-write semantics by default.

- Apache Arrow is the columnar memory format polars is built on and pandas can use, which makes zero-copy exchange between tools possible.

Requirements

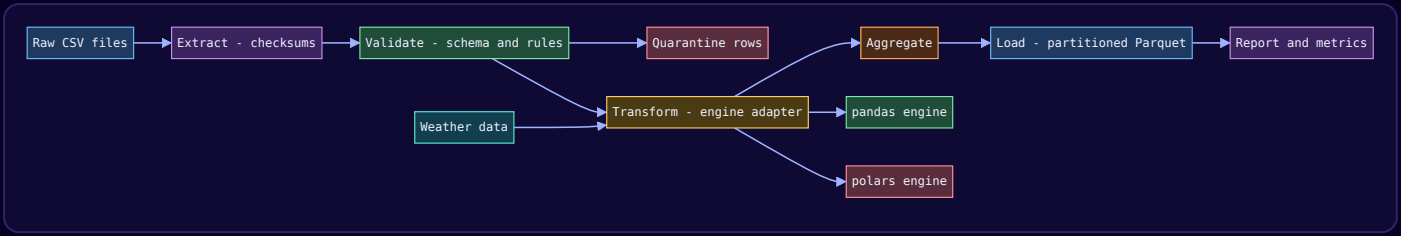
Functional

- Extract: download or read monthly CSVs, record source file checksums.
- Validate: schema (columns, types), ranges (duration > 0), uniqueness of trip ids, referential checks (stations exist). Failed rows go to a quarantine file with reasons.
- Transform: parse timestamps to UTC, derive duration and distance, join hourly weather, aggregate per station per day.
- Load: partitioned Parquet (`year=2026/month=10/`), idempotent re-runs per partition, a summary report.
- Backend switch: `--engine pandas|polars`, same outputs.

Non-functional

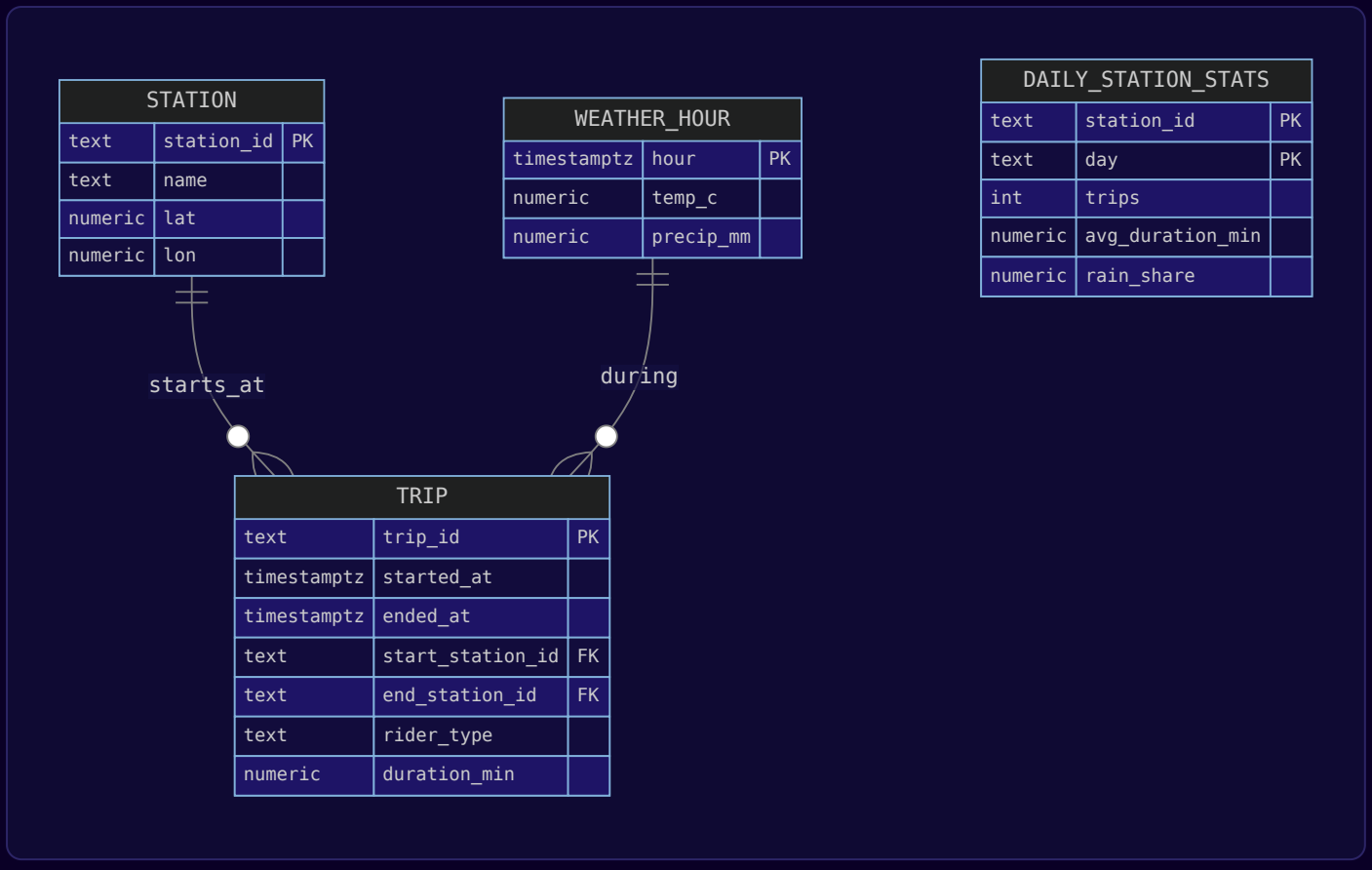
- Process 12 months (about 20–50 million rows, depending on the city) on a 16 GB laptop.
- Re-running a month replaces its partition atomically and produces identical output.
- Each stage logs row counts in and out; unexpected drops above 1 % fail the run.

The architecture



- **Extract** records what was read so runs are reproducible and incremental (skip unchanged files).
- **Validate** applies declarative rules and splits good and bad rows rather than failing on the first problem.
- **Engine adapter** is a `Protocol` with methods like `clean_trips`, `join_weather`, `daily_station_stats`, implemented by `PandasEngine` and `PolarsEngine`.
- **Load** writes each partition to a temporary folder, then renames it into place.
- **Report** summarises counts, quarantine reasons and timings.

Data model



Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
DataFrames	pandas and polars	Compare eager and lazy models
Storage	Parquet via pyarrow	Columnar, compressed, typed
Validation	own rules or pandera	Declarative checks
Typing	`Protocol` for engines	Swap implementations safely
Tests	pytest, small fixture frames	Fast, exact comparisons

Milestones

1. **pandas end to end on one month.** *Done when* the daily stats for a fixture match hand-computed values.
2. **Validation and quarantine.** *Done when* bad rows are quarantined with reasons and counts reconcile (in = good + bad).
3. **Polars engine.** *Done when* both engines produce identical Parquet output for the same input (compared after sorting).
4. **Scale.** Twelve months within memory limits. *Done when* polars lazy/streaming handles the full year and you have measured peak memory for both engines.
5. **Idempotent, incremental runs.** *Done when* re-running unchanged months is skipped and re-running a changed month replaces only its partition.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Eager vs lazy.** pandas executes each step immediately and materialises intermediate DataFrames, so memory can spike to several times the data size. Polars' lazy API builds a query plan, then optimises it: it pushes filters down to the CSV/Parquet scan, reads only needed columns and can stream in chunks. Write the polars version as one lazy expression chain and call `.collect()` once at the end.

- **Join explosions.** Joining trips to weather on hour should keep the trip count unchanged. If the weather table has two rows for one hour (daylight-saving duplicates, data errors), the join silently duplicates trips. Assert row counts after every join and validate uniqueness of join keys first (pandas `merge(validate="many_to_one")` does exactly this).
- **Time zones.** Bike data is usually local time without an offset; weather is often UTC. Localise with the correct zone, handle the non-existent hour in spring and the repeated hour in autumn explicitly, then convert to UTC before joining.
- **Types and nulls.** CSV readers guess types. A station id like `"00123"` becomes the integer 123; a column with one blank becomes float. Declare dtypes explicitly. pandas 3.x uses a dedicated string dtype by default and copy-on-write; polars has strict types and a single null representation — differences you must reconcile when comparing outputs.

Testing strategy

Small fixture CSVs covering edge cases (DST boundaries, negative durations, missing stations). Unit tests per transformation for both engines from one parametrised test. Engine parity test comparing outputs with `polars.testing` or `pandas.testing` helpers after conversion. A data-quality test suite that runs in production too (counts, null rates, ranges).

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

pandas has the largest ecosystem and is familiar; polars is usually faster and more memory-efficient on large data thanks to Rust, multithreading and lazy optimisation. Beyond one machine, move to DuckDB, Spark or a warehouse. Pipelines fail silently more often than loudly — row-count checks and quarantine reports are what catch bad upstream data.

Stretch goals

- Orchestrate with a scheduler and data freshness alerts.
- Query the Parquet output with DuckDB from the report step.
- Add a dashboard of daily trends with matplotlib or a notebook.

Skills practised

- Ch 18 — The data stack: pandas selection, groupby, merge, dates.
- Ch 13 — Type hints: `Protocol` for interchangeable engines.
- Ch 15 — Testing and debugging: data tests and parametrisation.
- Ch 17 — Performance, memory and internals: measuring memory and speed.

In the interview

Q: Why might polars be faster than pandas on the same task? **A:** It is written in Rust, runs multithreaded, and its lazy engine optimises the whole query — pushing filters and column selection into the scan and avoiding intermediate copies.

Q: How do you catch a join that duplicated rows? **A:** Validate join-key uniqueness before the join and assert row counts after it.

Q: What makes a pipeline idempotent? **A:** Each run computes a partition from its inputs and atomically replaces the previous output, so re-running gives the same result without duplicates.

TL;DR

A validated, partitioned, idempotent ETL pipeline implemented in both pandas and polars behind one interface — learn the data-quality habits and when lazy beats eager.

32. Distributed task runner

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 4–6 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 9, Ch 16, Ch 17

What it is

A small cluster computing system: a **scheduler** process accepts a **DAG** (directed acyclic graph — tasks with dependencies, no cycles) of Python function calls, and **worker** processes on one or more machines execute tasks, passing results to dependent tasks. Clients write `fut = client.submit(f, x)`, `client.map(g, items)`, and `client.gather(futures)`. It handles worker failures, retries, data locality and result spilling to disk.

The problem it solves

Some jobs are too big for one process or one machine: hyperparameter sweeps, rendering, simulations, large data transforms. Tools like Dask and Ray let Python developers scale out with familiar APIs. Building a mini version teaches distributed-systems fundamentals in a concrete way: serialisation, heartbeats, failure detection, scheduling heuristics and the cost of moving data.

Real-world examples

- Dask's documentation covers its distributed scheduler, futures API, task graphs and how it decides where to run tasks based on data locality.
- Ray's documentation describes remote functions and actors, an object store for sharing results, and fault tolerance through lineage.

Requirements

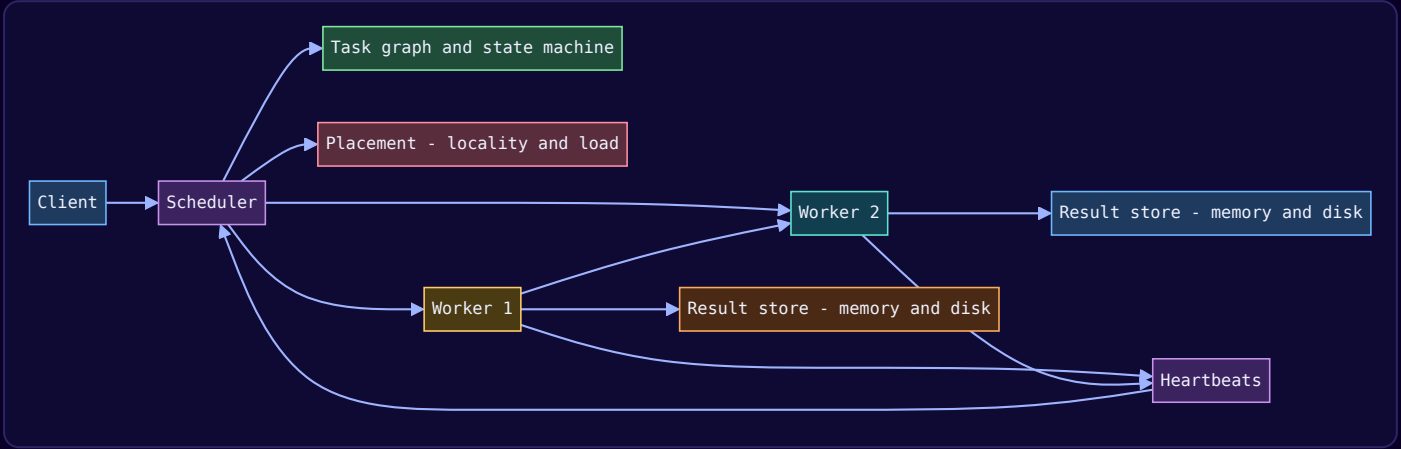
Functional

- Client API: `submit`, `map`, `gather`, futures that can be passed as arguments to other tasks (forming the DAG).
- Scheduler: tracks task states (waiting, ready, running, done, failed), assigns ready tasks to workers, retries on failure.
- Workers: connect to scheduler, execute tasks in a process pool, store results locally, serve them to other workers on request.
- Failure handling: heartbeat-based worker death detection, re-run lost tasks (including lost results needed downstream).
- Dashboard or CLI status: tasks per state, worker load.

Non-functional

- Scheduling overhead under 1 ms per task; 10,000 small tasks per minute through one scheduler.
- Worker death detected within 10 seconds and its tasks rescheduled.
- Results larger than 100 MB spilled to disk on the worker.

The architecture

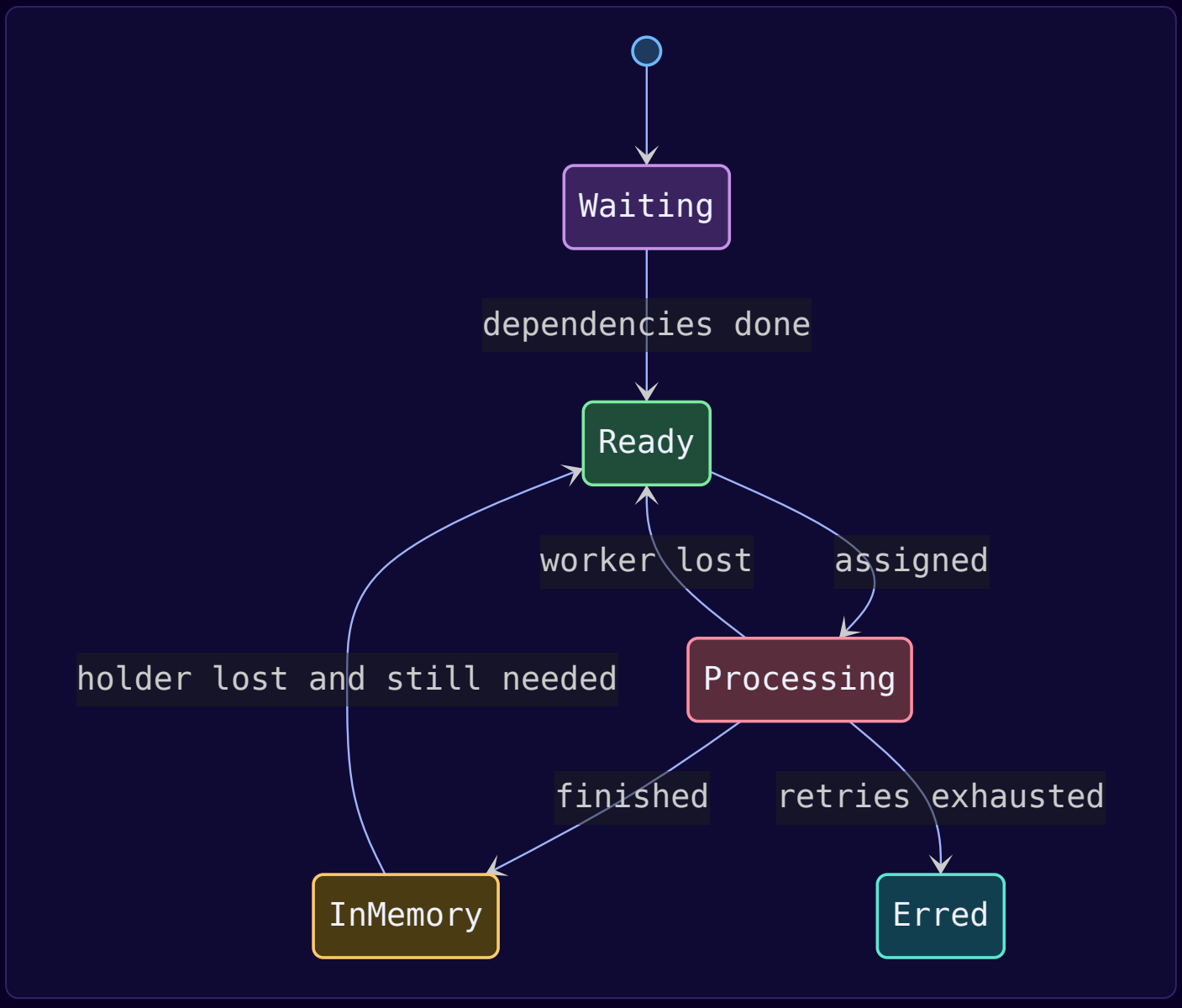


- **Client** serialises functions and arguments, submits task specs and receives completion events.
- **Scheduler** holds the graph and a state machine per task. When a task's dependencies are done it becomes ready and the placement policy picks a worker.
- **Placement** prefers the worker already holding the largest input (data locality), balanced against worker queue length.

- **Workers** run tasks in a local process pool (or threads on 3.14t), store results and fetch missing inputs directly from peer workers, not via the scheduler.
- **Heartbeats** from workers let the scheduler detect failures.

Data model

Type	Fields
`TaskSpec`	key, function (pickled reference), args with dependency keys, retries, resources
Task state	waiting, ready, processing (worker), memory (where results live), erred
`WorkerInfo`	address, nthreads, memory used, last heartbeat, tasks assigned
Message	type, payload (msgpack or pickle), request id



Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Networking	asyncio streams with length-prefixed frames	Full control, no broker
Serialisation	`pickle` (cloudpickle for lambdas) plus msgpack for control	Python objects and fast metadata
Execution	`ProcessPoolExecutor` per worker	Isolation, CPU parallelism
Spilling	files plus `compression.zstd`	Bounded memory
Monitoring	small HTTP status endpoint	Visibility

Milestones

1. **Single worker, no dependencies.** *Done when* `submit` and `gather` work over the network.
2. **DAG execution.** *Done when* a diamond-shaped graph (A → B, A → C, B and C → D) runs in the right order with results passed along.
3. **Multiple workers and locality.** *Done when* tasks run where their inputs live, measured by bytes transferred.
4. **Failure handling.** *Done when* killing a worker mid-run still completes the graph, re-running lost tasks.
5. **Spilling and throughput.** *Done when* memory stays under a limit with large results and 10,000 tiny tasks meet the throughput target.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Lineage-based recovery.** When a worker dies, both its running tasks *and* the results it held are lost. Results still needed by unfinished tasks must be recomputed, which may cascade to their inputs if those were also lost. Because the scheduler keeps the graph (the **lineage**), it can walk backwards and re-schedule exactly what is needed. This is how Dask and Ray (and Spark) recover without replicating every result.
- **Framing and serialisation safety.** TCP has no message boundaries, so prefix each message with its length. `pickle` can execute arbitrary code when loading, so only unpickle data from trusted peers: run the cluster on a private network, or add TLS and authentication. Never expose a pickle-speaking port to the internet.
- **Scheduling heuristics.** Optimal scheduling of DAGs is NP-hard, so use heuristics: run tasks in an order that frees memory early (depth-first along chains), place tasks near their largest inputs, and **work stealing** — idle workers take queued tasks from busy ones. Measure; heuristics that look smart can be slower than simple round-robin for tiny tasks.
- **Scheduler overhead.** A central scheduler that does milliseconds of work per task caps throughput at about a thousand tasks per second. Batch messages, keep state transitions O(1) with dicts and sets, and encourage users to make tasks coarse (seconds, not microseconds).

Testing strategy

In-process cluster tests (scheduler and workers as asyncio tasks in one process) for fast state-machine tests. Multi-process tests with real sockets. Fault-injection: kill workers at random points and assert the graph completes with correct results. Property tests on random DAGs comparing distributed results with local execution.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

A single scheduler is simple and consistent but a single point of failure and a throughput limit; Ray distributes scheduling to scale further. Recomputing lost results is cheap for cheap tasks but expensive for long ones — allow optional replication of precious results. Pickle ties workers to the same Python and library versions as the client; mismatches cause obscure errors, so check versions on connect.

Stretch goals

- Actors: long-lived stateful workers (a model loaded once, called many times).
- Resource tags (GPU, memory) used in placement.
- A web dashboard showing the task stream in real time.

Skills practised

- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: asyncio networking, process pools, cancellation.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: pickle, error propagation.
- Ch 17 — Performance, memory and internals: serialisation costs, memory limits.
- Ch 19 — Python for coding interviews: topological ordering of graphs.

In the interview

Q: How do you recover when a worker holding intermediate results dies? **A:** Use the task graph's lineage to recompute lost results that are still needed, re-scheduling their inputs if necessary.

Q: Why schedule tasks near their data? **A:** Moving large intermediate results over the network often costs more than the computation itself.

Q: Why is unpickling untrusted data dangerous? **A:** Pickle can construct arbitrary objects and call functions during loading, so a crafted payload can execute code.

Q: When is a distributed runner slower than a single machine? **A:** When tasks are tiny or data movement dominates — scheduling and serialisation overhead outweigh the parallel speed-up.

TL;DR

A scheduler with a task state machine, locality-aware placement, heartbeats and lineage-based recovery — the essence of Dask and Ray in a few thousand lines.

33. LSP-style linter with ast

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 3–4 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 12, Ch 13, Ch 14

What it is

A Python linter that parses code with the standard `ast` module and reports problems — unused imports and variables, mutable default arguments, `except:` without a type, shadowed built-ins, f-strings without placeholders, comparisons to `None` with `==` — with precise locations, and offers **auto-fixes** for some. It runs as a CLI and as a minimal **language server** speaking the **Language Server Protocol** (LSP, a JSON-RPC protocol editors use to talk to language tools), so diagnostics appear as you type in VS Code, Neovim or any LSP editor.

The problem it solves

Linters catch real bugs before tests run and keep codebases consistent. Writing one teaches how Python code is represented as a tree, how scopes and name binding really work, and how editors integrate tools. The LSP part teaches incremental document sync and responsive design: the editor must never freeze.

Real-world examples

- Ruff is a very fast Python linter and formatter written in Rust, implementing hundreds of rules and shipping its own language server.
- Pyflakes is a classic pure-Python linter focused on errors (unused imports, undefined names) via scope analysis over the AST — the closest model for this project.
- The Language Server Protocol specification defines messages such as `textDocument/didChange` and `textDocument/publishDiagnostics`.

Requirements

Functional

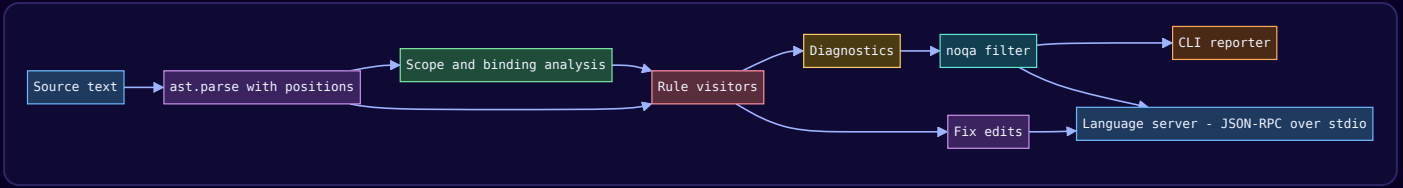
- Rules as plugins: each rule declares a code (`PY001`), message, severity and the AST node types it visits.
- Scope analysis: module, class, function, comprehension scopes, `global`/`nonlocal`, imports and `__all__`.
- Suppressions with `# noqa: PY001` comments. Configuration in `pyproject.toml` under a `[tool.minilint]` table.
- Auto-fix for safe rules (remove unused import, `== None` to `is None`), applied with `--fix` and as LSP code actions.

- Language server: initialize, didOpen, didChange, publishDiagnostics, codeAction.

Non-functional

- Lint 100,000 lines in under 10 seconds single-process, faster with a process pool.
- Diagnostics in the editor within 200 ms of the user pausing typing for a 2,000-line file.
- Never crash on syntax errors; report them as diagnostics instead.

The architecture



- **Parse** produces the AST, with `lineno`, `col_offset`, `end_lineno` and `end_col_offset` on nodes.
- **Scope analysis** walks the tree once, recording every binding (assignment, import, parameter, `def`, `class`) and every use, per scope, following Python's LEGB rules.
- **Rule visitors** subscribe to node types. A single traversal dispatches each node to the interested rules — not one traversal per rule.
- **Diagnostics** carry code, message, range and optional fix (a list of text edits).
- **Language server** reads JSON-RPC messages from stdin, keeps open documents in memory and re-lints with a debounce.

Data model

Type	Fields
`Diagnostic`	code, message, severity, start (line, col), end, fix
`Fix` / `TextEdit`	range, new_text, applicability (safe, unsafe)
`Binding`	name, kind, node, scope, used (bool)
`Scope`	kind, bindings dict, parent, uses list
`Document` (LSP)	uri, version, text, last diagnostics

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Parsing	`ast`	Exact Python grammar for the running version
Traversal	`ast.NodeVisitor` or a custom dispatcher	Familiar pattern
LSP transport	own JSON-RPC over stdio (or pygls)	Learn the protocol
Config	`tomllib` reading `pyproject.toml`	Standard place
Parallel CLI	`ProcessPoolExecutor`	Files are independent

Milestones

1. **Parse and two rules.** Bare `except` and `== None`. *Done when* diagnostics have exact ranges matching editor columns.
2. **Scope analysis.** Unused imports and variables, undefined names. *Done when* tests cover closures, comprehensions, `global`, `nonlocal`, `__all__` and `del`.
3. **Rule plugin system and config.** *Done when* rules can be enabled or disabled per project and `noqa` works.
4. **Fixes.** *Done when* `--fix` removes unused imports without breaking formatting of the rest of the line or file.
5. **Language server.** *Done when* diagnostics and quick fixes appear in a real editor while typing.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Scopes are subtle.** Class bodies do not create enclosing scopes for methods (a method cannot see class variables by bare name). Comprehensions have their own scope, though PEP 709 in 3.12 inlined them for speed while keeping the same visible behaviour. Names used before assignment in a function are local for the whole function (`UnboundLocalError`). Annotations in 3.14 are evaluated lazily, so a name used only in annotations still counts as "used" for an import. Write a test per rule of the language reference's naming and binding section.
- **Positions and encodings.** `ast` column offsets are in UTF-8 bytes; LSP positions default to UTF-16 code units. A line containing `é` or an emoji will put squiggles in the wrong place unless you convert. Negotiate the position encoding during LSP initialisation (newer clients support UTF-8) or convert carefully.
- **Fixes without destroying formatting.** Regenerating code with `ast.unparse` loses comments and formatting. Fixes must be text edits on the original source using node ranges. Removing one name from `from x import a, b, c` needs token-level care; the `tokenize` module helps locate commas.
- **Responsiveness.** Re-linting on every keystroke wastes work. Debounce (wait 150 ms of inactivity), cancel stale runs when a newer document version arrives, and run analysis off the main loop so the server can still answer requests.

Testing strategy

Fixture files with inline expectations (`x = 1 # expect: PY010`), checked by one parametrised test. Fix tests: input file, expected fixed output, and a check that the fixed output parses and has no remaining diagnostics for that rule. LSP tests driving the server over pipes with recorded JSON-RPC conversations. Run the linter over a large real codebase to find crashes.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Pure-Python AST linting is fine for most projects, but Ruff's speed comes from Rust and a single-pass architecture — know where Python's limits are. Rules without type information produce false positives (is `x.append` a list?); type-aware linting needs a type checker. False positives erode trust faster than missed bugs, so keep rules conservative.

Stretch goals

- Incremental analysis caching by file hash.
- Cross-file analysis: unused public functions in a package.
- A rule that flags f-string SQL and suggests t-strings (Project 19).

Skills practised

- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: introspection and rule registration.
- Ch 7 — Functions: LEGB scope rules in depth.
- Ch 13 — Type hints: annotations and deferred evaluation.
- Ch 14 — Standard library tour: `ast`, `tokenize`, `json`.

In the interview

Q: How does a linter know an import is unused? **A:** It records bindings and uses per scope while walking the AST. A binding from an import with no recorded use (and not exported in `__all__`) is unused.

Q: Why not fix code with `ast.unparse`? **A:** It discards comments and formatting. Fixes should be minimal text edits based on node positions.

Q: How do you keep an LSP server responsive? **A:** Debounce changes, cancel stale analysis for older document versions, and never block the message loop on heavy work.

TL;DR

Parse with `ast`, analyse scopes once, dispatch nodes to rule plugins, emit precise diagnostics and text-edit fixes, and serve them over LSP — how real linters and editors fit together.

34. A testing framework

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 3–4 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 8, Ch 12, Ch 15

What it is

A pytest-style test runner, `minitest`: it **discovers** test files and functions by naming convention, runs them, provides **fixtures** injected by parameter name (with setup/teardown and scopes), supports parametrisation, marks (skip, xfail), and shows detailed failure messages for plain `assert` statements by **rewriting assertions** at import time. It reports results in the terminal and as JUnit XML for CI, and can run tests in parallel.

The problem it solves

Every Python developer uses pytest, but few know how a bare `assert a == b` can print both values, or how fixtures know what to inject. Building a framework exercises the deepest parts of Python: import hooks, AST transformation, introspection of function signatures, generators for setup/teardown and process-level parallelism.

Real-world examples

- pytest's assertion documentation explains that it rewrites `assert` statements in test modules via an import hook to produce detailed introspection.
- The `unittest` documentation describes the standard library's xUnit-style framework: test cases, suites, loaders and runners.

Requirements

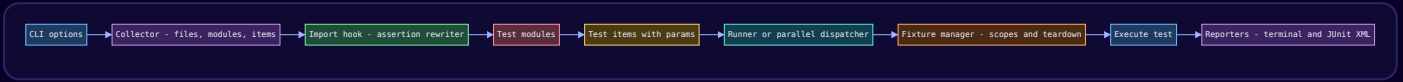
Functional

- Discovery: `test_*.py` files, `test_*` functions and `Test*` classes, configurable roots and patterns.
- Fixtures: functions decorated with `@fixture`, injected by name, with `function`, `module` and `session` scopes and `yield`-based teardown. Fixtures can depend on fixtures.
- `@parametrize("x,expected", [...])` producing one test per case with readable ids.
- Assertion rewriting for helpful messages, plus `raises()` context manager.
- Marks: skip, skipif, xfail. Output: dots, summary, failures with source context, JUnit XML. `-k` name filter and `-x` stop on first failure.
- Parallel execution with `-n 4` across processes.

Non-functional

- Framework overhead under 1 ms per trivial test.
- A failing teardown is reported but never hides the original failure.
- Test isolation: one test's failure never stops others (unless `-x`).

The architecture



- **Collector** walks directories, imports matching modules and turns each test function (and each parameter set) into a **test item**.
- **Import hook** is a `MetaPathFinder` placed on `sys.meta_path` that intercepts imports of test modules, parses the source, rewrites `assert` nodes and compiles the new AST.
- **Fixture manager** resolves a test's parameter names to fixtures, builds a dependency graph, caches results per scope and runs teardowns in reverse order.
- **Runner** executes items, catching exceptions and classifying outcomes (passed, failed, error, skipped, xfailed, xpassed).
- **Parallel dispatcher** sends item ids to worker processes that each collect the same tests and run their share.

Data model

Type	Fields
`TestItem`	node id (`path::func[param-id]`), function, params, marks
`FixtureDef`	name, function, scope, is_generator, dependencies
`FixtureCache`	per-scope dict of name to value and pending teardowns
`TestReport`	node id, outcome, duration, longrepr (formatted failure), captured output

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Import hook	`importlib.abc.MetaPathFinder`, `importlib.machinery.SourceFileLoader`	Control module compilation
Rewriting	`ast.NodeTransformer`, `compile`	Instrument asserts
Signatures	`inspect.signature`	Fixture injection by name
Teardown	generators and `contextlib.ExitStack`	Ordered, exception-safe cleanup
Parallel	`multiprocessing` or `ProcessPoolExecutor`	Isolation per worker
Output capture	`contextlib.redirect_stdout`	Show output only for failures

Milestones

1. **Discover and run.** *Done when* plain test functions run and failures show tracebacks.
2. **Fixtures with scopes.** *Done when* a session fixture is created once, function fixtures per test, and teardown order is reverse of setup.
3. **Parametrize and marks.** *Done when* ids look like `test_add[2-3-5]` and skip/xfail behave like pytest.
4. **Assertion rewriting.** *Done when* `assert f(x) == [1, 2, 3]` reports the actual value of `f(x)` and a diff.
5. **Parallel and JUnit.** *Done when* `-n 4` speeds up a slow suite and a CI system parses your XML.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Assertion rewriting.** `assert a.b == f(c)` normally raises a bare `AssertionError`. The rewriter transforms it into code that evaluates each sub-expression into a temporary variable, checks the condition, and on failure builds a message showing each intermediate value. It must preserve evaluation order and short-circuiting (`and`/`or`), must not evaluate anything twice (side effects), and must keep line numbers so tracebacks still point at the right line (`ast.copy_location`, `ast.fix_missing_locations`). Cache rewritten bytecode separately from normal `.pyc` files.
- **Fixture resolution.** Read the test's parameter names with `inspect.signature`, look up each fixture, recursively resolve its own parameters, and detect cycles. A narrower-scoped fixture cannot be used by a wider-scoped one (a session fixture depending on a function fixture is an error). Generator fixtures run up to `yield` for setup; teardown resumes them after the test — push them on an `ExitStack` per scope.
- **Robust error reporting.** Distinguish *failed* (assertion in the test) from *error* (exception in fixture setup). If teardown raises after a test failure, report both. Never let a reporter bug hide results: write results as they come.
- **Parallel collection.** Workers must collect exactly the same items in the same order as the controller, otherwise ids do not match. Send node ids, not function objects (functions do not pickle well), and have workers look them up after their own collection.

Testing strategy

Test the framework with itself once it is stable (**bootstrapping**), and with pytest before that. Fixture projects in temp folders with known outcomes, run as subprocesses, asserting on the summary line and JUnit

XML. Rewrite tests comparing messages for many assert forms. Tests for evaluation-order and side-effect preservation (a function with a counter called once).

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Import hooks are powerful but fragile: other hooks, zip imports and caching layers can interfere, so pytest only rewrites test modules and plugins by default. Parallel runs expose hidden test dependencies (shared files, global state, ordering) — a good thing, but painful. Session-scoped fixtures speed up suites but risk leaking state between tests.

Stretch goals

- Plugin hooks (`pytest_collection_modifyitems`-style) via entry points (Project 14).
- Watch mode that re-runs affected tests on save.
- Snapshot testing and coverage integration with `sys.monitoring`.

Skills practised

- Ch 8 — Modules, packages and environments: the import system and meta path finders.
- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: decorators for marks and fixtures, `ExitStack`, introspection.
- Ch 15 — Testing and debugging: fixtures, parametrisation, xUnit concepts.
- Ch 11 — Iterators, generators and functional tools: generator-based setup and teardown.

In the interview

Q: How does pytest show values in a failing bare `assert`? **A:** An import hook rewrites assert statements in test modules into code that records intermediate values and builds a detailed message.

Q: How are fixtures injected? **A:** The runner inspects the test function's parameter names and resolves each to a registered fixture, recursively, respecting scopes and caching.

Q: How is a yield fixture torn down? **A:** Setup runs until `yield`; the yielded value goes to the test; after the test the generator is resumed so code after `yield` runs, even if the test failed.

TL;DR

Discovery, signature-based fixture injection with scopes, AST assertion rewriting through an import hook and process-parallel runs — the inner workings of pytest, built by hand.

35. Plugin host on subinterpreters

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 3 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 8, Ch 16

What it is

A host application that runs untrusted-ish or crash-prone plugins (say, user-supplied data transformation scripts) in **subinterpreters** — independent Python interpreters inside the same process, each with its own modules, globals and (since 3.12) its own GIL. Python 3.14 exposes them in the standard library through the `concurrent.interpreters` module and `concurrent.futures.InterpreterPoolExecutor` (PEP 734). Each plugin gets its own interpreter; the host communicates through interpreter queues, enforces time limits and restarts misbehaving plugins.

The problem it solves

Running plugins in your process (Project 14) is fast but gives no isolation: a plugin can mutate global state, monkey-patch modules or leak memory into your app. Processes isolate fully but are heavier to start and need serialisation for every message. Subinterpreters sit in between: separate module state and true parallelism per interpreter, at lower cost than processes. The project teaches what isolation they provide and — just as importantly — what they do not.

Real-world examples

- PEP 734 describes the `concurrent.interpreters` module, its `Interpreter` objects, queues and what can be shared between interpreters.
- The `concurrent.interpreters` documentation covers creating interpreters, executing code and calling functions in them, and current limitations such as extension module compatibility.

Requirements

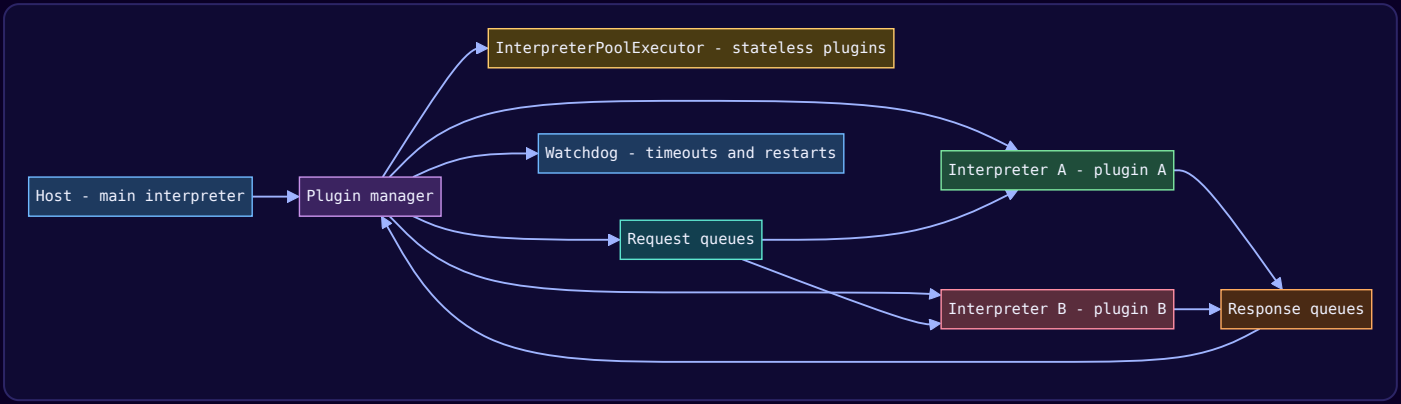
Functional

- Load each plugin (a module path) into its own interpreter. Call its `transform(record)` on batches of records.
- Communicate via interpreter queues using shareable types (bytes, str, int, tuples of these) and avoid relying on implicit pickling for anything large.
- Per-call time limit; on timeout or crash, discard and recreate the interpreter and report the failure.
- Run several plugins in parallel; a pool mode using `InterpreterPoolExecutor` for stateless plugins.
- Metrics per plugin: calls, errors, restarts, average latency.

Non-functional

- Plugin start-up under 50 ms (measure against process start-up).
- A plugin modifying `sys.path`, global variables or monkey-patching modules has no effect on the host or other plugins.
- Throughput scales with the number of interpreters for CPU-bound plugins on multi-core machines.

The architecture



- **Plugin manager** creates an interpreter per plugin (`interpreters.create()`), runs bootstrap code that imports the plugin, and starts a loop in a thread (`Interpreter.call_in_thread`) that reads requests from a queue and writes responses.
- **Queues** (`interpreters.create_queue()`) pass objects between interpreters, sharing or copying the simple types cheaply.
- **Watchdog** tracks in-flight calls and their deadlines and recycles stuck interpreters.
- **Pool** mode hands simple function calls to `InterpreterPoolExecutor`, which manages a pool of interpreters for you.

Data model

Type	Fields
`PluginSpec`	name, module path, mode (dedicated or pooled), timeout, max_restarts
`PluginHandle`	interpreter, request queue, response queue, worker thread, restarts, stats
Request	call id, method name, payload (bytes or simple tuple)
Response	call id, ok flag, payload or error text

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Interpreters	`concurrent.interpreters` (3.14)	Standard-library subinterpreters
Pooling	`concurrent.futures.InterpreterPoolExecutor` (3.14)	Executor API you already know
Messaging	interpreter queues, `json` or msgpack for complex data	Cross-interpreter safe
Threads	one host thread per dedicated interpreter	Interpreters run code on the calling thread
Comparison	`ProcessPoolExecutor`	Baseline for isolation and cost

Milestones

1. **Hello interpreter.** *Done when* code runs in a new interpreter and changes to its globals and `sys.modules` are invisible in the host.
2. **Request/response loop.** *Done when* a plugin transforms 10,000 records via queues with correct results.
3. **Parallelism.** *Done when* four CPU-bound plugins scale on four cores (measured), unlike four threads on the default build.
4. **Failure handling.** *Done when* a plugin raising, hanging or calling `sys.exit` is contained, reported and restarted.
5. **Benchmark.** *Done when* you have a table comparing start-up time, call latency and memory for interpreters vs processes.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **What is shared and what is not.** Each interpreter has its own modules, builtins and objects; Python objects cannot simply be passed by reference between them. Only certain types are shared or cheaply copied (`None`, `bool`, `int`, `float`, `str`, `bytes`, tuples of these, `memoryview` and queues themselves). Most other objects are copied with `pickle` behind the scenes, which costs time, and objects that cannot be pickled raise `NotShareableError`. Design your plugin protocol around bytes or simple tuples from day one.
- **Isolation is not a security sandbox.** Subinterpreters share the process: a plugin can still read files, open sockets, call `os._exit`, or crash the whole process through a C extension bug. They protect against accidental interference, not against malicious code. For hostile code you need OS-level isolation (separate processes with restricted permissions, containers).
- **Timeouts.** There is no way to forcibly kill code running in an interpreter the way you kill a process — `close()` only finalises an idle interpreter. A pragmatic design runs each interpreter's loop in its own host thread; on timeout the host marks the plugin dead, stops sending it work and starts a fresh interpreter. The stuck thread may linger until the code returns — document this, or fall back to processes for plugins that may loop forever.
- **Extension modules.** Many C extensions do not yet support multiple interpreters (they keep global state). Importing such a module in a subinterpreter typically fails with an `ImportError`. Check plugin dependencies early and fail with a clear message.

Testing strategy

Isolation tests: a plugin that modifies globals, `sys.path` and monkey-patches `json.dumps` must not affect the host. Fault tests for exceptions, `sys.exit`, infinite loops and huge outputs. Parallel scaling benchmarks. Comparison tests running the same plugins in a process pool to verify identical results.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Subinterpreters start faster and use less memory than processes and avoid pickling for simple types, but have stricter rules about shared data and incomplete extension support. Free-threaded threads (Project 30) share everything and are fastest for shared data but give no isolation. Processes give the strongest isolation available within Python. Pick based on trust and data-sharing needs.

Stretch goals

- Shared memory buffers via `memoryview` for large numeric batches.

- Hot reload: replace a plugin's interpreter with a new version without stopping the host.
- Resource accounting per plugin (CPU time, memory via `tracemalloc` inside the interpreter).

Skills practised

- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: subinterpreters, executors, the GIL per interpreter.
- Ch 8 — Modules, packages and environments: module state and `sys.modules`.
- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: containing and reporting failures.
- Ch 17 — Performance, memory and internals: measuring start-up cost and memory.

In the interview

Q: What is a subinterpreter? **A:** A separate Python interpreter inside the same process with its own modules and globals; since 3.12 each can have its own GIL, and 3.14 adds the `concurrent.interpreters` module to use them from Python code.

Q: Are subinterpreters a security sandbox? **A:** No. They isolate Python-level state but share the process, files and memory space. Use OS isolation for untrusted code.

Q: Subinterpreters vs processes vs free-threaded threads? **A:** Processes isolate best but cost most; subinterpreters isolate module state cheaply with parallelism; free-threaded threads share everything with the most race risk.

TL;DR

PEP 734's `concurrent.interpreters` gives each plugin its own interpreter and GIL in one process — learn the queue-based protocol, the parallelism gains and the honest limits of the isolation.

36. Log-structured key-value store

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 4 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 6, Ch 9, Ch 17

What it is

An embedded key-value database: `db.put(b"user:7", b"...")`, `db.get(...)`, `db.delete(...)`, `db.scan(start, end)`. It starts as a **Bitcask**-style store (an append-only log on disk plus an in-memory hash index pointing to each key's latest position) and grows into a small **LSM tree** (log-structured merge tree: writes go to a write-ahead log and an in-memory sorted table, which is flushed to immutable sorted files on disk and merged in the background), with crash recovery, compaction and a **bloom filter** per file.

The problem it solves

Databases are the foundation of most systems, and storage engines are a favourite topic in senior interviews. Building one reveals why sequential writes are fast, why deleted data still uses space, how crash recovery works and what "write amplification" means. Everything you learn transfers directly to understanding RocksDB, Cassandra, SQLite's WAL mode and Kafka.

Real-world examples

- The Bitcask paper from Basho describes the log-plus-hash-index design used by Riak.
- RocksDB is a widely used LSM-tree storage engine (forked from Google's LevelDB) with memtables, SSTables, compaction and bloom filters.
- SQLite's write-ahead logging page explains how a WAL gives atomic commits and concurrent readers.

Requirements

Functional

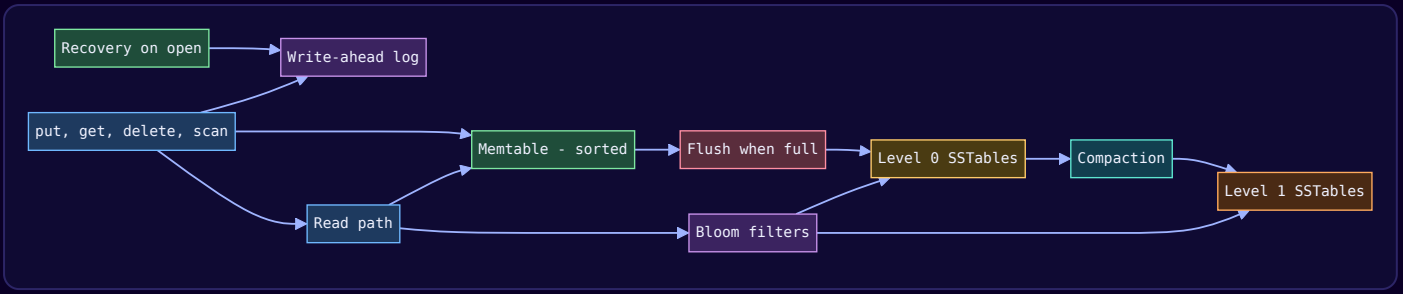
- `put`, `get`, `delete` (as a **tombstone** — a marker record meaning "deleted"), `scan` over key ranges (LSM version), batch writes applied atomically.
- Durability modes: fsync every write, every N ms, or never (for benchmarks).
- Crash recovery on open: replay the WAL, ignore a torn last record.

- Compaction: merge files, drop overwritten values and expired tombstones.
- `stats` command: number of files, live vs dead bytes, bloom filter hit rate.

Non-functional

- At least 50,000 small writes per second with batched fsync on an SSD (pure Python).
- Point reads in O(1) disk seeks for Bitcask; at most one disk read per level for LSM, most avoided by bloom filters.
- No acknowledged write lost in "fsync every write" mode after `kill -9` or power loss simulation.

The architecture



- **WAL** appends every write with a length and checksum before acknowledging it. On restart it rebuilds the memtable.
- **Memtable** is an in-memory sorted structure (a sorted list with `bisect` to start, a skip list later).
- **SSTable** (sorted string table) is an immutable file of sorted key/value records plus a sparse index and a bloom filter in a footer.
- **Read path** checks the memtable, then SSTables from newest to oldest; the first hit wins (a tombstone means "not found").
- **Compaction** merges SSTables with a k-way merge, keeping only the newest version of each key.

Data model

Structure	Layout
Log record	crc32, timestamp, key length, value length, flags (tombstone), key bytes, value bytes
Bitcask keydir	`dict[bytes, (file_id, offset, size, timestamp)]`
SSTable	data blocks of sorted records, sparse index (every Nth key and offset), bloom filter, footer
Manifest	list of live SSTables per level, written atomically

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Binary encoding	`struct`	Fixed headers
Checksums	`zlib.crc32`	Detect torn or corrupt records
Durability	`os.fsync`, `os.replace`	Real persistence and atomic manifests
Sorted memtable	`bisect` on a list, then a skip list	Simple first, faster later
Merging	`heapq.merge`	k-way merge of sorted iterators
Bloom filter	own implementation on `bytearray` and `hashlib`	Learn the maths

Milestones

1. **Bitcask.** Append-only log and keydir. *Done when* data survives restart by rebuilding the keydir from the log.

2. **Crash safety.** CRCs, torn-write handling, fsync modes. *Done when* a fault-injection test truncating the file at random byte offsets always recovers to a consistent prefix.
3. **Bitcask compaction.** *Done when* disk usage drops after many overwrites while reads stay correct.
4. **LSM.** WAL plus memtable plus SSTable flush, range scans. *Done when* scans return sorted live keys across memtable and files.
5. **Bloom filters and leveled compaction.** *Done when* reads of missing keys mostly skip disk and stats report false-positive rates near the configured target.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Torn writes and checksums.** A crash can leave the last record half-written. On recovery, read records sequentially, verify each CRC, and stop at the first bad or incomplete record, truncating the file there. Because records are only appended, everything before that point is intact.
- **Why LSM trees write fast and read slower.** Writes are sequential appends and in-memory inserts. Reads may have to look in several files. Bloom filters fix most of that for missing keys, and compaction limits the number of files. The cost moves into compaction: each value is rewritten several times as it moves down levels (**write amplification**). Every storage engine chooses a point on this triangle of write, read and space amplification.
- **Bloom filter maths.** A bloom filter with `m` bits and `k` hash functions holding `n` keys has a false-positive rate of about `(1 − e^(−kn/m))^k`. Around 10 bits per key with the best `k` (about 7) gives roughly a 1 % false-positive rate. Derive `k` hash positions from two hashes (`h1 + i × h2`) to keep it cheap.
- **Atomic file-set changes.** After compaction, readers must see either the old set of files or the new set, never a mix. Write the new SSTables, then atomically replace the manifest, then delete the old files only when no reader still uses them (reference counting).

Testing strategy

Model-based testing: random sequences of operations applied to both your store and a Python dict, comparing results — including after simulated crashes (truncate files at random points). Fuzz the decoder with corrupted bytes. Benchmarks for throughput and read latency with and without bloom filters. Long-running soak test with continuous compaction.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Bitcask needs all keys in memory, which limits it to key sets that fit in RAM but makes reads very fast. LSM trees handle huge key sets and range scans but need tuning. B-trees (used by most relational databases) read faster and write slower — a classic interview comparison. Pure Python limits absolute speed; the design lessons are what matter.

Stretch goals

- Snapshots and MVCC (multi-version concurrency control) for consistent scans during writes.
- Block compression with `compression.zstd`.
- A network server exposing the store with a Redis-like protocol (link to Project 18).

Skills practised

- Ch 9 — Errors, exceptions and files: binary I/O, fsync, atomic replace.
- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: hash index, `bisect`, `heapq.merge`.
- Ch 17 — Performance, memory and internals: memory per key, benchmarking.
- Ch 19 — Python for coding interviews: k-way merge, skip lists, bit manipulation.

In the interview

Q: Why are LSM trees good for write-heavy workloads? **A:** Writes become sequential appends to a log plus an in-memory insert; sorting and merging happen later in the background.

Q: How does a bloom filter help reads? **A:** It answers "definitely not in this file" without reading the file, so lookups for absent keys skip most disk reads. It can give false positives but never false negatives.

Q: How do you recover after a crash? **A:** Replay the write-ahead log, validating each record's checksum, and discard the incomplete tail.

Q: What is write amplification? **A:** The ratio of bytes written to disk to bytes written by the user, caused by rewriting data during compaction.

TL;DR

Append-only logs with checksums, a memtable flushed to immutable SSTables, bloom filters and compaction — the storage-engine design behind RocksDB and friends, built and crash-tested in Python.

37. Debugger on sys.monitoring

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 3–4 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 12, Ch 15, Ch 17

What it is

A command-line debugger, `pydbg`, built on the `sys.monitoring` API (PEP 669). It supports line breakpoints, conditional breakpoints, step into/over/out, inspecting and changing variables, evaluating expressions in a frame, watchpoints on variables, post-mortem debugging after an exception, and attaching to a running process using Python 3.14's safe external debugger interface (PEP 768, `sys.remote_exec`).

The problem it solves

Debuggers feel magical until you build one. Doing so teaches frames, code objects, line tables, the event model of the interpreter, and why old debuggers slowed programs down so much. It also explains what `breakpoint()`, `pdb` and IDE debuggers do — knowledge that makes you much faster at debugging real systems.

Real-world examples

- The `pdb` documentation describes the standard debugger's commands and, in 3.14, the new `-p PID` option to attach to a running process.
- debugpy is the debugger behind VS Code's Python support, implementing the Debug Adapter Protocol.
- PEP 768 specifies the safe external debugger interface and `sys.remote_exec()`. The `sys.monitoring` documentation lists events and tool ids.

Requirements

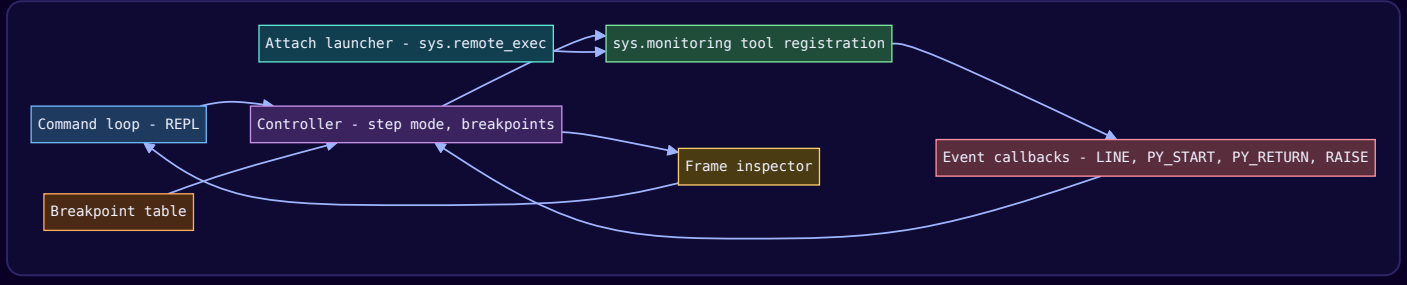
Functional

- `pydbg script.py`, `pydbg -p PID` (attach), `pydbg --post-mortem script.py`.
- Breakpoints by file and line, with optional condition and hit count. Temporary breakpoints.
- Step into, step over (next), step out (return), continue. Stack navigation (up, down, where).
- Print and set variables, evaluate expressions, display list of source around the current line.
- Watchpoints: stop when a variable's value changes.

Non-functional

- With no breakpoints in a function, near-zero overhead in that function (events disabled there).
- The debugger never alters program behaviour except where the user asks (setting variables).
- Clean detach: remove all hooks and let the program continue at full speed.

The architecture



- **Tool registration** claims a debugger tool id (`sys.monitoring.DEBUGGER_ID`) and registers callbacks.
- **Event callbacks** receive the code object and line or offset. The controller decides whether to stop.

- **Controller** implements step modes as small state machines: "step over" means stop at the next `LINE` event in the same or a parent frame.
- **Frame inspector** finds the current frame (`sys._getframe` from inside the callback) and reads `f_locals`, `f_globals`, `f_lineno`, `f_back`.
- **Attach launcher** uses `sys.remote_exec(pid, script_path)` to make the target run a small bootstrap script that starts the debugger server, which the CLI then connects to over a socket.

Data model

Type	Fields
`Breakpoint`	id, file, line, condition, hit_count, temporary, enabled
Code index	`dict[code object, set of breakpoint lines]` for fast checks
`StepState`	mode (continue, step, next, return), target frame, start depth
`Watch`	expression, frame, last value

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Events	`sys.monitoring`	Per-code-object and per-location control
Line tables	`code.co_lines()`, `dis`	Map lines to bytecode
Source	`linecache`	Display source lines
Evaluation	`eval` / `exec` in frame dicts	Inspect and modify
Attach	`sys.remote_exec` (3.14), sockets	Debug running processes

Milestones

1. **Stop on a line.** *Done when* a breakpoint pauses the program and `print x` shows the value.
2. **Stepping.** *Done when* step, next and return behave like pdb on a test program with recursion and generators.
3. **Selective events.** *Done when* overhead measured on a hot loop without breakpoints is close to zero, using `DISABLE` and per-code-object enabling.
4. **Conditions, watchpoints, post-mortem.** *Done when* each works on scripted test sessions.
5. **Attach.** *Done when* `pydbg -p PID` stops a long-running script at its next line and detaching leaves it running normally.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Cheap breakpoints.** The naive approach — check every line event against a breakpoint table — makes all code slow. With `sys.monitoring`, enable `LINE` events only for code objects that contain breakpoints (`set_local_events`), and when stepping, enable them globally only while stepping. Return `sys.monitoring.DISABLE` from a callback to turn off an event at a location you no longer care about, then call `restart_events()` when breakpoints change.
- **Stepping semantics.** "Next" must not stop inside called functions but must stop if the current function returns to its caller. Track the frame you started in and compare depths on each event. Generators and coroutines complicate this: a `yield` looks like a return, and resuming looks like a new start — handle `PY_YIELD` and `PY_RESUME` explicitly.
- **Changing locals.** Historically, writing to `frame.f_locals` of a function frame did not reliably change the real variables. PEP 667 (Python 3.13) made `frame.f_locals` a write-through proxy for function frames, so setting variables from a debugger now works consistently. Test it explicitly in your version.
- **Attach safely.** PEP 768 lets an external process ask the interpreter to run a script at a safe point (between bytecodes, when it is safe to run Python code). It needs operating-system permission to access the target process and can be disabled with an environment variable or build option. Handle permission errors with a clear message.

Testing strategy

Scripted sessions: feed a list of commands to the debugger's input and assert on the output transcript. Tests for every step mode across functions, recursion, exceptions, generators and `async def`. Overhead benchmarks. Attach tests that start a subprocess, attach, set a breakpoint and detach.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

In-process debuggers are simple but can be broken by the program they debug (monkey-patching, closed stdin). Remote debuggers over sockets need security: never listen on public interfaces without authentication. Multi-threaded programs need a policy — stop all threads or only the current one.

Stretch goals

- Implement the Debug Adapter Protocol so VS Code can drive your debugger.
- Reverse stepping for small programs by recording state at each line.
- Thread-aware breakpoints and an asyncio task view using 3.14's `asyncio.capture_call_graph`.

Skills practised

- Ch 17 — Performance, memory and internals: frames, code objects, bytecode.
- Ch 15 — Testing and debugging: pdb, post-mortem debugging.
- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: introspection.
- Ch 11 — Iterators, generators and functional tools: generator suspension and resumption.

In the interview

Q: How does a Python debugger stop on a line? **A:** It registers for line events from the interpreter; on each event it checks whether the location matches a breakpoint and, if so, enters an interactive loop with the current frame.

Q: Why is `sys.monitoring` better for debuggers than `sys.settrace`? **A:** Events can be enabled only where needed and disabled per location, so code without breakpoints runs at nearly full speed.

Q: How can you debug a process that is already running in 3.14? **A:** Use `python -m pdb -p PID`, which uses PEP 768's safe external debugger interface to inject the debugger at a safe point.

TL;DR

Selective `sys.monitoring` events, a stepping state machine, frame inspection and 3.14's remote attach — a debugger you understand down to the bytecode.

38. ASGI web framework from scratch

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 3–4 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 12, Ch 13, Ch 16

What it is

A small async web framework that speaks **ASGI** (Asynchronous Server Gateway Interface — the standard contract between async Python web servers like Uvicorn and applications). You build routing with path parameters, request and response objects, middleware, dependency injection driven by type hints, JSON validation, WebSockets, streaming responses, lifespan events and a test client — essentially a mini Starlette/FastAPI.

The problem it solves

Frameworks hide a lot: how a request becomes a function call, how middleware wraps everything, how `Depends` knows what to inject. Building one demystifies them, makes you better at debugging production web apps, and exercises decorators, type-hint introspection, async generators and protocol design all at once.

Real-world examples

- The ASGI specification defines the `scope`, `receive` and `send` interface, HTTP and WebSocket message types and lifespan events.

- Starlette is a lightweight ASGI toolkit that FastAPI builds on — a readable reference for routing, middleware and test clients.
- Uvicorn is an ASGI server you can run your framework under.

Requirements

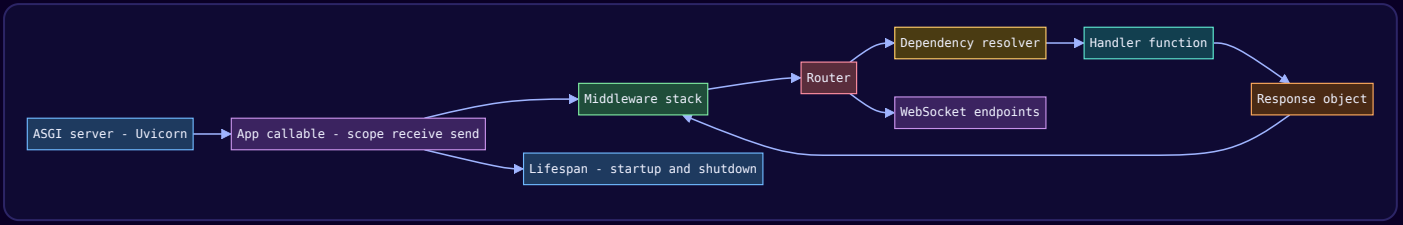
Functional

- Routing: `@app.get("/users/{id:int}")`, method matching, 404 and 405 handling, route groups.
- Request: headers, query params, body (bytes, JSON, form), streaming body. Response: JSON, HTML, streaming, files, cookies.
- Middleware: CORS, timing, error handling, GZip, as composable ASGI wrappers.
- Dependency injection from type hints and default markers (`db: Db = Depends(get_db)`), with per-request caching and cleanup via generators.
- WebSockets and lifespan startup/shutdown hooks. A test client that calls the app without a server.

Non-functional

- Routing cost independent of the number of routes for static prefixes (compiled matcher).
- At least 10,000 simple requests per second under Uvicorn on a laptop (framework overhead small vs server).
- Exceptions in handlers never leak stack traces to clients in production mode.

The architecture



- **App callable**: an ASGI app is any `async def app(scope, receive, send)`. `scope` describes the connection, `receive` gets incoming messages (body chunks), `send` emits response messages.
- **Middleware stack** is a chain of ASGI apps each wrapping the next — the same interface all the way down.
- **Router** compiles route patterns into regexes (or a tree) and converts path parameters.
- **Dependency resolver** inspects handler signatures and builds arguments, resolving nested dependencies and running generator dependencies' cleanup after the response.
- **Response objects** know how to send themselves (`await response(scope, receive, send)`).

Data model

Type	Fields
`Route`	path pattern, compiled regex, param converters, methods, endpoint, name
`Request`	scope, receive, cached body, headers (case-insensitive multidict), path params
`Response`	status, headers, body or async iterator, background tasks
`Dependant`	callable, parameters, sub-dependencies, use_cache
`Scope` (ASGI)	type, method, path, query_string, headers (list of byte pairs)

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Server	Uvicorn	Standard ASGI server
Introspection	`inspect.signature`, `annotationlib` (3.14)	Read handler hints safely
Validation	dataclasses or Pydantic	Parse JSON bodies into types
Async	asyncio, `contextlib.AsyncExitStack`	Dependency cleanup
Testing	own test client built on httpx's ASGI transport	No network in tests

Milestones

1. **Raw ASGI.** *Done when* a bare ASGI function returns "hello" under Uvicorn and you can explain each message.
2. **Router, Request, Response.** *Done when* path params, 404, 405 and JSON bodies work.
3. **Middleware.** *Done when* timing and error middleware wrap all routes and a handler exception becomes a clean 500.
4. **Dependency injection.** *Done when* nested dependencies resolve, are cached per request, and generator dependencies close after the response.
5. **WebSockets, streaming, lifespan, test client.** *Done when* a chat echo endpoint and a streaming CSV download both work, and tests run with no server.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **ASGI is message passing.** A request body may arrive in many `http.request` messages with `more_body: True`. Responses are `http.response.start` (status and headers) then one or more `http.response.body` messages. Headers are lists of byte pairs, not dicts — duplicates are legal (`Set-Cookie`). Respecting these details is what makes streaming uploads and downloads work.
- **Middleware as onion.** Each middleware receives the next app and returns a new app. To modify responses (add a header, gzip a body) it must wrap `send` with its own function that intercepts messages. Order matters: error handling must sit outside everything else to catch failures from other middleware.
- **Dependency injection with types.** For each handler parameter decide where its value comes from: path parameter if the name matches the route, a `Request` if annotated so, a dependency if the default is `Depends(...)`, otherwise query string or JSON body. Resolve dependencies recursively with per-request caching. Generator dependencies (`yield db`) are entered on an `AsyncExitStack` so cleanup runs after the response, even on errors. In 3.14, read annotations with `annotationlib` or `inspect.signature(..., annotation_format=...)` so forward references do not break start-up.
- **Never block the loop.** Sync handlers must run in a thread pool (`asyncio.to_thread` or `anyio`), otherwise one slow handler freezes the server.

Testing strategy

Test client that builds ASGI scopes and collects sent messages, so every test is in-process and fast. Tests for each ASGI message edge case (chunked bodies, duplicate headers, client disconnect). Middleware order tests. DI tests for caching and cleanup on exceptions. A load test with Uvicorn and a simple benchmark tool.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Building your own framework is a learning exercise; for production use Starlette or FastAPI, which handle many edge cases and security details. Type-driven DI is convenient but hides control flow — good error messages at start-up (unresolvable parameters) matter. Async frameworks shine for I/O-bound APIs; CPU-heavy handlers need workers or processes.

Stretch goals

- OpenAPI schema generation from routes and types.
- Server-sent events for one-way live updates.
- Run under the free-threaded build with a multi-threaded server and measure.

Skills practised

- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: coroutines, async generators, `to_thread`.
- Ch 12 — Decorators, context managers and metaprogramming: route decorators, async context managers.
- Ch 13 — Type hints: runtime annotation inspection.
- Ch 4 — Strings: regex route compilation.

In the interview

Q: What is ASGI? **A:** A standard interface between async servers and Python apps: an app is an async callable taking a connection scope plus receive and send functions for messages.

Q: How does middleware modify a response in ASGI? **A:** It wraps the inner app and passes it a wrapped `send` function that intercepts and changes outgoing messages.

Q: How does FastAPI-style dependency injection work? **A:** The framework inspects the handler's signature and type hints, resolves each parameter from the request or by calling dependency functions, caches them per request and runs cleanup afterwards.

TL;DR

Speak raw ASGI, then layer routing, onion-style middleware, type-driven dependency injection and streaming on top — and frameworks like FastAPI stop being black boxes.

39. Collaborative editor backend with CRDTs

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 4–6 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 16, Ch 19

What it is

The server side (and a minimal client) of a Google Docs-style collaborative text editor. Several users edit the same document at once, even offline, and all copies converge to the same text without conflicts. It uses a **CRDT** (conflict-free replicated data type — a data structure whose operations can be applied in any order on any replica and still reach the same state) for text, WebSockets for live sync, and an append-only operation log for persistence.

The problem it solves

Real-time collaboration is one of the hardest problems in application development: two people typing at the same position, one offline for an hour, messages arriving out of order. Naive "last write wins" loses work. CRDTs give a mathematically sound way to merge, and building one teaches ordering, causality, idempotency and the networking needed to keep many clients in sync.

Real-world examples

- crdt.tech is a community hub collecting CRDT papers, implementations and talks.
- Automerge is a CRDT library for JSON-like documents with local-first sync.
- Yjs is a widely used CRDT framework for collaborative editors, with providers for WebSocket sync and editor bindings.

Requirements

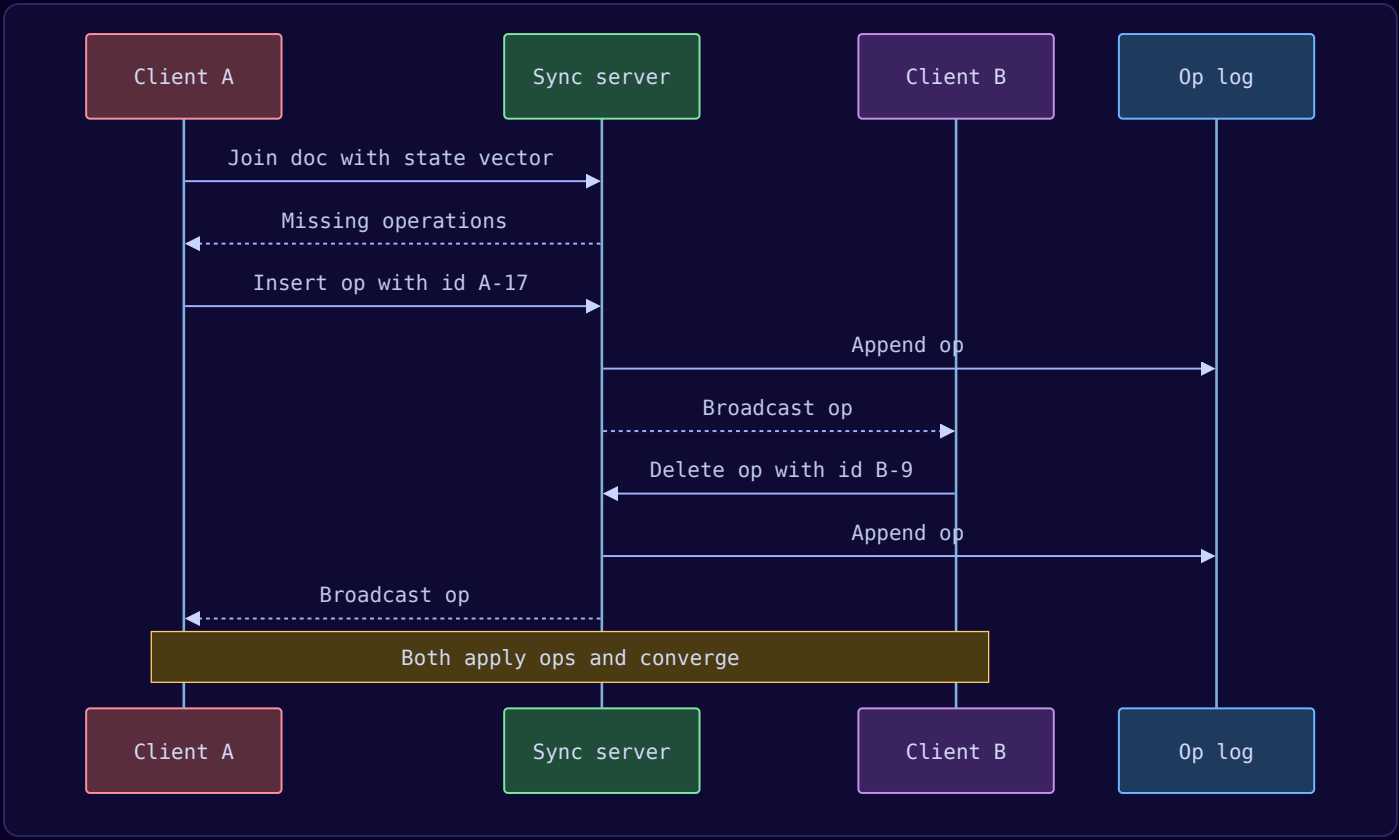
Functional

- Text CRDT supporting insert and delete at any position, with stable identifiers per character.
- WebSocket server: clients join a document, receive the current state, send operations, receive others' operations.
- Offline support: a client buffers operations and syncs on reconnect via a state-vector exchange (what have you seen?).
- Presence: show other users' cursors.
- Persistence: operation log plus periodic snapshots; load a document from snapshot plus newer operations.

Non-functional

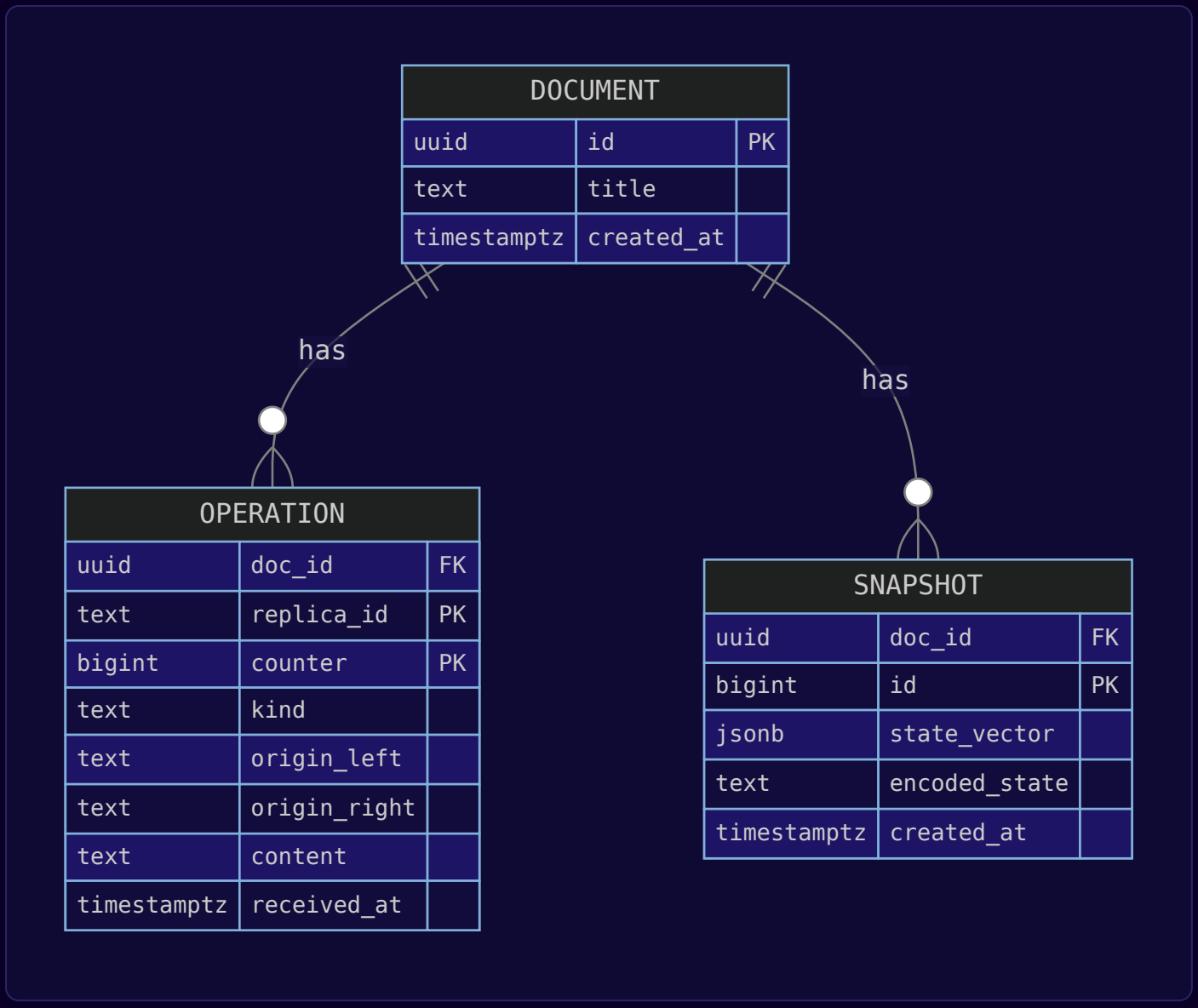
- All replicas converge after delivering all operations, regardless of order or duplication (verified by tests).
- Operation broadcast latency under 50 ms for 50 users in one document.
- A 100,000-character document with long history loads in under 1 second.

The architecture



- **Clients** apply their own operations immediately (optimistic local edits) and send them to the server.
- **Sync server** is an asyncio WebSocket server with rooms per document. It appends operations to the log, broadcasts them and answers "give me everything I have not seen" requests.
- **Op log** stores operations durably. Snapshots compact the history.
- **State vector**: for each replica id, the highest operation counter seen. Comparing vectors tells exactly which operations a client is missing.

Data model



Each character's identity is `(replica_id, counter)`. An insert records which characters were immediately left and right of it when created (the "origins").

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Transport	`websockets` on asyncio	Long-lived bidirectional connections
CRDT	your own sequence CRDT (RGA or YATA-style), compare with pycrdt (Yjs bindings)	Learn, then validate
Persistence	PostgreSQL or SQLite op log	Durable, ordered per document
Ids	`(replica_id, counter)` pairs, `uuid.uuid7()` (3.14) for documents	Unique, time-ordered
Testing	Hypothesis	Random concurrent histories

Milestones

1. **Local CRDT.** *Done when* two in-memory replicas receiving the same operations in different orders produce identical text (property test).
2. **Deletes and duplicates.** *Done when* tombstoned deletes and duplicate delivery still converge.
3. **Server sync.** *Done when* two browser or terminal clients edit live through the server.

4. **Offline and reconnect.** *Done when* a client edits offline for a while and merges cleanly on reconnect via state vectors.
5. **Persistence and snapshots.** *Done when* restart restores documents and load time meets the target with long histories.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Why positions do not work.** "Insert 'x' at index 5" means different things on two replicas that have both changed the text. Sequence CRDTs give every character a unique, immutable id and describe inserts relative to neighbours ("after character A-12"). Ties — two inserts after the same character — are broken by a deterministic rule (for example comparing replica ids), so every replica orders them the same way.
- **Deletes as tombstones.** Removing a character entirely would break inserts that reference it. Instead mark it deleted and keep it in the structure (a **tombstone**). This makes merges correct but grows memory — snapshots can garbage-collect tombstones once every replica has seen the delete, which requires knowing what everyone has seen.
- **Causality and delivery.** An operation may reference a character a replica has not received yet (an insert after a character created by a third user). Buffer such operations until their dependencies arrive. State vectors make catch-up efficient: a reconnecting client sends its vector, the server replies with exactly the missing operations.
- **Interleaving anomalies.** Some simple sequence CRDTs interleave characters when two users type words at the same spot concurrently ("hweolrlod"). Designs like YATA (used by Yjs) and recent research avoid this; test for it explicitly with concurrent multi-character inserts.

Testing strategy

Property-based convergence tests: generate random edit sessions on N replicas, deliver operations in random orders with duplicates and delays, and assert all replicas end with identical text. Server tests with multiple WebSocket clients. Reconnection tests. Performance tests with large documents and long histories.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

CRDTs converge without a central authority and work offline, but carry metadata overhead per character and need tombstone management. **Operational transformation** (OT), used by classic Google Docs, transforms operations against each other through a central server — less metadata, more complex correctness reasoning. A single server per document scales well; across servers, route each document to one owner or use pub/sub. Rich text, undo and permissions add significant complexity.

Stretch goals

- Rich-text formatting marks.
- Undo/redo per user that does not undo other users' changes.
- Interoperate with Yjs clients through pycrdt.

Skills practised

- Ch 16 — Concurrency and async: WebSocket servers, broadcast, backpressure.
- Ch 19 — Python for coding interviews: linked structures, ordering and graph reasoning.
- Ch 15 — Testing and debugging: Hypothesis property tests.
- Ch 6 — Dicts, sets and collections: indexes by id, state vectors as dicts.

In the interview

Q: What is a CRDT? **A:** A replicated data type whose operations commute (or whose states merge associatively, commutatively and idempotently), so replicas that receive the same updates in any order reach the same state.

Q: Why do CRDT text editors give each character an id? **A:** Indices shift under concurrent edits; ids are stable, so operations can refer to neighbours unambiguously on every replica.

Q: CRDT or OT? **A:** CRDTs suit offline and peer-to-peer sync with no central ordering; OT needs a server to order operations but has less per-character metadata.

Q: What is a state vector used for? **A:** It summarises which operations a replica has seen, so sync sends exactly the missing ones.

TL;DR

Characters with stable ids, relative inserts, tombstones, causal buffering and state-vector sync over WebSockets give you a collaborative editor that converges no matter how messages arrive.

40. Vector similarity search engine

Level: Advanced · **Time:** 4 weeks · **Prerequisites:** Ch 17, Ch 18, Ch 19

What it is

A search engine for **embeddings** — lists of numbers (vectors) that represent the meaning of text, images or products, produced by machine-learning models, where similar items have vectors pointing in similar directions. Given a query vector, it returns the k most similar stored vectors. You build exact search with numpy, then an approximate index (**HNSW**, hierarchical navigable small world graphs) that answers in milliseconds over a million vectors, plus metadata filters, persistence and an HTTP API.

The problem it solves

Semantic search, recommendations, duplicate detection and retrieval-augmented generation (RAG — giving a language model relevant documents) all need nearest-neighbour search over high-dimensional vectors. Exact search compares the query with every vector, which is too slow at scale. Approximate methods trade a little accuracy (**recall**) for huge speed-ups. Building one teaches vectorised numpy, graph algorithms, heaps and how to measure quality versus speed.

Real-world examples

- The HNSW paper, Efficient and robust approximate nearest neighbor search using Hierarchical Navigable Small World graphs by Malkov and Yashunin, defines the algorithm you will implement.
- FAISS from Meta is a library for efficient similarity search with many index types (flat, IVF, HNSW, product quantisation).
- hnswlib is a compact header-only C++ HNSW implementation with Python bindings — a good speed and recall baseline.

Requirements

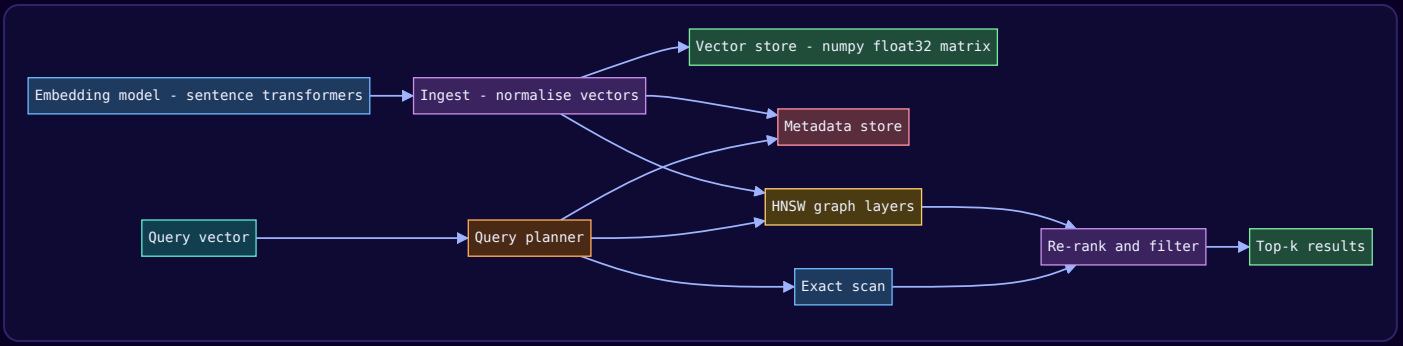
Functional

- Add vectors with ids and metadata. Delete by id (soft delete). Query top-k by cosine similarity or Euclidean distance.
- Exact (brute-force) index and HNSW index behind the same interface.
- Metadata filters (`category == "books"`) combined with vector search.
- Persistence: save and load the index. HTTP API for add and query.
- Evaluation tool: recall@k versus exact search, latency percentiles, build time, memory.

Non-functional

- Exact search over 100,000 vectors of 384 dimensions in under 50 ms with numpy.
- HNSW: recall@10 of at least 0.95 with p95 latency under 10 ms on 1 million vectors (pure-Python graph search with numpy distance batches; document what you achieve).
- Memory reported per vector, including graph links.

The architecture



- **Vector store** keeps vectors in one contiguous `float32` numpy matrix, normalised to length 1 so cosine similarity becomes a dot product.
- **HNSW graph** stores, for each vector and each layer, a list of neighbour ids. Upper layers are sparse "highways", layer 0 contains everything.
- **Query planner** chooses exact scan for small or heavily filtered candidate sets and HNSW otherwise.
- **Re-rank and filter** computes exact distances for candidates and applies metadata filters.

Data model

Structure	Shape
Vectors	`np.ndarray` of shape (n, d), `float32`
Ids	array mapping row to external id, dict for reverse lookup
Graph	per layer: list or array of neighbour id arrays, max M per node (2M on layer 0)
Node levels	array of top layer per node, entry point id
Metadata	dict or columnar arrays per field, deleted flags

Tech stack

Component	Choice	Why
Maths	numpy	Vectorised dot products, `argpartition` for top-k
Embeddings	sentence-transformers (any small model)	Realistic test data
Heaps	`heapq`	Candidate and result sets during search
Persistence	`np.save` plus JSON metadata	Simple, fast
API	FastAPI	Quick HTTP layer
Baselines	FAISS, hnswlib	Validate recall and speed

Milestones

1. **Exact search.** *Done when* top-k results match a naive Python loop and 100,000 vectors meet the latency target using matrix multiplication and `argpartition`.
2. **Evaluation harness.** *Done when* you can compute recall@k and latency percentiles for any index against exact search.
3. **HNSW build and search.** *Done when* recall@10 exceeds 0.9 on 100,000 vectors with tunable `M`, `ef_construction` and `ef_search`.
4. **Filters and deletes.** *Done when* filtered queries return only matching items with acceptable recall, and deleted items never appear.
5. **Scale and persistence.** *Done when* 1 million vectors build, save, load and meet documented recall and latency numbers, compared with hnswlib.

Deep dive: the hard parts

- **Vectorise exact search.** A Python loop over 100,000 vectors is far too slow. Store normalised vectors as one matrix, compute all similarities with one `matrix @ query`, then take the top k with `np.argpartition` (O(n)) followed by sorting only those k. This is often fast enough up to hundreds of thousands of vectors and is your ground truth.
- **How HNSW searches.** Each node gets a random top level (exponentially fewer nodes on higher layers). A search starts at the entry point on the top layer, greedily moves to the neighbour closest to the query until no improvement, then drops a layer and repeats. On layer 0 it runs a **best-first search** with a candidate heap of size `ef_search`, returning the best k. Larger `ef_search` means higher recall and slower queries — the key tuning knob.
- **Neighbour selection.** When inserting, connecting a node to its M nearest neighbours tends to create clusters with poor connectivity between them. The paper's heuristic keeps a candidate only if it is closer to the new node than to any already-selected neighbour, which preserves "long" links that help navigation. Implement both and measure recall.
- **Filtering.** Applying a metadata filter after HNSW search may leave fewer than k results when the filter is selective. Options: increase `ef_search` adaptively, filter during graph traversal (skip non-matching results but still traverse through them), or fall back to exact scan over the filtered subset when it is small. A planner choosing by estimated selectivity is what production systems do.

Testing strategy

Ground-truth tests with exact search. Recall regression tests on fixed random datasets (seeded). Property tests: results are sorted by similarity, never include deleted ids, always satisfy filters. Benchmarks for build time, query latency and memory at several sizes, compared with hnswlib.

Trade-offs, scaling and failure modes

Exact search is simple and perfectly accurate but linear in data size. HNSW gives excellent recall and speed but uses a lot of memory for graph links and is slow to build; IVF and product quantisation (in FAISS) trade more accuracy for less memory. Embedding models change: vectors from different models are not comparable, so store the model name and version with the index and rebuild when it changes. Pure Python graph traversal is much slower than C++ — the goal is understanding; production uses FAISS, hnswlib or a vector database.

Stretch goals

- Hybrid search combining BM25 from Project 23 with vector similarity.
- Product quantisation to compress vectors 8–32 times.
- Run graph search across threads on the free-threaded build and measure scaling.

Skills practised

- Ch 18 — The data stack: numpy arrays, broadcasting, vectorisation.
- Ch 19 — Python for coding interviews: heaps, graph search, top-k.
- Ch 17 — Performance, memory and internals: profiling, memory layout.
- Ch 13 — Type hints: a typed index interface for exact and approximate backends.

In the interview

Q: How would you find the 10 most similar vectors among 100,000 quickly in Python? **A:** Normalise vectors, compute all similarities with one matrix multiplication in numpy, and use `argpartition` to get the top 10 without fully sorting.

Q: What does HNSW trade away? **A:** Exactness and memory: it may miss some true neighbours (recall below 1) and stores a graph, in exchange for logarithmic-like query time.

Q: What is recall@k? **A:** The fraction of the true k nearest neighbours that the approximate search returned.

Q: How do metadata filters interact with ANN search? **A:** Selective filters can starve post-filtered results, so you raise `ef`, filter during traversal or switch to exact search over the filtered subset.

TL;DR

Start with vectorised exact search as ground truth, then build and tune HNSW, measure recall against latency honestly, and add filtering — the core of every vector database.